

99 RECIPES UNDER 💎💎💎99

Quick, Cheap and Ridiculously Easy Meals for Students Who Are Broke, Busy
and Hungry

Contents

Copyright Notice	4
Disclaimer	5
Welcome	6
How This Book Works	8
The Keep-It-Simple Kitchen Rules	9
Cheap Starter Pantry List	10
Basic Equipment Guide	12
How to Think About the ₹99 Budget	14
Ultra-Quick 5-10 Minute Meals	15
Breakfast & Morning Meals	45
Maggi/Noodles Reinvented	75
Rice & One-Pot Meals	96
Roti/Bread-Based Meals	126
Egg-Based Meals	146
Vegetarian Comfort Food	167
Budget Snacks & Late-Night Hunger	183
Sweet/Cheap Comfort Recipes	200
Emergency “Almost Nothing Left” Meals	210
10 Meals for the Last Week of the Month	216
10 Recipes for When You’re Too Tired to Cook	217
10 Filling Meals Under ₹30	218
10 Midnight Hunger Fixes	219
5 Recipes for When You Miss Home	220
Weekly Food Planner	221
Weekly Budget Planning Examples	222

Recipe Indexes	225
Final Quality-Control Summary	230

Copyright Notice

Copyright © 2026. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations used in reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

Disclaimer

This book is general cooking guidance, not personalized nutrition or medical advice. Ingredient prices are illustrative estimates based on reasonable Indian retail assumptions at the time of writing — actual prices vary by city, store, brand, package size, and season, so treat every cost in this book as a rough guide, not a guarantee.

Always consider your own allergies, dietary restrictions, and food sensitivities before trying a recipe. Follow basic food-safety practices (covered in this book) — cook eggs and other perishables thoroughly, store leftovers properly, and use your judgement about anything that smells or looks off. Equipment and ingredient availability will vary depending on where you live and what you have access to; treat every recipe as a starting point you can adapt, not a rigid rulebook.

Welcome



You know the feeling. Class ran long, or the assignment ate your whole evening, or you just spent forty-five minutes staring at a group chat trying to decide whose turn it is to order food — and somewhere in the middle of all that, your stomach has started sending increasingly urgent messages that you’ve been ignoring.

You open your food delivery app. You look at the total with delivery fee and “platform fee” and a tip you feel guilty not adding. You close the app. You open your wallet instead. It looks the way it always looks around this time — thinner than you’d like, with a few days left before anything useful happens to it again.

So you stand in front of whatever you’ve got. Maybe a half loaf of bread. An egg or two. Some rice from three days ago. A packet of noodles you bought “for emergencies” and have now bought four more times because every day has quietly become an emergency. And the question that’s actually running through your head isn’t “what

should I cook” — it’s simpler and more tired than that: **what can I make right now, with what I have, without spending money I don’t have?**

This book is the answer to that exact question, asked on a loop, for as many nights as it takes.

It is not going to teach you to become a chef. It’s not going to hand you a recipe that needs six spices you’ve never heard of and a piece of equipment you’ll use once. It’s not going to pretend that what you make is going to taste like your mother’s cooking, because it won’t, and promising that would just make you miss home more.

What it will do is give you 99 real, workable, cheap ways to feed yourself — built around a small budget, basic equipment, low energy, and the kind of hunger that doesn’t care how tired you are. Some nights you’ll want something quick between classes. Some nights you’ll want something that reminds you of home, even a little. Some nights you’ll genuinely have almost nothing left in the room and need three ingredients to become dinner. There’s a recipe in here for all of those nights.

You don’t need to be good at this. You just need to be hungry and a little bit willing. That’s already enough.

How This Book Works

Every recipe in this book follows the same simple layout, so you can scan it in ten seconds and know exactly what you're getting into. Here's what each part means:

The one-line description tells you the mood of the recipe — when you'd actually want to make this.

TIME is the realistic time from starting to eating, including any waiting (like boiling water), not just active cooking.

COST is the estimated total ingredient cost for the recipe, based on the portion of each ingredient actually used — not the price of the whole packet you bought. More on this in a moment, because it matters.

SERVES tells you how many people one batch feeds. Most recipes here are written for one hungry person, because most nights, that's who's cooking.

EQUIPMENT tells you exactly what you need — a pan, a kettle, a microwave, or sometimes nothing at all beyond a bowl and a spoon. If a recipe needs something specific, it's stated upfront so you're never halfway through before realising you can't finish it.

LEVEL is either Beginner or Easy. Nothing in this book requires real cooking skill — Easy just means slightly more steps or slightly more attention than Beginner.

Then you get **Why You'll Love It** (the quick pitch), **Ingredients** (exact, small, practical quantities), **Method** (numbered, clear, no assumed knowledge), a **Money Hack** (a tip to save more or stretch the ingredients further), sometimes a **Swap It** (what to use if you're missing something), a **Cost Breakdown** (so you can see exactly where the total comes from), and often a short closing line — just something supportive to send you off to eat.

A quick word on cost estimates

Here's the logic behind every price in this book: if a ₹40 packet of something gives you ten portions, and a recipe uses one portion, that recipe is costed at roughly ₹4 for that ingredient — not ₹40. You already own the rest of the packet for next time. Every cost breakdown in this book is calculated this way, using the actual amount used, not the shelf price of the whole item. Prices are based on reasonable, everyday Indian retail estimates and are meant as a planning guide, not an exact receipt — your city, your shop, and your luck on any given day will move these numbers a little in either direction.

The Keep-It-Simple Kitchen Rules

This book assumes you do not have a full kitchen. Maybe you’ve got one induction plate. Maybe just a kettle and a microwave. Maybe a rice cooker that’s quietly become the most useful appliance you own. That’s the entire design principle here — every recipe is built around minimal equipment, and every recipe tells you upfront exactly what it needs.

A few ground rules that apply throughout the book:

1. **“Equipment” always means the minimum required.** If a recipe says “kettle only,” you genuinely don’t need anything else to cook it.
2. **One pan or one pot, wherever possible.** Fewer things to wash is a feature, not an accident.
3. **No recipe assumes an oven.** A few mention an oven as an optional upgrade, but it’s never required.
4. **If you only have one piece of equipment, this book still works for you.** The equipment guide coming up shows you how to adapt.
5. **“Difficulty: Beginner” means exactly that.** If you’ve never cooked anything in your life before this book, you can still do this.

You are not being tested on technique here. You’re just trying to eat something warm and filling without spending money you don’t have. Keep that in mind, and the rest gets a lot easier.

Kettle Only

Instant noodles, oats, quick soups, tea-based comfort drinks

Microwave

Rice bowls, egg mugs, reheating, quick steaming

One Pan

Omelettes, bhurji, sandwiches, sautéed vegetables

Cheap Starter Pantry List



You don't need to buy everything on this list today. Build it up over your first couple of weeks, and you'll always have the bones of a meal within reach.

MUST-HAVE — buy these first, they show up constantly

- Atta (wheat flour) or bread
- Rice
- Eggs
- Onions, tomatoes, potatoes
- Cooking oil
- Salt, turmeric, red chilli powder, cumin seeds
- Tea leaves or tea bags
- A packet of instant noodles or two

NICE-TO-HAVE — cheap, useful, worth adding soon

- Curd (yoghurt)
- Peanuts or peanut butter
- Oats
- A small bag of dal (moong or toor)
- Bread jam or chutney
- Green chillies, garlic, ginger
- Coriander leaves (small bunch, use within a few days)
- Sugar or jaggery

BUY ONLY WHEN NEEDED — for specific recipes, not everyday use

- Paneer (buys well in small 100-200g packs, doesn't keep long once opened)
- Bananas or other seasonal fruit
- Cheese slices (optional, a small splurge)
- Milk, if you don't already keep some for tea

A rough shelf-life note: dry pantry items (atta, rice, dal, oats, spices) last weeks to months if kept sealed and dry. Fresh items — curd, milk, coriander, tomatoes — are best used within a few days. Eggs generally keep well for one to two weeks if stored cool. This is a general guide, not a food-safety guarantee — always use your own judgement, and check packaging for anything with a printed date.

Basic Equipment Guide



Here's what “equipment” means throughout this book, and roughly what each one is good for.

- **Induction plate / gas burner** — your main heat source for anything that needs real cooking (frying, boiling, sautéing).
- **Kettle** — for boiling water fast. Useful for noodles, tea, oats, and quick soups even without a stove.
- **Microwave** — for reheating, quick steaming, and mug-style meals that cook in a few minutes.
- **Rice cooker** — not just for rice; many one-pot meals in this book can go straight into a rice cooker.
- **Frying pan** — the single most useful pan for this book. Omelettes, sautés, toasted sandwiches, all live here.

- **Saucepan or pot** — for boiling rice, noodles, or making anything with a bit of liquid, like dal.
- **A knife and a cutting board (or a plate)** — you don't need anything fancy, just something that cuts an onion without a fight.
- **A bowl, a spoon, a mug** — more essential than they sound. Several recipes are built entirely around a bowl or a mug.
- **A storage container or two** — for leftovers, and for keeping pantry basics away from insects and moisture.

If you only have one piece of equipment...

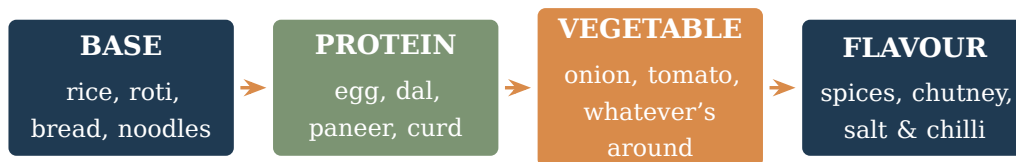
- **Only a kettle?** You can still make instant noodles, oats, quick soups, and hot drinks. Look for the “Kettle Only” equipment tag.
- **Only a microwave?** Mug meals, reheated rice bowls, and a handful of egg dishes are fully microwave-friendly.
- **Only a rice cooker?** You can cook rice, many one-pot meals, and even a basic omelette in most rice cookers on the “cook” setting.
- **Only a frying pan and a burner?** You've got the most flexible setup in the book — the majority of recipes work with just this.

How to Think About the ₹99 Budget

₹99 isn't a rule carved in stone — it's a target. Most recipes in this book land comfortably under it; a few sit right at the edge depending on what things cost where you live. The point isn't the exact number. The point is the habit: before you cook, you have a rough sense of what it's going to cost you, so there are no surprises and no guilt.

The ₹99 Emergency Meal Formula

Most cheap, filling meals — in this book and in general — come down to four simple building blocks:



Pick one from each column, and you almost always land on something edible, filling, and cheap — even without a recipe in front of you. This isn't a rigid rule (plenty of great recipes in this book skip a column entirely), but when you've genuinely got nothing planned and need to improvise, this formula will get you there.

A few habits that make ₹99 go further:

- **Buy in small batches, not single-use packs.** A 1kg bag of rice costs less per portion than five tiny packs bought over a month.
- **Reuse ingredients across recipes.** Onions, eggs, and bread show up in dozens of recipes in this book — buying them isn't a one-recipe expense.
- **Cook once, eat twice where it's safe to do so.** A bit of extra rice or dal, stored properly, becomes tomorrow's lunch.
- **Compare cost per portion, not price per packet.** A bigger pack is usually cheaper per use, even if it looks more expensive at the till.
- **Keep two or three emergency-only ingredients on hand** — instant noodles, an egg, a packet of oats — for the nights you have zero energy and zero plan.
- **Skip delivery fees whenever you can.** A ₹99 meal you cook yourself often costs less than the delivery fee alone on an app order.

None of this requires spreadsheets or discipline you don't have. It's just a slightly different way of looking at the same shopping list.

Ultra-Quick 5-10 Minute Meals

These are the recipes for when you have exactly one thing in stock: no patience. Nothing here takes more than ten minutes, start to finish. And because some of you reading this have genuinely never cooked anything before, every step below is broken down as small as it needs to be — exactly what to do, how long to wait, and what to look for, one action at a time. Read the whole recipe once before you start, then just follow it step by step. You won't get stuck.

1. Bread Omelette Roll-Up

For the ten minutes between “I should eat” and “class starts.”



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

This is an omelette and toast that decided to become one food instead of two separate things on a plate. You get the protein and richness of egg, the familiar comfort of bread, and a bit of crunch at the edges, all rolled into something you can genuinely

eat with one hand while walking to class. It's also forgiving: even if your first attempt looks a bit messy, it still tastes exactly right.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- 2 slices bread
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- Salt and pepper to taste
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Take a bowl. Crack one egg on the edge of the bowl — tap it firmly once, you'll see a crack line appear — then use both thumbs to pull the shell open and let the egg fall into the bowl. Do the same with the second egg.
2. Pick up a fork. Beat the eggs for about 20 seconds, moving the fork in fast circles. Stop when the egg looks like one smooth, even yellow colour — no separate white streaks left.
3. Add the chopped onion, a small pinch of salt, and a small pinch of pepper into the same bowl. Stir it 4-5 times with the fork, just to mix it in. Set the bowl aside.
4. Now put your pan on the stove. Turn the flame to medium — not high, not low, right in the middle.
5. Pour 1 teaspoon of oil into the pan. Wait about 30 seconds. You'll see the oil start to look thinner and move slightly when you tilt the pan — that means it's hot enough now.
6. Pour the egg mixture into the pan all at once. As soon as it hits the pan, pick up the pan handle and tilt it gently in a circle for 2-3 seconds so the egg spreads out into one flat, even layer, like a thin sheet.
7. Put the pan back down. Do not touch it now. Let it sit undisturbed for 1 full minute.
8. After 1 minute, look at the top of the egg. It should still look a little wet and shiny in the middle — that's normal, that's what you want. Now take your 2 bread slices and lay them flat on top of the egg, side by side, gently pressing down with your fingers for a second so they stick to the egg.
9. Let this cook for 1 more minute without touching it. You'll know it's ready for the next step when you lift one corner of the egg gently with a spatula and see the underside has turned light golden — not brown, just golden.
10. Now slide your spatula all the way underneath the whole thing, egg and bread together. In one confident motion, flip it over, so the bread is now facing down into the pan and the egg is on top.
11. Let it cook for 30 more seconds. This just lightly toasts the bread side.
12. Turn off the stove. Use your spatula to slide the whole thing out onto a plate.

While it's still warm, roll it up from one end to the other, like a wrap. It's ready to eat right now.

Money Hack: Buy eggs by the tray (30) instead of loose — it works out noticeably cheaper per egg over a month.

Swap It: No onion? Skip it, or use a pinch of any dried herb you have.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Bread — ₹4, Onion — ₹1, Oil/salt — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹20.

Eat it walking if you have to. Nobody's judging.

2. Peanut Butter Banana Toast

Sweet, filling, and ready before your kettle even finishes boiling water for tea.



TIME: 4 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed

LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Bread, peanut butter, and banana is one of those combinations that just works — the peanut butter is thick and a little sticky, the banana is soft and cool, and the bread underneath holds it all together. This is the recipe for a morning when you genuinely have zero minutes to spare but still want something that feels like a real breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices bread
- 1.5 tbsp peanut butter
- 1 small banana, sliced
- Pinch of salt (optional, makes the sweetness pop)

METHOD

1. If you have a toaster, put both bread slices in now and toast them. If you don't have a toaster, this step is optional — you can skip straight to step 2 with plain bread and it still works fine.
2. Lay both bread slices flat on a plate.
3. Open your peanut butter jar. Using a butter knife or spoon, scoop out about $\frac{3}{4}$ tablespoon and spread it on the first slice — press and spread from the centre outward until it covers the whole slice, right to the corners. Do the same on the second slice.
4. Take the banana. Peel it by pinching the top and pulling the skin down in strips. Lay the peeled banana on a cutting board or plate.
5. Using a knife, cut the banana into round slices, about as thick as your little finger — roughly half a centimetre each. You should get around 10–12 slices from one banana.
6. Lay the banana slices evenly across one piece of the peanut-butter-covered bread, covering it edge to edge.
7. If using salt, take a tiny pinch between two fingers and sprinkle it lightly over the banana slices — just a light dusting, not a lot.
8. Place the second slice of bread on top, peanut-butter-side facing down, to close it into a sandwich. Press down very gently with your palm. Cut in half if you like, and eat.

Money Hack: Buy the biggest peanut butter jar you can afford in one go — it's always cheaper per spoon than a small jar, and it doesn't spoil quickly.

Swap It: No banana? Try it with a drizzle of honey or jam instead.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹4, Peanut butter — ₹8, Banana — ₹6. Estimated total — ₹18.

This one's basically dessert pretending to be breakfast.

3. Curd Rice in a Bowl

The oldest comfort food trick in the book: leftover rice, curd, and five minutes.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹15 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Curd rice works precisely because it asks nothing of you — no heat, no real technique. It's cooling rather than heavy, which makes it the specific thing your body wants after a spicy dinner, a long day, or an evening your stomach feels unsettled.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup cooked rice (leftover is perfect)
- ½ cup curd

- Salt to taste
- A few curry leaves or a pinch of mustard seeds, tempered in oil (optional)
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Take your leftover rice and put it in a bowl. If it's been in the fridge and feels cold and hard, that's fine — we'll fix that in the next step.
2. Using the back of a spoon, press down on the rice and mash it gently — not into a paste, just enough to break up the big clumps so you're left with smaller, separate-ish grains. This takes about 15–20 presses.
3. Add the curd on top of the rice. Add a small pinch of salt.
4. Mix everything together with the spoon, stirring in circles, until the curd and rice are fully combined and you don't see any dry white rice left uncoated. This takes about 30 seconds of stirring.
5. Look at the texture. If it feels too thick to easily eat with a spoon, add a small splash of water or milk — about 2 tablespoons — and stir again. Repeat if it's still too thick.
6. This step is optional but recommended: heat a tiny pan on medium heat, add ½ teaspoon of oil, wait 20 seconds until it looks hot, then add a pinch of mustard seeds. Wait until you hear them start popping — like tiny crackling sounds, this takes about 10–15 seconds. Add the curry leaves right after (they will sizzle loudly, don't worry, that's normal), let them cook for 10 seconds, then turn off the heat and pour this entire mixture, oil and all, over your curd rice.
7. Sprinkle chopped coriander on top if you have it. Let the bowl sit for 2 minutes before eating — curd rice tastes better slightly less cold than straight from the fridge.

Money Hack: Always cook a little extra rice at dinner — even half a cup extra means curd rice is ready in five minutes tomorrow.

Swap It: No curd? Plain yoghurt works exactly the same way.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice (leftover) — ₹4, Curd — ₹10, Tempering (optional) — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹15.

Cooling, simple, and exactly what a tired stomach wants.

4. Loaded Masala Maggi

The 2-minute noodles you already know, but with actual vegetables and actual flavour.



TIME: 7 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Everyone already knows how to make Maggi, which is exactly the problem — it's so automatic that it rarely gets treated as a real meal. Adding an egg and whatever vegetables happen to be sitting in your fridge changes the entire eating experience.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles (with tastemaker)
- 1 egg
- ¼ onion, sliced
- ¼ tomato, chopped
- A few pieces of any vegetable you have (capsicum, carrot, peas)
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Put a pan on the stove. Pour in 1.5 cups of water — if you don't have a measuring

- cup, use a normal drinking glass, that's roughly 1.5 glasses.
2. Turn the flame to high. Let the water heat up until you see big, rolling bubbles across the whole surface — this usually takes 3–4 minutes. That's a proper boil, which is what you need.
 3. Add the sliced onion and any hard vegetables (carrot, capsicum) into the boiling water. Let them cook for 1 minute — just stand near the stove, no need to do anything else.
 4. Break the Maggi noodle block in half with your hands if you want shorter noodles (optional). Drop the noodles into the boiling water, then sprinkle in the full tastemaker packet, and add the chopped tomato too.
 5. Set a timer for 2 minutes. Stir the noodles gently with a fork or spoon every 20–30 seconds so they don't stick together in one clump at the bottom.
 6. When the timer goes off, push all the noodles over to one side of the pan using your spoon, so there's an empty space of broth on the other side.
 7. Crack the egg directly into that empty space. Wait about 10 seconds without touching it — this lets the white firm up slightly.
 8. Now break the yolk with your spoon and stir it around in that empty space for about 20 seconds, scrambling it into small pieces.
 9. Mix the scrambled egg pieces through the rest of the noodles. Cook for 1 more minute, stirring occasionally.
 10. Turn off the stove. Taste a tiny bit from the edge of the pan (careful, it's hot) — if it tastes a little flat, add one more small pinch of salt. Pour into a bowl and eat.

Money Hack: Buy Maggi in the 4-pack or family pack — it's noticeably cheaper per packet than buying singles.

Swap It: No egg? Add a handful of crushed peanuts at the end for crunch and protein instead.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Egg — ₹7, Vegetables — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹24.

Two-minute noodles, eight-minute satisfaction. Worth it.

5. Butter Masala Toast

For when you want “cheesy toast” flavours without buying actual cheese.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹12 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan or tawa **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A generous amount of butter hitting a hot pan does most of the work that a more complicated recipe would need several ingredients to achieve. This is the toast you make when you want to feel like you tried, on a morning when you very much did not have time to try.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices bread
- 1 tsp butter per slice
- Pinch of chaat masala or red chilli powder
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Take the butter straight from the fridge — don't wait for it to soften, that's not needed.
2. Using a butter knife, scoop about 1 teaspoon of butter and spread it over one whole side of the first bread slice. Press and spread it all the way to the corners

and edges — don't leave any bare spots, since bare spots dry out and taste plain. Repeat for the second slice.

3. Put a dry pan (no oil needed) on the stove. Turn the flame to medium.
4. Wait about 20 seconds, then hold your palm flat about 3 inches above the pan surface — if you feel warmth, the pan is ready. (Don't touch the pan itself.)
5. Place both bread slices into the pan, butter-side facing down onto the hot pan.
6. While they cook, sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt evenly over the top (dry) side of each slice — this way the seasoning is already in place and you won't need to reach for spice jars later while the pan is hot.
7. Let them cook undisturbed for about 2 minutes. After 2 minutes, use your spatula to lift one corner and peek underneath — you're looking for an even golden-brown colour with maybe a few slightly darker spots. If it still looks pale, cook for another 30 seconds and check again.
8. Once golden, use the spatula to lift both slices out onto a plate. They're ready to eat immediately.

Money Hack: A small block of butter lasts weeks in this recipe — it's cheaper per use than it looks on the shelf.

Swap It: No chaat masala? Plain chilli powder and salt does the job just as well.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹4, Butter — ₹6, Masala — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹12.

Small effort, disproportionately good result.

6. Quick Egg Bhurji Mash

Scrambled eggs' more flavourful, more filling cousin.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Bhurji is what happens when scrambled eggs stop being an afterthought and start being the main event. This is genuinely one of the fastest ways to turn two eggs into something that feels like a proper cooked meal.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove and turn the flame to medium. Add 1 teaspoon of oil.
2. Wait about 30 seconds for the oil to heat up — you'll see it thin out and move easily when you tilt the pan slightly.

3. Add the chopped onion (and the chilli, if using) into the pan. Stir it with your spoon for the first few seconds so it doesn't stick.
4. Let the onion cook for 2 minutes, stirring every 20–30 seconds. You want the onion to turn soft and slightly see-through at the edges — not brown, just soft. If it starts browning, turn your flame down a little.
5. Add the chopped tomato, a pinch of turmeric, a pinch of red chilli powder, and a pinch of salt. Stir everything together for a few seconds.
6. Let this cook for 1–2 minutes, stirring occasionally. You're waiting for the tomato pieces to go soft and start breaking apart into a saucy texture, rather than staying firm.
7. Now crack both eggs directly into the pan, right on top of the onion-tomato mixture.
8. Wait about 5 seconds without touching anything — you'll see the edges of the egg whites start turning from clear to white.
9. Using the edge of your spoon, start breaking the yolks and gently folding everything together — scoop from the bottom of the pan and fold it over the top, like you're turning pages. Keep doing this slowly.
10. Keep folding and cooking for about 1 more minute. Stop when the eggs look mostly set but still slightly soft and a little glossy — not dry or rubbery. They'll firm up a little more even after you take the pan off the heat.
11. Turn off the stove. Serve immediately, on its own or with bread.

Money Hack: This is a great way to use up a tomato or onion that's a day or two past its best.

Swap It: No tomato? It still works — just onion, chilli, and egg is a classic combination on its own.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Onion — ₹2, Tomato — ₹3, Spices/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹22.

Ten minutes of cooking for a meal that actually tastes looked-after.

7. Five-Minute Poha

Light, fast, and the closest thing to a “proper breakfast” you can make this quickly.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹15 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Poha barely needs cooking at all — the flattened rice is already par-cooked, so all you're doing is rehydrating it and warming it through with a bit of spice. It's genuinely light on the stomach.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup poha (flattened rice)
- ¼ onion, chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of turmeric, mustard seeds, salt
- A squeeze of lemon (optional)
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Put the poha into a sieve or colander (a strainer). Hold it under your tap and run cool water over it for about 10-15 seconds, moving the poha around gently with your other hand so the water reaches all of it.

2. Turn off the tap. Let the wet poha sit in the sieve for 1 minute — it will keep softening on its own during this time, so don't worry if it still feels a bit firm right after rinsing.
3. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium.
4. Wait 30 seconds for the oil to heat, then add a pinch of mustard seeds. Wait and listen — within 15-20 seconds you'll hear them start popping and crackling, like tiny sparks. That's your signal to move to the next step.
5. Add the chopped onion and chilli (if using). Stir and cook for about 2 minutes, until the onion turns soft.
6. Add a pinch of turmeric and a pinch of salt. Stir for 5 seconds — don't let the spices sit alone on the hot pan too long or they can burn and taste bitter.
7. Add the softened poha from the sieve. Using your spoon, mix everything together gently — turn and fold rather than stir hard, since poha strands break easily if handled roughly.
8. Cook for 1 more minute, folding gently every 15 seconds, just to warm the poha through evenly.
9. Turn off the stove. If using lemon, cut it in half and squeeze one half over the poha now. Give it one final gentle toss, then serve.

Money Hack: Poha is sold cheaply in bulk at most kirana stores — buying a 500g bag lasts many breakfasts.

Swap It: No mustard seeds? Skip the tempering step and just sauté the onion directly in oil.

COST BREAKDOWN

Poha — ₹8, Onion — ₹2, Spices/oil — ₹3, Lemon — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹15.

Light enough for a morning that already feels heavy.

8. Curd, Banana & Honey Bowl

No cooking, no cleanup, no excuses.



TIME: 3 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

There's a specific kind of morning where even a five-minute recipe feels like too much, and this exists for exactly that morning — three ingredients, no heat, no pan to wash.

INGREDIENTS

- $\frac{3}{4}$ cup curd
- 1 banana, sliced
- 1 tsp honey
- A few roasted peanuts, crushed (optional)

METHOD

1. Take a bowl. Spoon the curd into it first — about $\frac{3}{4}$ of a cup, or roughly 6 heaped spoonfuls.
2. Peel the banana by pinching the top and pulling the skin down. Place it on a cutting board.
3. Cut the banana into round slices, about half a centimetre thick, one by one, until the whole banana is sliced.

4. Lay the banana slices on top of the curd, arranging them so they cover most of the surface rather than piling in one spot.
5. Open your honey and, using a spoon, drizzle about 1 teaspoon over the top — move the spoon slowly back and forth as you pour so it spreads over the whole bowl instead of landing in one thick blob in the middle.
6. If using peanuts, take a small handful, place them between your fingers or in your palm, and crush them by pressing firmly — you'll feel them break apart. Sprinkle the crushed pieces over the top.
7. Your bowl is ready — eat immediately with a spoon.

Money Hack: Buy curd in the bigger 400g-500g tub instead of small cups — it's meaningfully cheaper per spoon.

Swap It: No honey? A pinch of sugar or jaggery works fine.

COST BREAKDOWN

Curd — ₹10, Banana — ₹6, Honey — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹20.

Three ingredients, zero stress. Sometimes that's the whole win.

9. Bread Upma

Upma's quicker, bread-based cousin — same comfort, less semolina-stirring.



TIME: 7 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

This version skips the traditional semolina and water-ratio fuss entirely by using torn bread, which already has structure and just needs a little moisture and spice. It's also one of the best possible uses for bread that's gone a bit stale.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 slices bread, torn into small pieces
- $\frac{1}{4}$ onion, chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of mustard seeds, turmeric, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- A splash of water

METHOD

1. Take the 3 bread slices. Using your hands (not a knife), tear each slice into small, bite-sized pieces — roughly the size of a large postage stamp. Do this over a plate so all the pieces land together.

2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, turn the flame to medium, and wait 30 seconds for it to heat up.
3. Add a pinch of mustard seeds. Listen for the popping and crackling sound — this takes about 15 seconds.
4. Add the chopped onion and chilli. Stir and cook for 2 minutes, until the onion turns soft.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric and a pinch of salt. Stir for a few seconds.
6. Add the torn bread pieces into the pan.
7. Take a small splash of water — about 1 tablespoon, just a light sprinkle from your fingers or a spoon, not a pour — and drizzle it over the bread pieces.
8. Using your spoon, toss and fold everything together gently for about 2 minutes. You're done when every piece of bread looks yellow-coated from the turmeric and feels warm all the way through.
9. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: This is the perfect use for bread that's gone slightly stale — it works even better here than fresh bread.

Swap It: No mustard seeds? A pinch of cumin seeds works just as well in the tempering.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹6, Onion — ₹2, Spices/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹11.

Proof that "stale bread" and "no plan" can still become breakfast.

10. Tomato-Onion Chutney Sandwich

A cold sandwich that tastes like someone put actual thought into it.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan (optional)
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A quick raw chutney made from finely chopped onion, tomato, and chilli gives you far more depth than plain ketchup, for almost no extra effort.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices bread
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ½ tomato, finely chopped
- 1 green chilli, finely chopped (optional)
- Pinch of salt, chaat masala
- 1 tsp oil (if toasting)

METHOD

1. On a cutting board, chop the onion as finely as you can — cut it into thin strips first, then turn it and chop across into small pieces. Put the chopped onion into a small bowl.

2. Do the same with the tomato — cut it into small pieces, roughly the same size as the onion pieces. Add it to the same bowl.
3. If using chilli, chop it very finely (small pieces, since it's spicy) and add it too.
4. Add a pinch of salt and a pinch of chaat masala to the bowl. Mix everything together with a spoon for about 10 seconds.
5. Let this sit for 1-2 minutes if you have the time — this isn't essential, but it helps the flavours combine a little.
6. Lay out 2 slices of bread on a plate. Using a spoon, spread the chutney mixture evenly across both slices, right to the edges.
7. Place the other 2 bread slices on top to close the sandwiches.
8. If you want it warm: put a pan on the stove with 1 teaspoon of oil, turn the flame to medium, wait 30 seconds for it to heat, then place the sandwiches in. Press down gently with your spatula. Cook for 1 minute, then flip and cook the other side for 1 minute too. If you're happy eating it cold, skip this step entirely — just cut and eat.

Money Hack: This chutney mix also works as a topping for Maggi, rice, or eggs — make a bit extra and reuse it.

Swap It: No chaat masala? A pinch of black pepper and a squeeze of lemon does something similar.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹8, Onion — ₹2, Tomato — ₹3, Spices — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹15.

Cold, tangy, and ready before your roommate finishes complaining about their day.

11. Roasted Peanut Chaat

Crunchy, tangy, and dangerously easy to keep eating past the point of being hungry.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹12 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Crunchy plus tangy plus a little spicy is almost always more satisfying than any one of those alone. This is dangerously easy to keep nibbling well past the point where you meant to stop.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup roasted peanuts
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt
- Squeeze of lemon
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Take a bowl. Add the roasted peanuts into it — about half a cup, or a small handful and a half.
2. On a cutting board, finely chop the onion and add it to the bowl.

3. Finely chop the tomato too, and add it in the same bowl.
4. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt over everything.
5. Cut a lemon in half. Squeeze one half firmly over the bowl, using your other hand cupped underneath to catch any seeds so they don't fall in.
6. Using a spoon, toss everything together gently for about 10 seconds, until the masala and lemon juice are spread evenly through the mix.
7. If using coriander, sprinkle it on top now. Eat right away — don't let it sit too long, since the peanuts start to soften once they touch the lemon juice.

Money Hack: Buy roasted peanuts loose from a local vendor rather than packaged — usually cheaper for the same amount.

Swap It: No fresh tomato? Skip it — the peanuts, onion, and chaat masala still work well alone.

COST BREAKDOWN

Peanuts — ₹6, Onion — ₹2, Tomato — ₹2, Masala/lemon — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹12.

A snack that somehow also counts as a meal if you eat enough of it.

12. Jaggery Oats Bowl

Warm, sweet, and the closest thing to a hug you'll get on a rainy evening.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹15 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Oats cooked slowly in milk thicken naturally into a comforting, porridge-like texture. Jaggery adds a deep, slightly caramel-like sweetness that pairs beautifully with the earthiness of oats.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup rolled oats
- 1 cup milk (or milk and water mixed)
- 1 tbsp jaggery or sugar, grated or crushed
- Pinch of cardamom powder (optional)

METHOD

1. Pour 1 cup of milk into a small pan. Put it on the stove and turn the flame to medium.
2. Stay near the stove — don't walk away. Watch the milk closely. After about 2 minutes, you'll see small bubbles forming at the edges and steam rising — that means it's warm and close to boiling.

3. The moment you see it starting to rise or bubble up, add the oats immediately and turn the flame down to low.
4. Stir the mixture for the first minute, about every 20–30 seconds, so the oats don't settle and stick to the bottom of the pan.
5. Let it cook for another 2–3 minutes on low heat, stirring every 30 seconds. You're watching for the mixture to thicken — it should coat the back of your spoon rather than drip straight off.
6. Add the jaggery (grate or crush it first if it's in a hard block) and the cardamom, if using. Stir well.
7. Cook for 1 more minute, stirring, until you can't see any gritty jaggery bits left — it should be fully melted into the mixture.
8. Turn off the stove. Taste a small spoonful (careful, it's hot) — add a little more jaggery if you want it sweeter. Pour into a bowl and eat while warm.

Money Hack: Jaggery keeps for months unrefrigerated — buying a small block is cheaper long-term than buying sugar sachets.

Swap It: No milk? Make it with water — less creamy, but still warm and comforting.

COST BREAKDOWN

Oats — ₹6, Milk — ₹6, Jaggery — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹15.

This is what "everything's going to be fine" tastes like.

13. Boiled Chana Chaat

High-protein, filling, and mostly just requires you to open a can or boil some chickpeas in advance.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Once chickpeas are boiled, this recipe is really just assembly. The combination of tang, sharpness, and savoury-sour chaat masala wakes up what would otherwise be a fairly plain ingredient.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup boiled chickpeas (chana)
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt
- Squeeze of lemon
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. If your boiled chickpeas are cold from the fridge, put them in a sieve and run warm tap water over them for about 20 seconds — this takes the chill off and makes them taste better.

2. Let them drain in the sieve for a minute, then tip them into a bowl.
3. Finely chop the onion on a cutting board and add it to the bowl.
4. Finely chop the tomato too, and add it in.
5. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt over the top.
6. Cut a lemon in half. Squeeze one half over the bowl — chickpeas can handle a good amount of lemon, so don't be shy, use the whole half.
7. Toss everything together gently with a spoon for about 10 seconds, making sure the masala coats everything rather than sitting at the bottom.
8. Sprinkle coriander on top if using, and serve.

Money Hack: Boil a big batch of chickpeas once a week (soak overnight, boil 20-25 minutes) and refrigerate — then this recipe becomes a 5-minute assembly job all week.

Swap It: No fresh chickpeas boiled? Canned chickpeas work just as well — rinse them first.

COST BREAKDOWN

Chickpeas — ₹10, Onion — ₹2, Tomato — ₹2, Masala/lemon — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹16.

Protein, crunch, and tang — this one actually keeps you full.

14. Garlic Butter Toast

Simple, fragrant, and makes your room smell like you have your life together.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan or tawa **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Garlic and butter cooked together release an aroma that's disproportionately impressive for how little effort it takes.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices bread
- 1 tsp butter
- 1 clove garlic, finely minced (or a pinch of garlic powder)
- Pinch of salt, chilli flakes (optional)

METHOD

1. Take one garlic clove. Peel off the papery skin with your fingers or the flat side of a knife. Place the peeled clove on a cutting board.
2. Using a knife, chop the garlic as finely as you can — cut it into thin slices first, then chop across into tiny pieces. Keep chopping until the pieces are very small.
3. Put 1 teaspoon of butter into a small bowl. Add the chopped garlic. Mix them together thoroughly with a spoon until the garlic is evenly spread through the

butter, not sitting in one clump.

4. Using a knife, spread the garlic butter over one side of each bread slice, covering right to the edges.
5. Put a dry pan on the stove (no extra oil needed) and turn the flame to medium.
6. Place both bread slices into the pan, butter-side facing down. Let them sit undisturbed — don't move them around.
7. Cook for about 2 minutes. Then lift one corner with your spatula to check underneath — you want an even golden colour, with the garlic bits looking just slightly browned, not black. If it's not golden yet, cook another 30 seconds and check again.
8. Once golden, remove from the pan immediately. While still hot, sprinkle a pinch of salt and chilli flakes over the top — the heat helps the seasoning stick.

Money Hack: A whole bulb of garlic costs very little and lasts weeks — worth keeping on hand just for recipes like this.

Swap It: No fresh garlic? A pinch of garlic powder mixed into the butter works almost as well.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹4, Butter — ₹6, Garlic — ₹2, Spices — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹14.

Smells like effort. Took none.

15. Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits

Not really a meal, but on the nights you're too tired to chew much else, this counts.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

There's a specific kind of tiredness where even chewing feels like effort, and warm, mildly spiced milk with something to dunk in it is exactly the right register for that mood.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup milk
- Pinch of turmeric, cardamom powder, or a small piece of crushed ginger
- 1 tsp sugar or jaggery (optional)
- 4-5 biscuits (Parle-G or similar)

METHOD

1. Pour 1 cup of milk into a small pan. Place it on the stove and turn the flame to medium.
2. Stay right next to the stove for this whole step — don't walk away, even for a minute. Milk can rise up and spill over the sides very quickly, within about 30 seconds of starting to boil, with no warning.

3. Watch for small bubbles forming around the edges of the pan and steam starting to rise — this usually takes about 2 minutes.
4. The moment you see it about to rise up, add a pinch of turmeric or cardamom (whichever you're using) and the sugar if using. Stir once with a spoon.
5. Turn the flame down to low. Let it simmer gently — small bubbles, not a big rolling boil — for about 1 minute, so the spice flavour has time to mix into the milk.
6. Turn off the stove. Carefully pour the hot milk into a mug, leaving a little space at the top so it doesn't spill.
7. Take one biscuit. Dip it into the milk and hold it there for 2-3 seconds — count "one, two, three" in your head — then take it out and eat it before it gets too soft and breaks apart. Repeat with each biscuit.

Money Hack: A packet of basic biscuits is one of the cheapest snacks per piece in any Indian kirana store — always worth keeping a pack around.

Swap It: No cardamom or turmeric? Even plain warm milk with sugar does the comfort-food job.

COST BREAKDOWN

Milk — ₹8, Spices/sugar — ₹2, Biscuits — ₹6. Estimated total — ₹16.

Some nights, warm milk and biscuits is the whole meal. That's allowed.

Breakfast & Morning Meals

Mornings are rough. Class is early, sleep was short, and the last thing you want is a complicated recipe. Every method below is broken into small, exact steps — what to do, how long to wait, what it should look like — so you can follow along without guessing.

16. Mashed Potato Stuffed Roti

A shortcut aloo paratha for people who don't have the energy to actually stuff and roll dough.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One tawa or pan
LEVEL: Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

This version skips the stuffing step entirely by mixing the mashed potato straight into the dough, so you get the exact same flavour with none of the fiddly technique. It's a slightly denser, more rustic flatbread, and it's far more forgiving if your rolling isn't perfectly even.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup atta (wheat flour)
- 1 medium potato, boiled and mashed
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ¼ tsp red chilli powder, pinch of salt
- Water, as needed to knead
- 1 tsp oil or ghee, for cooking

METHOD

1. Make sure your boiled potato has cooled down — if it's still hot, wait 5 minutes before touching it, since a hot potato makes the dough sticky.
2. Put the potato in a bowl. Using a fork, mash it by pressing down firmly and moving it around, until there are no big lumps left — small soft lumps are fine, big chunks are not, since they'll tear the dough later.
3. Add the atta into the same bowl, along with the chopped onion, chilli powder, and a pinch of salt.
4. Using your fingers, rub and mix everything together for about 30 seconds — it should look like uneven, crumbly bits, not smooth yet.
5. Add water, just 1 tablespoon at a time. After each spoon, knead the dough with both hands for 15–20 seconds — press it, fold it, press again. Keep adding water slowly like this until the dough turns into one smooth, soft ball that doesn't stick to your palm when you touch it. This usually takes about 4–5 tablespoons of water total.
6. Divide the dough into 2 equal balls, roughly the size of a small lemon each.
7. Sprinkle a little dry flour onto your rolling surface. Place one dough ball on it and flatten it slightly with your palm.
8. Using a rolling pin, roll it out evenly in all directions — roll once, then turn the dough a quarter turn, then roll again. Keep repeating this turning-and-rolling until you have a round flatbread about the size of a small plate.
9. Put your tawa or pan on the stove and turn the flame to medium. Wait about 1 minute for it to heat up — you can test it by flicking a few drops of water onto it; if they sizzle and disappear quickly, it's ready.
10. Place the rolled roti onto the hot tawa. Let it cook for about 30 seconds, then flip it over using a spatula.
11. Add ½ teaspoon of oil or ghee on top and spread it lightly with the back of your spoon. Let it cook for 1 minute, pressing gently around the edges with your spatula.
12. Flip again, add a little oil to this side too, and cook for another minute. You're looking for light golden-brown spots appearing on the surface — once you see those on both sides, it's done. Repeat steps 7–12 with the second dough ball.

Money Hack: Boil two or three extra potatoes whenever you're already boiling one — they keep for a couple of days and make this recipe a five-minute job next time.

Swap It: No potato on hand? Use mashed, cooked dal instead for a different but equally filling version.

COST BREAKDOWN

Atta — ₹6, Potato — ₹4, Onion — ₹2, Spices/oil — ₹6. Estimated total — ₹18.

Tastes like effort. Took about fifteen minutes.

17. Sooji Uttapam

A thick, savoury pancake made from semolina — crispy edges, soft middle.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

This sooji-based version gets you most of the way to a real South Indian uttapam in twelve minutes — the semolina swells and softens as it rests in curd, giving you a batter that fries up with crisp edges and a soft, slightly spongy centre, without any waiting for fermentation.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup sooji (semolina)
- ½ cup curd
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of salt
- Water, as needed
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Put the sooji into a mixing bowl. Add the curd and a pinch of salt.
2. Stir with a spoon, then start adding water — just a splash at a time, about 1 tablespoon each time — stirring after each addition. Keep going until you get a batter about as thick as pancake batter: it should drop off your spoon slowly in a ribbon, not pour like water and not sit like a paste.
3. Now leave the bowl alone for exactly 5 minutes. Set a timer if you need to — don't skip this rest, it's what softens the semolina properly.
4. After 5 minutes, check the batter. If it's thickened up too much while sitting, stir in one more small splash of water.
5. Add the chopped onion and tomato into the batter and stir them through evenly.
6. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
7. Pour the batter into the centre of the pan. Using the back of your spoon or ladle, spread it outward in a gentle circular motion, making a thick circle about the size of a small plate — don't spread it too thin, uttapam should stay fluffy in the middle.
8. Let it cook undisturbed for 3 minutes. Do not touch it during this time. You'll know it's ready to flip when you see the edges turning dry-looking and starting to lift slightly away from the pan on their own.
9. Slide a wide spatula fully underneath, and flip it over in one motion.
10. Cook the second side for 2 minutes, pressing down very lightly with your spatula here and there so it makes good contact with the pan.
11. Once both sides show golden-brown patches, slide it onto a plate and serve.

Money Hack: Sooji is one of the cheapest grains per kilo in most kirana stores — a small bag lasts for many breakfasts.

Swap It: No curd? Use water instead, though curd gives a slightly softer texture.

COST BREAKDOWN

Sooji — ₹6, Curd — ₹5, Vegetables — ₹3, Oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹16.

Crispy edges, soft middle, ready before your tea gets cold.

18. Eggless Banana Pancakes

Sweet, soft, and doesn't need eggs, a whisk, or any real pancake skills.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Mashed banana does two jobs at once here — it binds the batter together and adds enough natural sweetness that you barely need added sugar. The riper the banana, the better, so the ones with brown spots are actually perfect.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 ripe banana, mashed well
- ½ cup atta or plain flour
- ¼ cup milk (adjust for batter thickness)
- Pinch of cinnamon or cardamom powder (optional)
- 1 tsp oil or ghee

METHOD

1. Peel the banana and put it in a bowl. Using a fork, mash it by pressing down repeatedly until it's mostly smooth, with just a few tiny soft lumps left — don't worry about getting it perfectly smooth.
2. Add the flour, milk, and cinnamon (if using) into the same bowl.
3. Stir with a spoon just until you can't see any dry flour anymore — about 10-15 stirs. Stop as soon as it looks combined; stirring more than needed makes the pancakes tougher.
4. Put your pan on the stove and add a little oil or ghee, spreading it around with a spoon. Turn the flame to low-medium — lower than you might expect, since these brown fast on the outside but need gentle heat to cook through.
5. Wait 30 seconds for the pan to warm up.
6. Using a spoon, scoop out a small amount of batter — about 2 tablespoons — and pour it into the pan, making a small circle no bigger than your palm. Repeat with the rest of the batter if your pan has room for more than one at a time.
7. Let it sit undisturbed. After about 1½ minutes, look at the surface — you'll see small bubbles forming and staying open, like tiny craters. That's your sign it's ready to flip.
8. Slide a thin spatula underneath and flip it in one smooth motion.
9. Cook the second side for another 1-1½ minutes. It's done when it springs back gently if you press the centre lightly with your finger.
10. Lift it out onto a plate. Repeat with any remaining batter.

Money Hack: Overripe bananas — the ones with brown spots you'd normally skip — actually work best here since they're sweeter and mash more easily.

Swap It: No milk? Water works, though the pancakes will be slightly less rich.

COST BREAKDOWN

Banana — ₹6, Flour — ₹4, Milk — ₹4, Oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹16.

Sweet enough to feel like a treat, simple enough to make with your eyes half-closed.

19. Loaded Masala Omelette with Toast

A proper sit-down breakfast, still done in under ten minutes.



TIME: 9 min **COST:** ₹28 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

This is the breakfast for the rare morning you actually have ten spare minutes and want to use them properly — a well-spiced omelette next to warm, buttered toast, timed so both finish together.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of turmeric, salt, pepper

- 2 slices bread
- 1 tsp butter
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Crack both eggs into a bowl. Beat them with a fork for about 20 seconds until smooth and evenly yellow.
2. Add the onion, tomato, chilli (if using), turmeric, salt, and pepper. Stir it all together for about 10 seconds so the colour looks uniform.
3. Spread butter on one side of each bread slice now, before you start cooking anything — this saves you from doing it later with messy hands.
4. Put a pan on the stove with 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for the oil to heat.
5. Pour the egg mixture into the pan and tilt the pan gently to spread it evenly across the bottom.
6. While the egg cooks, put a second dry pan (or the same pan later, once the egg is out) on another burner if you have one, or set the bread aside to toast right after — place the buttered bread in, butter-side down, and let it toast for about 2 minutes until golden, then remove and set aside.
7. Back to the egg: let it cook undisturbed for about 2 minutes. You'll know it's close to ready when the edges look fully set and only the very centre still looks a little glossy.
8. Slide your spatula underneath, supporting the egg fully so it doesn't fold on itself, and flip it over in one motion.
9. Cook the second side for 1 more minute.
10. Slide the omelette onto a plate next to the toast. Serve both together while still hot.

Money Hack: Buttering bread before toasting (rather than after) uses less butter overall and toasts more evenly.

Swap It: No tomato? Just onion and chilli still makes a great masala omelette.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Vegetables — ₹4, Bread — ₹4, Butter/oil — ₹6. Estimated total — ₹28.

This is the breakfast that makes you feel like an adult who has it together.

20. Besan Chilla

A savoury gram-flour pancake — naturally vegetarian, naturally high-protein, genuinely tasty.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Besan batter firms up almost immediately in a hot pan and crisps beautifully at the edges, which is what makes chilla such a satisfying egg-free alternative to an omelette.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup besan (gram flour)
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- ¼ tomato, finely chopped (optional)
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- Water, as needed
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Put the besan in a bowl. Add water a little at a time — about 2 tablespoons at first — and stir with a spoon or whisk after each addition, pressing out any lumps against the side of the bowl.
2. Keep adding water slowly and stirring until you get a smooth batter with the thickness of heavy cream — it should pour off your spoon in a steady stream, with no lumps anywhere.
3. Add the onion, tomato, chilli, turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir until evenly mixed through.
4. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
5. Pour a ladleful of batter into the centre of the pan. Immediately, using the back of the ladle, spread it outward in a circular motion from the centre, working your way out to the edges, making one thin, even layer.
6. Let it cook undisturbed. Watch for the edges to start looking dry and slightly curling upward, and small holes may appear on the surface — this usually takes about 2 minutes.
7. Slide a wide, flat spatula underneath in one motion and flip it confidently — don't hesitate halfway, a quick, decisive flip works best.
8. Cook the second side for about 1½ minutes, until it's golden with a few darker crisp spots.
9. Slide it onto a plate and serve hot.

Money Hack: Besan is cheap, keeps for months in a sealed container, and works in dozens of recipes — always worth having a bag around.

Swap It: No fresh vegetables? A plain besan chilla with just spices is still tasty on its own.

COST BREAKDOWN

Besan — ₹8, Vegetables — ₹4, Spices/oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹14.

Vegetarian, protein-rich, and doesn't taste like either of those things is the point.

21. Overnight Oats (Prep Tonight, Eat Tomorrow)

Zero-effort breakfast because all the effort happened the night before.



TIME: 5 min prep + overnight **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Oats left to soak overnight in milk or curd soften completely through a slow, cold process, so by morning they're creamy and ready without ever touching a stove.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup rolled oats
- ¾ cup milk or curd (or a mix of both)
- 1 tsp honey or sugar
- A few banana slices or any fruit you have
- Pinch of cinnamon (optional)

METHOD

1. Find a container with a lid — a small box, a jar, or even a bowl you can cover with a plate.
2. Add the oats into the container.
3. Pour in the milk or curd.
4. Add the honey.

5. Using a spoon, stir everything together thoroughly for about 15–20 seconds, making sure to scrape the sides so no dry oats are left clinging there uncovered.
6. Put the lid on (or cover with a plate). Place it in the fridge.
7. Leave it there overnight — at least 6 hours if possible, though even 3–4 hours works if you’re prepping in the evening for a late morning.
8. In the morning, take it out. Don’t be alarmed if it looks thick — that’s exactly right, it means the oats have absorbed the liquid properly.
9. Stir it well with a spoon to loosen it up.
10. Slice your banana or other fruit now, right before eating, and place the slices on top. Sprinkle with cinnamon if using. Eat cold, straight from the container.

Money Hack: No fridge? Skip the milk and use only curd — it holds up better overnight at room temperature in cooler weather. In hot weather, this recipe is safest with fridge access.

Swap It: No fruit? A spoon of jam or a few crushed peanuts on top works just as well.

COST BREAKDOWN

Oats — ₹6, Milk/curd — ₹8, Honey — ₹2, Fruit — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹18.

You already did the work. Past-you deserves a thank you.

22. Sprouted Moong Breakfast Bowl

Crunchy, light, and quietly one of the more filling things on this list.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Sprouted moong is crisp and light rather than firm and starchy, which is part of why this bowl feels so much lighter to eat than the same beans boiled whole.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup sprouted moong (store-bought or home-sprouted)
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt
- Squeeze of lemon
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. If your sprouts have been in the fridge, put them in a sieve and rinse them under cool running water for about 10 seconds. Shake the sieve gently to remove excess water.
2. Tip the rinsed sprouts into a bowl.
3. Finely chop the onion and add it in.

4. Finely chop the tomato and add it in too.
5. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt over the top.
6. Cut a lemon in half and squeeze one half over the bowl.
7. Toss everything together gently with a spoon — turn and fold rather than stir hard, so you don't crush the sprouts.
8. Sprinkle coriander on top if using, and eat within the next few minutes while everything's still fresh.

Money Hack: To sprout moong at home: soak dried moong overnight, drain, and leave in a covered container for 1-2 days, rinsing once a day, until small sprouts appear. Costs far less than store-bought sprouts.

Swap It: No sprouts? Boiled chickpeas or boiled moong (unsprouted) work as a substitute with a similar texture.

COST BREAKDOWN

Sprouts — ₹8, Vegetables — ₹4, Masala/lemon — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹14.

Crunchy, light, and it'll actually keep you full till lunch.

23. Egg Bhurji Roti Wrap

Yesterday's bhurji logic, wrapped into today's breakfast-on-the-go.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹24 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A roti holds its shape far better than bread when rolled tightly around a filling, so this genuinely stays together while you eat it one-handed on your way out.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- ¼ onion, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1 roti or chapati (leftover or fresh)

METHOD

1. Put a pan on the stove with 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
2. Add the chopped onion. Stir and cook for about 1 minute — just until it softens slightly and turns a little see-through at the edges. Don't let it brown.
3. Add the turmeric, chilli powder, and a pinch of salt. Stir for a few seconds.

4. Crack both eggs directly into the pan. Wait 5 seconds, then start breaking the yolks and folding everything together gently with your spoon.
5. Keep folding for about 1 minute, until the eggs are just set — soft, not dry. Turn off the stove.
6. Take the roti. Place it directly over a low flame for about 5 seconds on one side, using tongs to hold it, then flip and do the other side for 5 seconds too — this makes it soft and bendy. (If you don't have an open flame, warm it in a dry pan for about 20 seconds on each side instead.)
7. Lay the warm roti flat on a plate. Spoon the bhurji onto it in a line, positioned slightly off-centre rather than in the middle.
8. Fold the shorter, nearer edge of the roti up and over the filling first.
9. Continue rolling it the rest of the way into a tight roll, tucking in as you go so nothing falls out.

Money Hack: Leftover rotis from last night's dinner are perfect here — this is a great way to avoid roti going to waste.

Swap It: No roti on hand? Use two slices of bread instead, folded over the bhurji like a sandwich.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Onion — ₹2, Spices/oil — ₹3, Roti — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹24.

Breakfast you can eat with one hand while packing your bag with the other.

24. Vermicelli Upma (Semiya)

Thinner, lighter, and cooks even faster than regular upma.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Vermicelli cooks almost as fast as instant noodles but tastes like a proper South Indian breakfast — light, mildly spiced, and easy on a sleepy stomach.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup thin vermicelli (roasted, if available)
- ¼ onion, chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of mustard seeds, turmeric, salt
- 1.5 cups water
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Check your vermicelli packet — if it says “roasted,” skip to step 3. If it’s plain, continue to step 2.
2. Put the pan on the stove on medium heat with no oil yet. Add the vermicelli and stir constantly with a spoon for about 1 minute, until it turns a shade darker and smells lightly toasty. Tip it out onto a plate and set aside.

3. In the same pan, add 1 teaspoon of oil and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
4. Add a pinch of mustard seeds. Wait for the popping sound — about 15 seconds.
5. Add the chopped onion and chilli. Cook for 1 minute, stirring, until the onion softens.
6. Add a pinch of turmeric and a pinch of salt, then pour in the 1.5 cups of water. Turn the flame up to high and let it come to a full, rolling boil — you'll see big bubbles across the whole surface, which takes about 2 minutes.
7. Add the roasted vermicelli, and give it one stir to spread it out evenly in the water.
8. Cover the pan with a lid, turn the flame down to low, and set a timer for 4 minutes. Don't lift the lid during this time.
9. After 4 minutes, remove the lid and fluff gently with a fork — the water should be fully soaked up, with the strands separate rather than sitting in liquid. Serve.

Money Hack: Roasted vermicelli costs slightly more than plain, but saves you the roasting step — worth it if you make this often.

Swap It: No mustard seeds? Just sauté the onion in oil directly, skipping the tempering step.

COST BREAKDOWN

Vermicelli — ₹8, Onion — ₹2, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

Light enough that you won't regret it by 10am.

25. Milk Dalia (Broken Wheat Porridge)

Warm, mildly sweet, and the kind of breakfast that makes cold mornings bearable.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Dalia cooks into a soft, slightly nutty porridge that's gentler on the stomach than most breakfast cereals, and it needs almost no attention while it simmers.

INGREDIENTS

- ¼ cup dalia (broken wheat)
- 1 cup milk (or milk and water mixed)
- 1 tbsp sugar or jaggery
- Pinch of cardamom powder (optional)

METHOD

1. Put the dalia and milk into a pan together, right from the start — don't heat the milk alone first.
2. Place the pan on the stove and turn the flame to medium.
3. Watch it closely — milk-based mixtures can rise up fast. The moment you see it starting to rise or bubble at the edges (usually within 2-3 minutes), turn the flame down to low immediately.

4. Let it simmer gently on low heat for about 8 minutes. Stir every minute — count roughly 60 seconds between each stir — so the dalia doesn't stick to the bottom.
5. Watch for the grains to swell up and look plump, and the whole mixture to thicken into a soft, spoonable porridge. That's your sign it's nearly done.
6. Add the sugar and cardamom. Stir well.
7. Cook for 1 more minute, stirring, until you can't feel any gritty sugar bits when you taste a small spoonful (careful, it's hot). Turn off the stove and serve warm.

Money Hack: Dalia is one of the cheapest grains available and keeps for months — a small bag makes many breakfasts.

Swap It: No milk? Cook it in water instead and stir in a spoon of curd at the end for creaminess.

COST BREAKDOWN

Dalia — ₹5, Milk — ₹6, Sugar — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹13.

This is the breakfast equivalent of a soft blanket.

26. Quick Bread Pakora

Crispy, golden, and technically breakfast if you eat it before noon.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

The bread's absorbent structure soaks up just enough spiced besan batter to crisp beautifully in hot oil without falling apart — a shatteringly crisp coating around a soft, warm centre.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices bread, halved diagonally
- ½ cup besan (gram flour)
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- Water, as needed
- 2 tsp oil, for pan-frying

METHOD

1. Cut each bread slice diagonally into 2 triangles, so you have 4 triangles total. Set aside.
2. Put the besan in a bowl. Add the turmeric, chilli powder, and a pinch of salt.
3. Add water a little at a time — about 2 tablespoons at first — whisking with a fork or spoon after each addition, breaking up any lumps against the side of the bowl.

4. Keep adding water slowly until you get a smooth batter, about as thick as a milkshake — thin enough to coat the bread but thick enough to actually stick.
5. Put a pan on the stove, add 2 teaspoons of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
6. Pick up one bread triangle. Dip it fully into the batter, making sure both sides and the crust are coated. Hold it up for a second to let the extra batter drip back into the bowl.
7. Place it carefully into the hot pan. Repeat with the other triangles, leaving a little space between each one so they're not touching — this stops them from steaming each other instead of frying.
8. Let them cook undisturbed for about 2 minutes. Lift one edge with your spatula to check — you want a deep golden-brown colour, not just pale beige.
9. Flip each one over with your spatula and cook the second side for 2 minutes too, checking the same way.
10. Once both sides are deep golden, lift them out onto a plate and serve warm.

Money Hack: This is an excellent way to use up bread that's starting to go a little dry or stale.

Swap It: No besan? A thin batter of atta with the same spices works as a substitute, though the texture will be slightly different.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹4, Besan — ₹6, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

Crunchy enough to make you forget it took ten minutes, not thirty.

27. Cold Veg Sandwich with Mint Chutney

Fresh, crunchy, and doesn't need any cooking or cleanup.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

This leans entirely on freshness and crunch, which makes it the right choice on a warm morning when a hot breakfast feels like the last thing you want.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices bread
- ¼ cucumber, thinly sliced
- ¼ carrot, thinly sliced or grated
- 1 tsp mint or coriander chutney (or ketchup, if that's what you have)
- Pinch of salt, pepper

METHOD

1. Wash the cucumber and carrot under running water for a few seconds.
2. On a cutting board, slice the cucumber into thin rounds — as thin as you comfortably can, since thick slices make the sandwich hard to bite through.
3. Slice or grate the carrot the same way.
4. Lay out 2 slices of bread on a plate. Using a spoon or knife, spread the chutney

evenly over both slices, right to the edges — this thin layer helps protect the bread from getting soggy later.

5. Arrange the cucumber slices evenly over the chutney on one piece of bread.
6. Add the carrot on top of the cucumber.
7. Sprinkle a pinch of salt and pepper directly over the vegetables.
8. Place the second chutney-covered bread slice on top, chutney-side facing down, to close the sandwich.
9. Press down very gently with your palm, just enough to help it hold together.
10. Using a knife, cut it in half with one smooth, single cutting motion — don't saw back and forth, which can push the filling out the sides.

Money Hack: Buy cucumber and carrot in small quantities twice a week rather than a big batch — they lose their crunch quickly once cut.

Swap It: No chutney on hand? A thin layer of curd mixed with salt and pepper works as a cool, tangy substitute.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹8, Vegetables — ₹8, Chutney — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹18.

Cool, crunchy, and doesn't ask anything of you before 9am.

28. Moong Dal Chilla

A slightly heartier, protein-packed cousin of the besan chilla.



TIME: 15 min (plus 2 hr soak) **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan
LEVEL: Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Soaked and blended moong dal makes a naturally protein-rich batter with a slightly nutty flavour, closer to a savoury dosa than a besan chilla.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup yellow moong dal, soaked 2 hours (or overnight)
- 1 green chilli, small piece of ginger
- Pinch of salt, cumin seeds
- Water, as needed
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. First thing — soak the dal. Put ½ cup moong dal in a bowl, cover it completely with water, and leave it for at least 2 hours (or overnight if you're planning ahead).
2. When ready to cook, pour the dal into a sieve to drain off the soaking water completely. Give the sieve a shake to remove excess water.

3. Put the drained dal into a blender, along with the chilli and ginger. Add just a small splash of water — about 2 tablespoons.
4. Blend for about 30 seconds, then stop and scrape down the sides with a spoon. Blend again for another 20 seconds. Keep repeating this until the batter is completely smooth with no visible dal pieces — it should be thick but pourable, similar to pancake batter.
5. Pour the batter into a bowl. Add a pinch of salt and the cumin seeds, and stir them in by hand with a spoon (not blended, so they stay whole).
6. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
7. Pour a ladleful of batter into the centre. Using the back of the ladle, spread it outward in gentle circles from the centre to the edges, making a thin, even circle.
8. Let it cook undisturbed for about 2 minutes — you'll see the edges lift slightly and turn golden.
9. Slide a wide spatula underneath and flip it in one confident motion.
10. Cook the second side for about 1½ minutes, until golden. Slide onto a plate and serve.

Money Hack: Soak a bigger batch of dal and keep it in the fridge for up to two days — batter can be made fresh each morning without resoaking.

Swap It: No blender? Finely mash the soaked dal by hand with a fork — it won't be as smooth, but it still works.

COST BREAKDOWN

Moong dal — ₹8, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹12.

Needs a little planning the night before, but mornings-you will thank tonight-you.

29. Chai and Rusk (The Classic Combo)

Not a recipe so much as a ritual, but it counts as breakfast on the hardest mornings.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹8 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Letting the tea leaves actually boil in the water for a minute before the milk goes in is what pulls out real colour and strength, rather than leaving you with pale, weak tea.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup water
- ½ cup milk
- 1 tsp tea leaves (or 1 tea bag)
- 1 tsp sugar (adjust to taste)
- 2-3 rusks

METHOD

1. Pour 1 cup of water into a small pan. Put it on the stove and turn the flame to high.
2. Wait until you see big, rolling bubbles across the whole surface — proper boiling, not just steam. This takes about 2-3 minutes.
3. Add the tea leaves directly into the boiling water. Let them boil, uncovered, for

a full 1 minute — don't add anything else yet, this step is what builds the actual tea flavour.

4. Add the milk and sugar. Stir once.
5. Watch the pan closely now, since milk rises fast — bring it back up to a gentle boil, which takes about 1–2 minutes.
6. The moment it starts to rise, let it simmer for about 2 minutes, watching the colour — you're looking for a rich, slightly reddish-brown colour, not pale milky beige.
7. Turn off the stove. Place a small sieve or tea strainer over your cup, and pour the tea through it to catch the leaves.
8. Take one rusk. Dip it into the hot tea and hold it there for 2–3 seconds — count “one, two, three” — then take it out and eat before it softens too much and breaks. Repeat with each rusk.

Money Hack: A packet of rusks lasts weeks unrefrigerated and costs very little per piece — one of the cheapest “breakfasts” available.

Swap It: No milk? Black tea with a little extra sugar works fine too.

COST BREAKDOWN

Tea/milk/sugar — ₹5, Rusks — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹8.

Some mornings, this is enough. That's completely fine.

30. Curd and Flattened Rice Bowl (Dahi Poha)

A cooling, no-cook cousin of regular poha — perfect for warm mornings.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Instead of tempering poha in hot oil, this version simply lets it soften directly in curd — a completely different, cooling experience for a warm morning.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup thin poha (flattened rice)
- ¾ cup curd
- Pinch of salt, roasted cumin powder
- ¼ cucumber or onion, finely chopped (optional)
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Put the poha in a sieve. Rinse it briefly under running water for about 5 seconds — just a quick pass, not a long soak.
2. Let it sit in the sieve for 2 minutes. It will soften and turn slightly translucent at the edges on its own.
3. Tip the softened poha into a bowl.

4. Add the curd, a pinch of salt, and a pinch of roasted cumin powder.
5. Using a spoon, fold everything together gently — turn and lift rather than stir hard, since poha strands are delicate and break easily.
6. If using cucumber or onion, fold it in now, along with the coriander.
7. Let the bowl sit for 1-2 minutes before eating, if you can spare it — this short rest lets the poha soak up a bit more of the curd's tang.

Money Hack: This is a great way to use up curd that's a day or two from its best — the tang actually improves the flavour here.

Swap It: No roasted cumin powder? Regular cumin powder works, just slightly less smoky in flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Poha — ₹4, Curd — ₹10, Vegetables — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹16.

Cool, soft, and ready before you've even finished waking up.

Maggi/Noodles Reinvented



Everyone already knows how to make basic Maggi. These recipes exist for the days you want the same comfort but a completely different experience. Every method step below is broken down small — what to do, how long to wait, what to check for — so you can follow along exactly, even if noodles are the only thing you’ve ever “cooked” before.

31. Dry Garlic Butter Maggi

No soupy masala water here — this is Maggi that eats more like a stir-fry.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cutting the water down and finishing the noodles in garlic butter, instead of leaving them swimming in masala liquid, gives you something richer and more concentrated — closer to a proper noodle stir-fry than the bowl-and-spoon experience you're used to.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles (use half the tastemaker only)
- 1 tsp butter
- 1 clove garlic, minced
- Pinch of chilli flakes
- 1 cup water (less than usual)

METHOD

1. Pour 1 cup of water into a pan — this is less than the usual amount, so keep an eye on it since it heats up faster than you'd expect.

2. Put the pan on the stove and turn the flame to high. Wait for big, rolling bubbles across the whole surface — that's a proper boil, about 2 minutes.
3. Break the noodle block in half with your hands if you want shorter strands, then drop it into the boiling water.
4. Set a timer for 2 minutes. Stir every 20 seconds with a fork so the noodles don't clump. Check at the 1-minute mark — because there's less water this time, it might fully soak up before the timer ends. If the noodles look tender and the water's mostly gone, stop cooking right there rather than waiting for the full 2 minutes.
5. Once the noodles are tender and glossy-looking rather than sitting in liquid, sprinkle in half the tastemaker packet and stir it through. Fold the other half of the packet closed and set it aside for another day.
6. Take a small separate pan. Add the butter and turn the flame to low.
7. Wait about 30 seconds for the butter to fully melt.
8. Add the minced garlic. Stir constantly and cook for no more than 30 seconds — the moment you can smell it, that's your cue, since garlic burns and turns bitter fast if left even a little longer.
9. Tip the cooked noodles into this garlic butter pan.
10. Using two forks or a fork and spoon, toss and lift the noodles for about 20 seconds so every strand gets coated in the garlic butter.
11. Turn off the stove. Sprinkle chilli flakes on top and serve immediately.

Money Hack: Saving half the tastemaker packet each time means one Maggi packet can quietly stretch across two meals.

Swap It: No butter? A tsp of oil with the garlic works, just slightly less rich.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Butter — ₹4, Garlic — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹20.

Same noodles, completely different mood.

32. Maggi Frittata (Noodle Omelette)

What happens when leftover Maggi meets an egg and refuses to be wasted.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Leftover, clumped-together noodles are exactly what lets this hold together as a pancake once bound with egg — crisp outside, soft and savoury in the middle, nothing like soggy reheated noodles.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup leftover cooked Maggi
- 2 eggs
- Pinch of salt, pepper
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Crack both eggs into a bowl. Beat with a fork for about 20 seconds until smooth and no white streaks remain.
2. Add a pinch of salt and pepper, and stir once more.
3. Add the leftover noodles into the same bowl. Using a fork (or clean fingers), break up any large clumps so the egg can reach every strand, not just the outside of one big lump. This takes about 30 seconds of mixing.

4. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to low-medium — lower than you'd use for a quick omelette, since this needs gentler heat to set all the way through.
5. Wait 30 seconds for the oil to warm.
6. Pour the noodle-egg mixture into the pan. Using the back of your spatula, press it down gently into one even, flat layer.
7. Let it cook completely undisturbed for 3 minutes. Do not touch it. You'll know it's ready when the edges look golden and start pulling slightly away from the sides of the pan.
8. To flip it: slide your spatula all the way underneath to loosen it fully. If you're not confident flipping it mid-air, instead slide it out onto a plate, then place the pan upside-down over the plate, and quickly flip both together so it drops back into the pan the other way up.
9. Cook the second side for 2 more minutes, until equally golden.
10. Slide it onto a plate, cut into wedges if you like, and serve.

Money Hack: This is the single best reason to always cook slightly more Maggi than you think you'll eat.

Swap It: No leftover Maggi? Cook a fresh packet with less water than usual to get a similar dry texture.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi (leftover) — ₹8, Eggs — ₹14. Estimated total — ₹22.

Leftovers deserve better than the bin, and this proves it.

33. Peanut Maggi (Dry, Crunchy Twist)

A nutty, slightly crunchy variation that tastes nothing like the noodles you're used to.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Adding crushed peanuts right at the end, off the heat, keeps them properly crunchy against the soft noodles — every bite alternates between the two textures.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles
- 2 tbsp roasted peanuts, roughly crushed
- 1 tsp oil
- Pinch of chilli flakes
- 1 cup water

METHOD

1. Pour the 1 cup of water into a pan and put it on the stove on high heat. Wait for a full, rolling boil — about 2 minutes.
2. Add the noodles. Set a timer for 2 minutes, stirring every 20 seconds. Check at the 1-minute mark since this smaller amount of water can cook off faster than usual — stop once the noodles are tender and the water is mostly gone.

3. Stir in the tastemaker while the noodles are still hot, so it dissolves and coats evenly.
4. While the noodles cook, take a small handful of roasted peanuts and place them on a cutting board or in your palm. Crush them by pressing down firmly with the back of a spoon, or by pressing your palms together with the peanuts in between — you want a mix of larger pieces and small crumbs, not a fine powder.
5. Once the noodles are done, turn off the stove.
6. Add the crushed peanuts directly into the pan and toss briefly for about 10 seconds — adding them now, off the heat, keeps them crunchy instead of letting them soften.
7. Drizzle 1 teaspoon of oil over the top and sprinkle with chilli flakes. Give it one final toss and serve.

Money Hack: Buy peanuts in bulk from a local vendor rather than small packaged bags — much cheaper per handful.

Swap It: No peanuts? Roasted chana (chickpeas) gives a similar crunch.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Peanuts — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹18.

Crunchy, nutty, and somehow still ready in eight minutes.

34. Maggi Bhel

Cold, tangy, and probably the most unexpected way to eat instant noodles.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle only **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooled, plain boiled noodles have a firmer, slightly chewy bite that holds up well against raw onion and lemon — completely different from the soft, hot noodles you're used to.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles, boiled and cooled (no tastemaker)
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt
- Squeeze of lemon
- A few crushed peanuts (optional)

METHOD

1. Boil water in a kettle or pan — enough to fully cover the noodles.
2. Add the noodles to the boiling water. Do not add the tastemaker packet for this recipe. Cook for 2 minutes, stirring occasionally, until just tender — slightly firmer than you'd normally leave them, since they'll soften a touch more as they

cool.

3. Drain the noodles in a sieve, shaking off as much water as you can.
4. Spread the drained noodles out on a plate, rather than leaving them piled in a bowl — this helps them cool faster and stops them clumping together.
5. Let them sit for about 5 minutes, until they reach room temperature. You can touch them to check — no warmth left.
6. Transfer the cooled noodles to a bowl. Add the chopped onion and tomato.
7. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt over the top.
8. Cut a lemon in half and squeeze one half over the bowl.
9. Using your hands or two spoons, toss everything together thoroughly for about 20 seconds, making sure the noodles are evenly coated rather than sitting in clumps with bare noodle showing.
10. Sprinkle crushed peanuts on top if using, and serve.

Money Hack: This is a smart way to use a Maggi packet whose tastemaker sachet got lost or damaged — you don't need it here at all.

Swap It: No lemon? A small splash of vinegar or a dash of tamarind chutney gives similar tang.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Vegetables — ₹4, Masala/lemon — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹20.

Cold noodles, hot weather, perfect match.

35. Cheesy Maggi (Small Splurge Version)

For the day your budget stretches just a little further than usual.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹32 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A single processed cheese slice melts smoothly into hot noodles rather than seizing into a rubbery clump — a noticeably creamier, richer version of a food you already know well.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles
- 1 processed cheese slice
- 1.5 cups water
- Pinch of chilli flakes (optional)

METHOD

1. Pour about 1¼ cups of water into a pan — slightly less than the usual 1.5 cups, so the finished sauce ends up a little thicker.
2. Put the pan on the stove and turn the flame to high. Wait for a full boil, about 2–3 minutes.

3. Add the noodles and the full tastemaker packet. Cook for 2 minutes, stirring every 20 seconds.
4. Turn off the stove. The noodles should still be hot and just off the heat.
5. Take the cheese slice out of its wrapper. Tear it into 4 or 5 smaller pieces with your hands, rather than adding it whole — smaller pieces melt faster and more evenly.
6. Drop the torn cheese pieces into the hot noodles.
7. Stir continuously with a fork for about 30 seconds, folding the cheese through until every piece has fully melted and disappeared into a creamy coating — you shouldn't see any solid cheese pieces left.
8. Sprinkle chilli flakes on top if you want some heat, and serve immediately — the cheese firms up again as it cools, so eat this one while it's hot.

Money Hack: Buy cheese slices in a pack rather than a block — you can use exactly one slice per recipe without waste, and the rest keeps in the fridge for weeks.

Swap It: No cheese? A tablespoon of milk stirred in at the end gives a creamier texture, even without the cheese flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Cheese slice — ₹15. Estimated total — ₹29.

This is the "treat yourself" recipe of the noodle world.

36. Maggi Soup Bowl

Thinner, brothier, and exactly what you want when you're coming down with something.



TIME: 7 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

More water than usual, added deliberately, turns the same familiar tastemaker into a light, warming broth instead of a thick coating sauce — gentler on a sensitive stomach.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles
- 2.5 cups water (more than usual)
- A few vegetable scraps or frozen peas, if available
- Pinch of pepper

METHOD

1. Pour the full 2.5 cups of water into a pan — noticeably more than a standard packet needs, so use a slightly bigger pan if you have one to avoid it boiling over the sides.
2. Put the pan on the stove and turn the flame to high. Wait for a rolling boil, about 3-4 minutes since there's extra water this time.

3. If using vegetables, add them now and let them cook for 1-2 minutes before anything else goes in.
4. Add the noodles and the tastemaker packet.
5. Set a timer for 2 minutes, stirring occasionally. Because there's so much more water, the noodles will float freely rather than sitting in a thick sauce — that's exactly right.
6. Turn off the stove. Sprinkle pepper over the top.
7. Pour into a bowl and eat straight away while it's properly hot — this recipe loses a lot of its comfort once it cools down.

Money Hack: This is a good way to use vegetable ends and scraps that are too small to cook any other way.

Swap It: No vegetables at all? Plain is still comforting — this recipe works with just noodles and broth.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Vegetables (if used) — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹17.

For the days your body needs something gentler than usual.

37. Maggi Fried Rice Style

Chopped-up noodles tossed like fried rice — same comfort, different texture entirely.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cutting cooked noodles into shorter pieces before stir-frying changes how they behave in the pan — instead of one long, tangled mass, you get bite-sized pieces that toss more like grains of rice.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles, boiled and drained (no tastemaker, or use half)
- ¼ onion, ¼ capsicum, chopped
- 1 egg (optional)
- 1 tsp soy sauce or tomato ketchup
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Boil water in a pan, add the noodles, and cook for 2 minutes without the tastemaker (or use just half if you'd like some flavour).
2. Drain the noodles in a sieve. Rinse briefly under cool running water for about 5 seconds — this stops the cooking and washes off extra starch so the strands stay separate.

3. Tip the noodles onto a cutting board. Using kitchen scissors (easiest) or a knife, cut across the noodles into rough 1-2 inch lengths — you don't need to be precise, just aim for pieces roughly the size of cooked rice grains.
4. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to high. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
5. Add the chopped onion and capsicum. Stir-fry, keeping everything moving constantly, for about 2 minutes until slightly softened but still with some bite.
6. If using egg: push the vegetables to one side of the pan, crack the egg into the empty space, wait 5 seconds, then scramble it with your spoon for about 20 seconds. Mix it through the vegetables.
7. Add the chopped noodles and the soy sauce or ketchup.
8. Toss everything together vigorously on high heat for about 1 minute, using a lifting and turning motion so the sauce coats every piece rather than pooling at the bottom.
9. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: This is a great way to use half a leftover Maggi packet alongside whatever small amounts of vegetables are sitting in your fridge.

Swap It: No soy sauce? Ketchup with a pinch of pepper gives a different but still tasty result.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Vegetables — ₹4, Sauce — ₹2, Egg (optional) — ₹7. Estimated total — ₹20 (₹27 with egg).

Same noodles, completely different personality.

38. Tomato Masala Noodles (No Tastemaker)

For the day your tastemaker sachet is missing but your noodle craving isn't.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A properly cooked onion-tomato base does the flavour job the tastemaker packet usually does, and arguably gives you a more rounded taste than the powdered seasoning ever could.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles (tastemaker not needed)
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
2. Add the chopped onion. Cook for 2 minutes, stirring occasionally, until it turns soft and see-through — this is your flavour base, so don't rush it.

3. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for 2–3 minutes, pressing down on the pieces gently with the back of your spoon every so often to help them break down. You'll know it's ready when the raw tomato smell is gone and it looks soft and saucy rather than firm.
4. Add a pinch of turmeric, a pinch of chilli powder, and a pinch of salt. Stir for about 30 seconds so the spices cook briefly in the oil rather than tasting raw and powdery.
5. Pour in the 1.5 cups of water. Turn the flame up to high and wait for a full, rolling boil — about 2–3 minutes.
6. Add the noodles. Set a timer for 2 minutes, stirring every 20–30 seconds so the masala coats the noodles evenly.
7. Turn off the stove once the timer's up, and serve.

Money Hack: Making your own masala base like this means you can use cheaper, plain noodle blocks instead of always buying the branded flavoured packets.

Swap It: No fresh tomato? A teaspoon of tomato ketchup mixed in works as a decent substitute.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi (noodles only) — ₹10, Vegetables — ₹4, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹18.

Turns out the tastemaker was never the whole story.

39. Maggi Upgrade Bowl with Boiled Egg

Simple noodles, one boiled egg on top, and suddenly it looks like you tried.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹26 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Noodles in a bowl with a halved egg arranged on top look and feel like a meal you planned, even though the only extra step is boiling an egg alongside.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles
- 1 egg
- Pinch of chilli flakes or pepper
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Fill a small pan with enough water to fully cover an egg. Put it on the stove and turn the flame to high.
2. Once it's boiling (big bubbles across the whole surface), gently lower the egg into the water using a spoon.
3. Let it boil for 8 minutes for a fully set yolk, or 6-7 minutes if you like the centre a little soft. Set a timer so you don't lose track.

4. While the egg cooks, start the noodles in a separate pan: pour in 1.5 cups water, bring to a boil on high heat (about 2-3 minutes), add the noodles and tastemaker, and cook for 2 minutes, stirring occasionally.
5. When the egg timer goes off, use a spoon to lift the egg out and drop it into a bowl of cold water. Leave it there for 1-2 minutes — this stops the cooking and makes peeling much easier.
6. Peel the egg: tap it gently all over on a hard surface to crack the shell, then start peeling from the wider end, where there's usually a small air gap to get your fingernail under.
7. Once peeled, place the egg on a cutting board. Using a knife, slice it in half lengthwise in one clean cut — wipe the blade with a tissue between cuts if you're doing more than one egg.
8. Pour the finished noodles into a bowl. Place the egg halves on top rather than stirring them in.
9. Sprinkle chilli flakes or pepper over the top and serve.

Money Hack: Boil three or four eggs at once whenever you're boiling one — extra boiled eggs keep well in the fridge for a few days and upgrade any meal instantly.

Swap It: No time to boil an egg? A fried egg on top works just as well, and takes less time.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Egg — ₹7, Spices — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹22.

Looks like a proper meal. Took the same ten minutes as always.

40. Chilli Garlic Noodle Bowl

Sharp, spicy, and closer to a street-style noodle stall than a packet of instant noodles.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooking garlic and chilli briefly in hot oil before the noodles go in releases a sharper, more aromatic flavour that coats every strand instead of just sitting on top.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 packet Maggi noodles, boiled and drained (tastemaker optional)
- 2 cloves garlic, finely chopped
- 1-2 green chillies, chopped
- 1 tsp soy sauce or vinegar
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Boil water in a pan, add the noodles, and cook for 2 minutes. Drain thoroughly in a sieve and set aside — try to move on to the next step fairly soon so they don't cool and clump.
2. On a cutting board, peel the garlic cloves and chop them very finely into small bits.

3. Chop the green chillies finely too — the smaller the pieces, the more evenly the heat spreads through the dish.
4. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium-high. Wait about 30 seconds until the oil looks hot and shimmery.
5. Add the chopped garlic and chilli together. Stir constantly with your spoon, without stopping, for about 30 seconds — you're watching for the garlic to turn pale gold at the edges, and listening for a steady sizzle.
6. The instant the garlic reaches that pale gold colour, add the drained noodles immediately — waiting even a few extra seconds risks burning the garlic and making it bitter.
7. Add the soy sauce or vinegar.
8. Toss everything together vigorously on high heat for about 1 minute, lifting and turning constantly so the garlic and chilli spread evenly through the noodles rather than staying clumped in one spot.
9. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: Buying garlic as a whole bulb rather than pre-peeled pods is significantly cheaper and lasts for weeks.

Swap It: No soy sauce or vinegar? A squeeze of lemon at the end adds a similar sharpness.

COST BREAKDOWN

Maggi — ₹14, Garlic/chilli — ₹3, Sauce — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹19.

This one's got a bit of an attitude. In a good way.

Rice & One-Pot Meals

Rice is one of the cheapest, most flexible bases you can cook with. Every method below spells out exactly what to do at each moment — how long to wait, what the water should look like, when to cover the pot and when not to — so nothing is left to guesswork.

41. Simple Vegetable Pulao

One pot, whatever vegetables you have, and rice that actually tastes like something.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹28 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU’LL LOVE IT

Toasting the rice briefly in oil before any water goes in coats each grain and helps it cook up fluffy and separate rather than sticky.

INGREDIENTS

- ¾ cup rice, rinsed
- 1 small onion, sliced

- ½ cup mixed vegetables (peas, carrot, beans — whatever you have)
- 1 small piece cinnamon, 1 clove, 1 bay leaf (optional, if you have whole spices)
- Pinch of salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Put the rice in a bowl. Fill it with water, swirl it around with your hand for a few seconds, then carefully pour the cloudy water out while holding the rice back with your fingers. Repeat this 2 more times, until the water you pour out looks mostly clear instead of milky-white. Drain fully.
2. Put a pot on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium.
3. If using whole spices, add them now. Wait about 15 seconds — you'll smell the cinnamon and see the bay leaf curl slightly at the edges.
4. Add the sliced onion. Cook for about 3 minutes, stirring occasionally, until it turns soft and just golden at the edges.
5. Add the mixed vegetables. Cook for 2 minutes, stirring now and then.
6. Add the drained rice. Stir gently for about 1 minute, making sure every grain gets coated in the oil — this toasting step is what gives pulao its texture.
7. Add the 1.5 cups of water and a pinch of salt. Stir once.
8. Turn the flame up to high and wait for it to reach a full boil — big bubbles across the surface, about 2 minutes.
9. As soon as it's boiling, put the lid on tightly and turn the flame down to the lowest setting.
10. Set a timer for 12 minutes. Do not lift the lid during this time, not even to peek — every peek lets out steam the rice needs.
11. When the timer goes off, turn off the stove but leave the lid on. Let it rest undisturbed for 5 more minutes.
12. Remove the lid. Using a fork, fluff the rice gently by lifting and turning it, rather than stirring hard, so you don't mash the grains.

Money Hack: Frozen mixed vegetables (if available and affordable) are often cheaper per use than buying several fresh vegetables just for one recipe.

Swap It: No whole spices? A pinch of garam masala added with the vegetables gives a similar warmth.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹8, Vegetables — ₹12, Spices/oil — ₹4, Onion — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹26.

Smells like a proper kitchen. Took twenty minutes and one pot.

42. Egg Fried Rice

The one-pot classic — leftover rice, an egg, and whatever vegetables are lying around.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹24 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Rice that's had time in the fridge has dried out just enough to fry up separate and slightly crisp, instead of clumping into a sticky mass the way fresh rice would.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice (a day old works best)
- 1 egg
- ¼ onion, ¼ capsicum, chopped (or any vegetable)
- 1 tsp soy sauce (or ketchup)
- Pinch of pepper, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Take the cold rice and break up any large clumps with your fingers or a fork before it goes near the pan — this is much easier to do now than once it's hot in the pan.
2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to high. Wait about 30 seconds until the oil looks hot and shimmery.
3. Add the chopped onion and capsicum. Stir-fry, keeping everything moving, for about 1 minute.
4. Push the vegetables over to one side of the pan with your spatula, creating an empty space on the other side.
5. Crack the egg into that empty space. Wait 5 seconds, then scramble it with the edge of your spatula for about 20 seconds.
6. Mix the scrambled egg through the vegetables.
7. Add the rice. Using a folding and tossing motion — lifting from the bottom and turning it over, rather than stirring in circles — mix everything together for about 30 seconds.
8. Add the soy sauce, pepper, and salt.
9. Continue tossing on high heat for about 2 minutes. You're looking for a few grains to pick up a light golden colour where they touch the hot pan directly.
10. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: Day-old rice fries much better than fresh — it's drier and doesn't turn mushy. Worth deliberately cooking extra rice the night before.

Swap It: No soy sauce? A dash of vinegar and a little extra salt gets you close.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice (leftover) — ₹6, Egg — ₹7, Vegetables — ₹4, Sauce/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹20.

Leftover rice's best possible future.

43. South Indian Lemon Rice

Tangy, light, and needs almost no vegetables to taste complete.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Frying mustard seeds briefly in hot oil releases far more flavour than sprinkling them in raw — that flavoured oil then coats the rice, and the fresh lemon juice at the end makes it taste bright and finished.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice, cooled slightly
- Juice of 1 lemon
- Pinch of mustard seeds, turmeric
- A few peanuts (optional)
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- 1 tsp oil
- Salt to taste

METHOD

1. If your rice is piping hot, let it sit for a few minutes to cool slightly — hot rice breaks apart and turns mushy when tossed, while slightly cooled rice holds its shape.

2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
3. Add a pinch of mustard seeds. Wait for them to pop — a clear crackling sound, about 15 seconds.
4. Add the chilli and peanuts if using. Cook for about 1 minute, until the peanuts turn a shade darker.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric. Stir for just a few seconds — long enough to see the oil turn yellow, not long enough to let it sit and taste raw.
6. Add the cooked rice. Using a folding motion — turning gently from underneath rather than stirring hard — mix it through the tempering so the yellow colour spreads evenly.
7. Turn off the stove completely before the next step — this matters, since cooking lemon juice even briefly dulls its brightness.
8. Cut the lemon in half. Squeeze both halves over the rice. Add a pinch of salt.
9. Toss well, then taste a small spoonful (careful, it may still be warm) — add a touch more lemon or salt if it needs it.

Money Hack: This is a great way to use rice that's slightly dried out from sitting in the fridge — the lemon and tempering bring it back to life.

Swap It: No mustard seeds? Cumin seeds work as a substitute in the tempering.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹6, Lemon — ₹3, Peanuts — ₹3, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹16.

Tangy enough to wake up even the most tired taste buds.

44. One-Pot Tomato Rice

Rich, slightly tangy, and cooks entirely in one pot with almost no supervision.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooking rice directly in a tomato-onion base means every grain absorbs that flavour as it swells and softens, rather than just having sauce sitting on top.

INGREDIENTS

- ¾ cup rice, rinsed
- 1 onion, chopped
- 2 tomatoes, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Rinse the rice: fill the bowl with water, swirl, pour out the cloudy water while holding the rice back, and repeat 2-3 times until the water runs clear. Drain fully.
2. Put a pot on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.

3. Cook for 2–3 minutes, stirring occasionally, until soft and translucent.
4. Add the chopped tomatoes. Cook for 4–5 minutes, pressing them gently with the back of your spoon every minute or so to help them break down. You’re watching for the pieces to lose their firm shape and turn into a soft, jammy mass, with a little oil visible at the edges — that’s your sign the raw tomato taste is gone.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir for about 1 minute.
6. Add the drained rice and stir well so every grain gets coated in the tomato base.
7. Add the 1.5 cups of water and stir once more.
8. Turn the flame up to high and wait for a full boil, about 2 minutes.
9. Cover tightly with a lid and reduce the flame to the lowest setting. Set a timer for 12 minutes. Don’t lift the lid during this time.
10. When the timer goes off, turn off the stove and let it rest, covered, for 5 more minutes.
11. Remove the lid and fluff gently with a fork before serving.

Money Hack: This is one of the best uses for tomatoes that have gone a bit too soft to eat raw.

Swap It: No fresh tomatoes? Two tablespoons of tomato purée or ketchup mixed with a little water works as a substitute.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹8, Tomatoes — ₹6, Onion — ₹2, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹20.

One pot, minimal effort, maximum comfort.

45. Comfort Khichdi

Rice and dal cooked together into one soft, warm, everything-is-okay-now bowl.



TIME: 25 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Khichdi wants the rice and dal to fully merge into a soft, porridge-like texture, which is why the water quantity here is deliberately higher and the cooking time longer than a typical rice dish.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup rice, rinsed
- ¼ cup yellow moong dal or toor dal, rinsed
- Pinch of turmeric, salt
- 1 tsp ghee or oil
- Pinch of cumin seeds
- 2.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Rinse the rice and dal together in a bowl: fill with water, swirl, pour out the cloudy water while holding everything back with your fingers, repeat 2 times until it runs mostly clear.

2. Put a pot on the stove, add the ghee, and turn the flame to medium. Wait about 20 seconds for it to melt.
3. Add the cumin seeds. Wait for them to sizzle — about 10 seconds.
4. Add the rinsed rice and dal together. Stir for about 1 minute so both are lightly coated in the ghee — you'll notice a faint nutty smell starting.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, a pinch of salt, and the full 2.5 cups of water.
6. Turn the flame up to high and bring it to a boil — about 3 minutes.
7. Once boiling, turn the flame down to a gentle simmer (low-medium) and cover the pot partially — leave a small gap for steam to escape, don't seal it completely like you would for plain rice.
8. Set a timer for 18 minutes. Stir every 3–4 minutes with a spoon so nothing sticks to the bottom.
9. Check at the 18-minute mark: the rice and dal should have both softened completely and lost their separate shapes, and the whole mixture should look thick but still easy to spoon — almost like a savoury porridge.
10. If it's thicker than you'd like, stir in a small splash of hot water. Turn off the stove and serve warm.

Money Hack: Cook a bigger batch — khichdi reheats well the next day with a splash of water stirred in.

Swap It: No dal on hand? Plain rice porridge with just cumin and salt is still soothing, if less protein-rich.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹5, Dal — ₹6, Ghee/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹15.

This is what being taken care of tastes like.

46. Simple Peas Pulao

Sweet peas, fragrant rice, and barely any effort involved.



TIME: 18 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Peas are naturally sweet, and cooking them briefly in ghee before the rice goes in brings that sweetness out even more.

INGREDIENTS

- $\frac{3}{4}$ cup rice, rinsed
- $\frac{1}{2}$ cup peas (fresh or frozen)
- 1 small piece cinnamon or 1 clove (optional)
- Pinch of salt
- 1 tsp ghee or oil
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Rinse the rice in a bowl: fill with water, swirl, pour off the cloudy water while holding the rice back, repeat 2-3 times until it runs clear. Drain fully.
2. Put a pot on the stove, add the ghee, and turn the flame to medium.
3. If using whole spices, add them now and wait about 10 seconds until fragrant.

4. Add the peas — if frozen, no need to thaw first, just tip them straight in. Cook for about 1 minute, stirring, just to take the raw edge off.
5. Add the drained rice. Stir for about 1 minute so it's evenly coated in the ghee.
6. Add the water and a pinch of salt. Stir once.
7. Turn the flame up to high and bring to a full boil — about 2 minutes.
8. Cover tightly with a lid and turn the flame down to the lowest setting. Set a timer for 12 minutes. Don't lift the lid.
9. When the timer goes off, turn off the stove and let it sit, still covered, for 5 more minutes.
10. Remove the lid and fluff gently with a fork, being careful not to mash the peas.

Money Hack: Frozen peas are available cheaply year-round and don't need peeling — a small bag lasts many meals.

Swap It: No whole spices? A pinch of garam masala works as a simpler substitute.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹8, Peas — ₹6, Ghee/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹18.

Sweet, soft, and quietly one of the easiest things you'll ever cook.

47. Quick Rajma Rice

A simplified take on the North Indian classic, using boiled or canned kidney beans.



TIME: 15 min (with pre-boiled rajma) **COST:** ₹26 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Starting with already-boiled rajma means all your time goes into building a proper masala base rather than waiting for beans to soften.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup boiled rajma (kidney beans) — home-cooked or canned
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups cooked rice, to serve

METHOD

1. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
2. Cook for about 4 minutes, stirring occasionally — you want it to turn properly golden-brown, not just soft, since that deeper colour gives the gravy more flavour.

3. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for 3–4 minutes, mashing gently with your spoon, until it fully breaks down into a soft, jammy texture with no firm pieces left.
4. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, garam masala, and salt. Stir for about 1 minute.
5. Add the boiled rajma along with a small splash of water — enough to loosen everything into a gravy, not a dry sauté.
6. Turn the flame down to low-medium and let it simmer for 8–10 minutes, stirring occasionally.
7. Partway through, press a few beans gently against the side of the pan with the back of your spoon — this releases starch and naturally thickens the gravy.
8. Turn off the stove once the gravy looks thick and well combined. Serve hot, ladled generously over rice.

Money Hack: Boil a large batch of rajma on a free afternoon (soak overnight, pressure cook or boil until soft) and freeze in portions — this turns a slow dish into a 15-minute one anytime.

Swap It: No rajma? Boiled chickpeas or even boiled black-eyed peas work with the same masala base.

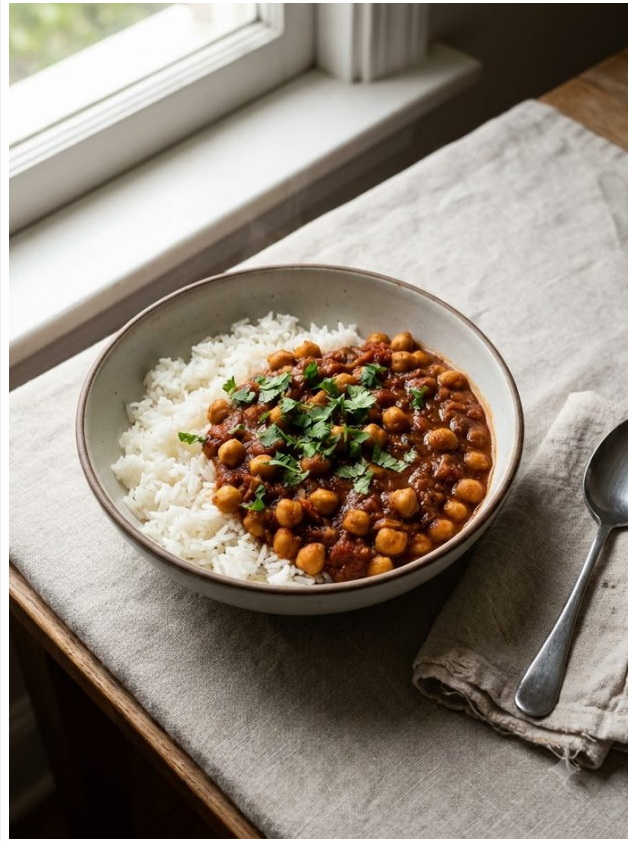
COST BREAKDOWN

Rajma (boiled) — ₹12, Vegetables — ₹5, Spices/oil — ₹4, Rice — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹26.

All the comfort of a slow-cooked dish, none of the actual waiting.

48. Chana Masala Rice Bowl

Spiced chickpeas over rice — filling, protein-rich, and genuinely tasty.



TIME: 15 min (with pre-boiled chana) **COST:** ₹24 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Chickpeas hold their shape a little more firmly than kidney beans, giving you distinct chunks in every spoonful rather than a fully merged gravy.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup boiled chickpeas (chana)
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups cooked rice, to serve

METHOD

1. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
2. Cook for about 4 minutes, stirring occasionally, until it turns a proper deep gold colour.

3. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for 3–4 minutes, mashing gently against the pan as it cooks, until it turns soft and glossy with no firm pieces left.
4. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, garam masala, and salt. Stir for about 1 minute.
5. Add the boiled chickpeas along with a small splash of water.
6. Turn the flame down and let it simmer gently for about 8 minutes, stirring occasionally.
7. Partway through, press a few chickpeas gently against the side of the pan with your spoon — this thickens the gravy naturally.
8. Turn off the stove once thick and well combined. Serve hot over rice.

Money Hack: Chickpeas are one of the cheapest protein sources available — buying dried chickpeas and boiling your own works out far cheaper than canned.

Swap It: No garam masala? A pinch of cumin powder and coriander powder makes a reasonable substitute blend.

COST BREAKDOWN

Chickpeas (boiled) — ₹10, Vegetables — ₹5, Spices/oil — ₹4, Rice — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹24.

Filling enough to make you forget how little it cost.

49. Budget Schezwan Fried Rice

A milder, cheaper take on the spicy Indo-Chinese favourite.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹26 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooking garlic hot and fast, right at the start, recreates the sharp, tangy heat of real Schezwan sauce using nothing more exotic than pantry basics.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice (day-old, if possible)
- ¼ onion, ¼ capsicum, chopped
- 2 cloves garlic, finely chopped
- 1 tsp ketchup, ½ tsp chilli sauce or chilli powder
- 1 tsp soy sauce (optional)
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to high. Wait about 30 seconds until the oil looks hot and shimmery — hotter than most other rice recipes in this book.
2. Add the chopped garlic alone first. Stir constantly, without stopping, for 20–30 seconds — watch for it to turn pale gold and smell fragrant. Pull it off that heat

level immediately once it does; another few seconds and it burns.

3. Add the chopped onion and capsicum right away. Stir-fry, keeping everything moving, for about 1 minute.
4. Add the rice, breaking up any clumps as you mix it in.
5. Add the ketchup, chilli sauce, and soy sauce.
6. Toss everything together vigorously on high heat for about 2 minutes — you're looking for the rice to pick up an even reddish tint and a few grains to show light charring where they touch the pan directly.
7. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: Small sachets of chilli sauce or ketchup (the kind that come with delivery orders) are perfect for recipes like this — save them instead of throwing them away.

Swap It: No chilli sauce? A pinch of dried red chilli flakes mixed into the ketchup gets you close.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹6, Vegetables — ₹4, Garlic — ₹2, Sauces/oil — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹17.

Cheaper than delivery, spicier than you expected.

50. Curry Leaf & Peanut Rice

A South Indian-style rice that's fragrant, nutty, and needs very few ingredients.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Curry leaves release almost all of their fragrance the moment they hit hot oil — a few seconds of sizzling unlocks a smell raw curry leaves simply don't have.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice
- A small handful curry leaves (fresh, if you can find them)
- 2 tbsp peanuts
- Pinch of mustard seeds, turmeric
- 1 tsp oil
- Salt to taste

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
2. Add a pinch of mustard seeds. Wait for the popping and crackling sound — about 10-15 seconds.

3. Add the curry leaves right away — they'll sizzle loudly and might spit a little, so stand back slightly if needed, that's completely normal.
4. Add the peanuts at the same time. Cook for about 1 minute, until the peanuts turn a shade darker and the curry leaves look slightly crisp.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric. Stir for just a few seconds to let its colour bloom in the hot oil.
6. Add the cooked rice. Using a folding motion — turning gently from underneath — mix it through so the tempering distributes evenly without crushing the peanuts or curry leaves.
7. Add salt to taste, toss once more, and serve while still warm.

Money Hack: Dried curry leaves (sold in small packets) work almost as well as fresh and last much longer without going bad.

Swap It: No curry leaves at all? Skip them — the mustard seeds and peanuts still give a good tempering flavour on their own.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹6, Peanuts — ₹4, Curry leaves/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

Simple ingredients, but the smell alone makes it feel special.

51. Budget Paneer Pulao

A small amount of paneer goes a long way when it's tucked into a full pot of rice.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹32 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Frying the paneer briefly before it goes anywhere near the rice gives it a light golden crust that holds its texture rather than turning soft and forgettable once mixed in.

INGREDIENTS

- ¾ cup rice, rinsed
- 100g paneer, cubed
- ¼ onion, sliced
- ½ cup peas or mixed vegetables
- Pinch of garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Cut the paneer into small cubes, about the size of a dice, using a knife on a cutting board.
2. Rinse the rice: fill with water, swirl, pour off the cloudy water while holding the rice back, repeat 2-3 times until it runs clear. Drain.

3. Put a pot on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium.
4. Add the paneer cubes in a single layer, spread apart so they're not touching. Let them sit undisturbed for 45 seconds — don't move them yet, this is what gives them a proper golden crust.
5. Turn each cube over with a spoon and let the other side cook for another 30-40 seconds, until lightly golden. Remove the paneer to a plate and set aside.
6. In the same pot (no need to clean it — the browned bits add flavour), add the onion. Cook for about 2 minutes until soft.
7. Add the peas and cook for 1 minute.
8. Add the drained rice, garam masala, and a pinch of salt. Stir for about 1 minute to coat the rice in the remaining oil and spice.
9. Add the water, stir once, and turn the flame up to high. Wait for a full boil, about 2 minutes.
10. Cover tightly and turn the flame down to the lowest setting. Set a timer for 12 minutes. Don't lift the lid.
11. At the 10-minute mark of the timer, quickly lift the lid, scatter the fried paneer over the top of the rice, and re-cover immediately — this lets the paneer warm through gently in the last 2 minutes of steam rather than cooking further and toughening.
12. When the timer ends, turn off the stove and let it rest, covered, for 5 minutes before fluffing gently with a fork.

Money Hack: Buy paneer in the smallest pack available (100g) if you're only using it occasionally — it doesn't keep well once opened, so there's no benefit to buying more than you'll use soon.

Swap It: No paneer? Boiled, cubed potato makes a different but still satisfying version.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹8, Paneer — ₹16, Vegetables — ₹5, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹33.

A little paneer, spread across a whole pot, still feels like a treat.

52. Egg Curry Rice Bowl

Boiled eggs simmered in a simple tomato-onion gravy, served over rice.



TIME: 18 min **COST:** ₹28 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Once boiled and simmered briefly in a proper masala gravy, eggs take on flavour the way meat would in a similar curry, cooking in a fraction of the time.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs, boiled and peeled
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups cooked rice, to serve

METHOD

1. If you haven't already boiled your eggs: place them in a small pan of water, bring to a boil on high heat, then boil for 8-9 minutes. Transfer to a bowl of cold water for 2 minutes, then peel.
2. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
3. Cook for about 4 minutes, stirring occasionally, until deep golden-brown — don't

rush this step, since a well-browned onion is most of what gives this simple gravy real depth.

4. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for 3–4 minutes, mashing gently, until it fully breaks down into a soft, glossy mixture.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, garam masala, and salt. Stir for about 1 minute.
6. Add a small splash of water to loosen the mixture into a gravy, and let it simmer for 3–4 minutes.
7. Using a knife, halve the boiled eggs lengthwise — wipe the blade with a tissue between cuts if doing more than one, to keep the yolk from smearing.
8. Nestle the egg halves into the gravy, cut-side up, and spoon a little sauce over the yolks.
9. Let them warm through gently for 1–2 minutes without stirring vigorously, which can break the yolks apart and cloud the gravy.
10. Turn off the stove and serve over rice.

Money Hack: Boiling four eggs instead of two, and saving the extras for another recipe, saves you from heating water twice in one day.

Swap It: No garam masala? A pinch each of cumin and coriander powder makes a decent substitute.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Vegetables — ₹5, Spices/oil — ₹4, Rice — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹28.

Saucy, warm, and a genuinely good reason to boil an extra egg.

53. Masala Rice with Roasted Papad

Simple spiced rice, made complete with the crunch of a roasted papad on the side.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A crisp, freshly roasted papad adds a completely different texture and a toasty aroma that turns “just rice” into something that feels properly finished.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice
- ¼ onion, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1-2 papads

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
2. Cook for about 2 minutes, until soft.
3. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir for a few seconds.

4. Add the cooked rice and toss well, folding it through the spice mix until every grain looks evenly coated and warmed through — about 1 minute.
5. Turn off the stove and set the rice aside, covered, to keep it warm.
6. To roast the papad over an open flame: hold it with tongs about an inch above the flame, and keep turning it constantly and evenly. You're watching for it to puff up slightly and darken evenly in small spots — this takes about 15–20 seconds per side.
7. If using a dry pan instead: put it on medium heat, place the papad in, and press it down firmly and evenly with a spatula, flipping every few seconds so it doesn't scorch in one spot before the rest crisps.
8. Once evenly roasted (it should look puffed and feel crisp, not floppy), serve the rice hot with the papad on the side, or crumble it over the top.

Money Hack: A packet of papads lasts a long time and costs very little per piece — always worth keeping a few on hand.

Swap It: No papad? A few crushed plain crackers on top gives a similar crunch.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹6, Onion/spices — ₹4, Papad — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹13.

One crunchy papad can save an otherwise boring bowl of rice.

54. Simple Dal-Chawal

Rice and dal, served separately rather than cooked together — the other great Indian comfort combination.



TIME: 25 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU’LL LOVE IT

The tempering poured over the finished dal at the end is what elevates this from “boiled lentils” to something genuinely craveable — don’t skip that final step even when you’re tired.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup rice
- ¼ cup toor or moong dal
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, cumin seeds, salt
- 1 tsp ghee or oil
- 2.5 cups water (for the dal)
- 1 cup water (for the rice)

METHOD

1. Rinse the rice in a small pan: fill with water, swirl, pour off the cloudy water, repeat once or twice. Add the 1 cup of fresh water, put it on the stove on high heat, and bring to a boil, about 2 minutes.

2. Once boiling, cover, turn the flame down to low, and let it simmer for 12 minutes. Then turn off the heat and leave it covered to stay warm — set this pan aside.
3. In a separate pot, rinse the dal the same way. Add the 2.5 cups of water and a pinch of turmeric.
4. Put this pot on the stove on high heat and bring it to a boil, about 3 minutes.
5. Turn the flame down to a simmer. Cook for about 15 minutes, mashing gently with the back of your spoon every few minutes — you're aiming for it to break down into a slightly thick, soupy consistency.
6. While the dal simmers, make the tempering: heat the ghee in a small separate pan on medium heat, add the cumin seeds, and wait about 10 seconds for them to sizzle.
7. Add the chopped onion and tomato to the tempering pan. Cook for about 2 minutes, until soft.
8. Once the dal has reached the consistency you want, pour the hot tempering (onion, tomato, and all the ghee) directly into the dal pot — it will sizzle loudly on contact, which is exactly right, that sizzle releases the aroma straight into the dal.
9. Add salt to taste, stir once, and serve the dal hot, ladled generously over the warm rice.

Money Hack: Cook a bigger batch of dal — it keeps for a couple of days in the fridge and reheats well with a splash of water.

Swap It: No fresh tomato? Skip it — a simple cumin-onion tempering is still deeply comforting on its own.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹5, Dal — ₹6, Vegetables/spices — ₹5, Ghee — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹18.

This is the meal that quietly fixes a bad day.

55. Carrot & Coconut Rice

A lightly sweet, fragrant rice dish that feels a little different from the usual.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Grating the carrot means it cooks through almost instantly and blends seamlessly into the rice, giving you a soft, evenly sweet character throughout rather than occasional sweet bites.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice
- 1 small carrot, grated
- 1 tbsp desiccated coconut (or fresh, if available)
- Pinch of mustard seeds, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Wash the carrot under running water. Using a grater, grate it on a plate — hold the carrot firmly against the grater and move it up and down until it's fully shredded.
2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.

3. Add a pinch of mustard seeds. Wait for the popping sound, about 10–15 seconds.
4. Add the grated carrot. Cook for about 2 minutes, stirring frequently, until it softens and turns slightly translucent at the edges rather than staying raw and firm.
5. Add the cooked rice, the coconut, and a pinch of salt.
6. Using a folding motion, toss everything together gently for about 1 minute, making sure the carrot and coconut spread evenly rather than clumping in one spot.
7. Cook for 1 more minute just to warm everything through evenly, then turn off the stove and serve while still warm.

Money Hack: A small packet of desiccated coconut lasts a long time in the pantry and works in both sweet and savoury recipes.

Swap It: No coconut? Skip it — the carrot and tempering alone still make a nice, lightly sweet rice dish.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice — ₹6, Carrot — ₹4, Coconut — ₹4, Spices/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹17.

A little different, a little sweet, still done in fifteen minutes.

Roti/Bread-Based Meals

Roti and bread are both cheap, both filling, and both far more flexible than most people give them credit for. Every method here spells out each small action — how to warm a roti so it doesn't crack, how to know a filling is properly cooked — so nothing is assumed.

56. Roti Pizza

Leftover roti, whatever toppings you've got, and a hot pan — that's the whole recipe.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A covered pan traps enough heat and steam to melt the cheese and soften the vegetables at the same time — without the lid, the top stays cold while the bottom risks burning.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or chapati (leftover works well)
- 1 tsp ketchup or tomato chutney
- ¼ onion, ¼ capsicum, thinly sliced
- 1 cheese slice or a sprinkle of grated cheese (optional)
- Pinch of oregano or chilli flakes

METHOD

1. Lay the roti flat on a plate. Using a spoon, spread the ketchup or chutney over it in a thin, even layer, right to the edges.
2. On a cutting board, slice the onion and capsicum as thinly as you can manage.
3. Scatter the sliced onion and capsicum evenly over the sauce-covered roti.
4. If using cheese, place the slice on top now, or sprinkle the grated cheese evenly across the surface.
5. Put a dry pan on the stove and turn the flame to low — lower than usual, since anything higher will burn the base before the toppings soften.
6. Carefully slide the topped roti into the pan.
7. Cover immediately with a lid. Set a timer for 3 minutes and don't lift the lid during this time — the trapped steam is doing the cooking.
8. After 3 minutes, lift the lid and check: the cheese should look fully melted and the vegetables slightly softened. If not quite there, cover again and cook for 1 more minute.
9. Turn off the stove. Using a spatula, slide the pizza out onto a plate. While it's still hot, sprinkle oregano or chilli flakes on top. Cut into wedges and eat.

Money Hack: This is the best possible use for a roti that's gone a little too dry to eat plain.

Swap It: No cheese? A well-seasoned topping of vegetables and chutney is still tasty without it.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Toppings — ₹8, Cheese (optional) — ₹8. Estimated total — ₹13 (₹21 with cheese).

Pizza logic, roti budget.

57. Vegetable Roti Roll

Stir-fried vegetables wrapped in a warm roti — portable, filling, and endlessly customisable.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooking the vegetables until any extra moisture has cooked away is what keeps the roti from getting soggy — a wet filling seeps in and makes it fall apart within minutes.

INGREDIENTS

- 1-2 roti or chapati
- ¼ onion, ¼ capsicum, ¼ carrot, thinly sliced
- Pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 1 tsp ketchup or chutney

METHOD

1. On a cutting board, slice the onion, capsicum, and carrot thinly, trying to keep all the pieces roughly the same size so they cook evenly together.

2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium-high. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
3. Add all the sliced vegetables together. Stir-fry constantly, keeping them moving, for 3–4 minutes — you’re watching for them to soften while still holding a slight bite, with any liquid in the pan mostly cooked away by the time you finish.
4. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Toss to coat evenly, then turn off the stove.
5. Take the roti. Warm it by holding it directly over a low flame for a few seconds on each side using tongs, turning until it feels soft and bendy. (No open flame? Warm it in a dry pan for about 20 seconds per side instead.)
6. Lay the warm roti flat. Using a spoon, spread the chutney or ketchup down the centre.
7. Pile the cooked vegetables on top of the chutney, in a line down the middle rather than spread edge to edge.
8. Fold the bottom edge of the roti up and over the filling first.
9. Continue rolling from one side to the other, tucking in tightly as you go so nothing spills out the ends.

Money Hack: This recipe is a great way to use up small leftover bits of several vegetables that aren’t individually enough for a full dish.

Swap It: No fresh vegetables? Leftover bhurji or dal also rolls up well in a roti.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹8, Vegetables — ₹8, Spices/oil/chutney — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹20.

Handheld, filling, and doesn’t require sitting still to eat.

58. Sweet Coconut Stuffed Roti

A simple, lightly sweet stuffed flatbread for when you want something a little different.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One tawa **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Not overfilling the dough and sealing the edges firmly before rolling is what stops the jaggery from bursting through while you roll it out.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup atta (wheat flour)
- 3 tbsp desiccated coconut
- 2 tbsp jaggery, grated or crushed
- Pinch of cardamom powder (optional)
- Water, as needed
- 1 tsp ghee, for cooking

METHOD

1. Put the atta in a bowl. Add water a little at a time — about 1 tablespoon at a time — kneading with both hands between each addition, until you get a soft, smooth dough. This dough should feel slightly softer than usual roti dough.
2. Cover the bowl with a plate or cloth and let it rest for 5 minutes — this relaxes the dough and makes rolling easier later.

3. While it rests, make the filling: put the coconut, jaggery (grated or crushed finely), and cardamom into a small bowl. Mix well with a spoon until combined.
4. Divide the rested dough into 2 balls, slightly larger than you'd make for a plain roti.
5. Take one ball. Flatten it in your palm into a small disc, about the size of your palm.
6. Place about 1 tablespoon of the coconut-jaggery filling in the centre — don't overfill, since too much filling makes sealing difficult.
7. Bring the edges of the dough up and over the filling, gathering them together at the top like a small pouch, and pinch them firmly together to seal completely, with no gaps.
8. Gently flatten the sealed ball with your palm, then using a rolling pin, roll it out carefully — apply light, even pressure, and stop immediately if you feel resistance or see the filling starting to poke through.
9. Put your tawa on the stove and turn the flame to medium. Wait about 1 minute for it to heat.
10. Place the rolled roti on the tawa. Watch closely — if you see any dark, wet patches forming, that's leaking jaggery, so move the roti to a slightly cooler part of the pan.
11. Cook for about 2 minutes, add a little ghee, flip, add ghee to the other side, and cook for 2 more minutes, until golden-brown spots appear on both sides. Repeat steps 5-11 with the second ball.

Money Hack: This filling also works well as a spread on plain bread if you don't want to make dough at all.

Swap It: No jaggery? Sugar works, though jaggery gives a deeper, more caramel-like flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Atta — ₹6, Coconut — ₹5, Jaggery — ₹3, Ghee — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹18.

Sweet enough to feel like dessert, simple enough to make on a Tuesday.

59. Crispy Roti Chips with Chutney

Leftover roti, cut up and fried crisp — a snack that costs almost nothing.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹10 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Dry, slightly hard rotis fries up better than soft, fresh roti — there's less moisture inside to fight against, so it crisps properly instead of turning greasy and limp.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 leftover rotis, cut into triangles
- 1 tsp oil
- Pinch of chaat masala or salt
- Ketchup or chutney, to serve

METHOD

1. Put each roti flat on a cutting board. Using a knife, cut it into 4-6 triangles, trying to keep them roughly even in size.
2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds until it looks shimmery.
3. Place the roti triangles into the pan in a single layer, without them overlapping — if they don't all fit, fry in two batches rather than crowding the pan.

4. Let them fry for about 2 minutes. Check the underside by lifting one with your spatula — you want an even golden-brown colour.
5. Flip each piece over and fry the second side for another 2 minutes, checking the same way.
6. Once both sides are golden and you notice the sizzling sound has become a little quieter, remove them from the pan onto a plate.
7. While still hot, sprinkle chaat masala or salt over them — seasoning sticks much better to hot, slightly oily chips.
8. Serve immediately with ketchup or chutney for dipping.

Money Hack: This is specifically designed for rotis that have gone hard or dry — don't throw those away, this is exactly what they're for.

Swap It: No chaat masala? Plain salt and a squeeze of lemon works just as well.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti (leftover) — ₹6, Oil/masala — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹10.

Turns "this roti is too dry to eat" into an actual snack.

60. Curd Roti Wrap

A cool, tangy wrap that needs no cooking beyond warming the roti.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan (optional, to warm roti) **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Whisking the curd thoroughly before spreading it is what turns lumpy, watery curd into something smooth that spreads and stays evenly distributed once rolled.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or chapati
- ½ cup curd, whisked smooth
- ¼ cucumber or onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt

METHOD

1. Put the curd into a bowl. Using a fork or small whisk, whisk it vigorously for about 30 seconds — keep going until it looks smooth and slightly loose, with no lumps remaining.
2. If you'd like the roti soft and warm, warm it now by holding it over a low flame for a few seconds on each side, or in a dry pan for about 20 seconds per side.

3. Lay the roti flat. Using a spoon, spread the whisked curd evenly over it, leaving a small bare border around the edge so it doesn't squeeze out once rolled.
4. Finely chop the cucumber or onion on a cutting board, and scatter it evenly over the curd.
5. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt over the top.
6. Starting from one edge, roll the roti up firmly and tightly, rather than loosely, so it holds together when you pick it up.

Money Hack: This is a good way to use curd that's slightly more sour than you'd want to eat plain — the tang works well here.

Swap It: No cucumber? Grated carrot or thinly sliced onion both work well instead.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Curd — ₹8, Vegetables — ₹2, Masala — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹16.

Cool, tangy, and barely counts as cooking.

61. Simple Missi Roti

A spiced, besan-enriched roti that's a little more flavourful than the everyday kind.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One tawa **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Besan doesn't develop gluten the way wheat flour does, so this roti ends up slightly more crumbly and rustic, with a deeper, nuttier flavour from the gram flour mixed directly into the dough.

INGREDIENTS

- $\frac{3}{4}$ cup atta (wheat flour)
- $\frac{1}{4}$ cup besan (gram flour)
- $\frac{1}{4}$ onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of carom seeds (ajwain) or cumin seeds, red chilli powder, salt
- Water, as needed
- 1 tsp oil, for cooking

METHOD

1. Put the atta and besan together in a bowl. Mix them together dry with your hand or a spoon first, before adding anything wet.
2. Add the chopped onion, carom seeds, chilli powder, and a pinch of salt. Mix through the dry flour.

3. Add water gradually, about 1 tablespoon at a time, kneading with both hands between each addition. This dough often needs a bit more water than plain atta dough, so don't be surprised if it takes 5-6 tablespoons total to reach a firm, smooth consistency.
4. Divide the dough into 2 balls.
5. Take one ball and roll it out on a lightly floured surface, using gentle, even pressure and rotating the dough often — this dough can tear more easily than plain wheat dough at the edges, so go slowly.
6. Put your tawa on the stove and turn the flame to medium. Wait about 1 minute for it to heat.
7. Place the rolled roti on the tawa. Cook for about 1 minute, then flip.
8. Add a little oil, spreading it with the back of your spoon, and press gently around the edges with your spatula. Cook for 2 minutes.
9. Flip again, add oil to this side too, and cook for 1-2 more minutes, until golden-brown spots appear on both sides. Repeat with the second ball.

Money Hack: This roti is filling enough to eat with just a smear of butter or pickle, saving you the cost of making a separate side dish.

Swap It: No carom seeds? Cumin seeds or a pinch of dried fenugreek leaves work as substitutes.

COST BREAKDOWN

Atta/besan — ₹8, Onion/spices — ₹4, Oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹14.

Flavourful enough to skip the side dish entirely.

62. Stovetop Cheese Garlic Roti

No tandoor, no oven — just a roti, garlic butter, and a hot pan doing all the work.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹24 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One tawa **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Covering the pan while the cheese melts traps enough heat above to soften it while the pan crisps the base below — the same trick as the roti pizza.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or chapati (fresh, uncooked dough works best if you have it)
- 1 tsp butter
- 1 clove garlic, minced
- 1 tbsp grated cheese or 1 cheese slice, torn
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Peel and finely chop the garlic clove on a cutting board.
2. Put the butter in a small bowl. Add the chopped garlic and mix thoroughly with a spoon so it's evenly spread through, not sitting in one clump.
3. Warm the roti briefly in a dry pan, about 20 seconds per side, until soft and bendable.

4. Using a knife, spread the garlic butter generously over one side of the roti, right to the edges.
5. If using a cheese slice, tear it into small, even pieces with your hands rather than leaving it whole — smaller pieces melt faster. Scatter the cheese evenly over the buttered roti.
6. Cover the pan with a lid, and turn the flame to low.
7. Cook for about 1 minute, checking once — you're waiting for the cheese to fully melt and turn glossy, not just soften at the edges.
8. Turn off the stove, sprinkle coriander on top if using, and serve.

Money Hack: Buying garlic as a whole bulb and butter in a small block, rather than pre-made garlic butter, works out much cheaper across many recipes.

Swap It: No cheese? Garlic butter roti is still genuinely tasty on its own.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Butter/garlic — ₹6, Cheese — ₹8. Estimated total — ₹19.

Restaurant naan vibes, hostel-room budget.

63. Bread Uttapam

A thicker, pancake-style breakfast using torn bread instead of a fermented batter.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Soaking the bread fully and then squeezing out the water is what turns it into a sticky, mouldable mixture that holds its shape in the pan, rather than a loose, crumbly mess.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 slices bread, torn into small pieces and soaked briefly in water
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Tear the bread slices into small pieces with your hands and drop them into a bowl of water, pressing down gently so they're fully submerged.
2. Let them soak for about 30 seconds — just long enough to fully soften, not so long they start dissolving.
3. Lift the bread out with your hands and squeeze it firmly over the sink, pressing out as much water as you can.

4. Put the squeezed bread in a bowl. Using a fork, mash it until it forms a rough, sticky, combined mixture rather than distinct wet chunks.
5. Add the onion, tomato, a pinch of turmeric, and a pinch of salt. Mix thoroughly so everything is evenly distributed.
6. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
7. Spoon the bread mixture into the pan and spread it out with the back of your spoon into a flat, even disc about a centimetre thick.
8. Let it cook undisturbed for about 3 minutes — you're waiting for the underside to turn golden and firm enough to flip cleanly.
9. Slide a wide spatula underneath and flip it carefully.
10. Cook the second side for 2-3 minutes, then remove and serve.

Money Hack: This works particularly well with bread that's gone slightly stale, since it needs to be soaked anyway.

Swap It: No tomato? Grated carrot adds colour and a little sweetness instead.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹6, Vegetables — ₹4, Spices/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹13.

Bread having an identity crisis, in the best way.

64. Spiced Chana Roti Wrap

Leftover chana masala or plain boiled chickpeas, wrapped up for an easy, filling meal.



TIME: 8 min (with pre-cooked chana) **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan (optional) **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

If you've got leftover chana masala from another recipe in this book, this is the fastest, most satisfying way to give it a second life.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or chapati
- $\frac{3}{4}$ cup cooked, spiced chickpeas (leftover chana masala works great)
- $\frac{1}{4}$ onion, thinly sliced
- Squeeze of lemon

METHOD

1. If the chickpeas are cold from the fridge, warm them in a pan on medium heat for about 2 minutes, stirring occasionally, or microwave them for about 45 seconds.
2. Warm the roti too, either over a low flame for a few seconds per side, or in the same pan you used for the chickpeas.
3. Lay the warm roti flat on a plate. Spoon the warm chickpeas onto it, positioning them slightly toward one edge rather than dead centre.

4. Scatter the sliced onion over the chickpeas.
5. Cut a lemon in half and squeeze one half over the filling.
6. Fold the near edge of the roti over the filling first, then continue rolling the rest of the way, tucking in as you go so the filling stays contained.

Money Hack: This is the perfect next-day use for leftover chana masala from the Chana Masala Rice Bowl recipe — no extra cooking required.

Swap It: No leftover chana masala? Plain boiled chickpeas with a pinch of chaat masala works as a simpler filling.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Chickpeas (leftover) — ₹10, Onion/lemon — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹18.

Yesterday's dinner, today's lunch, zero extra effort.

65. Leftover Sabzi Roti Roll

The single best way to make sure last night's vegetable curry doesn't go to waste.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan (optional)
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Mashing a wet sabzi slightly before rolling gives you a thicker filling that holds together properly — a runny filling is the main reason rolls fall apart.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or chapati
- $\frac{3}{4}$ cup leftover sabzi (any vegetable curry), lightly mashed if it helps it roll better
- Squeeze of lemon (optional)

METHOD

1. Warm the leftover sabzi in a pan on medium heat for about 2 minutes, stirring occasionally, or in the microwave for about 45 seconds — you want it properly hot, not just lukewarm.
2. Look at the sabzi. If it looks particularly wet or saucy, mash it lightly with a fork for a few seconds to bring it together into a slightly thicker mixture.
3. Warm the roti separately, either over a low flame or in a dry pan, until soft and bendable.

4. Lay the roti flat. Spoon the sabzi onto it, positioned toward one edge.
5. If using lemon, cut it in half and squeeze one half over the filling.
6. Roll the roti tightly starting from the edge closest to the filling, tucking in as you go, and eat immediately while everything is warm.

Money Hack: This is exactly why it's worth cooking a slightly bigger batch of any vegetable curry — today's dinner becomes tomorrow's easy lunch.

Swap It: No leftover sabzi? A quick mash of boiled potato with any spices you have makes a reasonable stand-in filling.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Sabzi (leftover) — ₹8. Estimated total — ₹13.

This is what leftovers were always meant to become.

Egg-Based Meals



Eggs are one of the cheapest, fastest sources of protein you can buy, and they're endlessly flexible. Every method below tells you exactly what the egg should look like at each stage, so you can actually see and feel the doneness rather than guessing.

66. Boiled Egg Chaat

Boiled eggs, chopped up and tossed with a tangy, crunchy mix.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan (to boil) **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Chopping the boiled egg into rough, uneven pieces rather than neat slices helps it pick up seasoning far more effectively — the broken, textured surfaces catch the chaat masala and lemon.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs, boiled and peeled
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt
- Squeeze of lemon
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Place the eggs in a small pan and cover them with water. Put the pan on the stove and turn the flame to high.
2. Once the water is at a full, rolling boil (big bubbles everywhere), set a timer for 9 minutes.

3. When the timer ends, use a spoon to carefully lift the eggs out and drop them into a bowl of cold water. Leave them there for 2 minutes — this makes peeling much easier and stops the yolk from turning grey.
4. Peel each egg: tap it gently all over on a hard surface until the shell cracks in several places, then start peeling from the wider end, where there's often a small air gap you can get your thumbnail under.
5. Place the peeled eggs on a cutting board. Using a knife, chop them into rough, uneven chunks — not neat cubes, just cut across a few times in different directions.
6. Put the chopped egg into a bowl. Add the finely chopped onion and tomato.
7. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt over the top.
8. Cut a lemon in half and squeeze one half over the bowl.
9. Toss everything together very gently with a spoon — egg yolk crumbles easily, so don't stir hard. Top with coriander if using, and serve.

Money Hack: Boil a batch of 4-5 eggs at once — extras keep in the fridge for a few days and turn any meal into a quick protein boost.

Swap It: No chaat masala? A mix of salt, a pinch of cumin powder, and black pepper works as a substitute.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Vegetables — ₹4, Masala/lemon — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹20.

Simple, tangy, and gone faster than you'd expect.

67. Egg Bhurji Sandwich

Spiced scrambled egg, pressed between bread instead of rolled into a wrap.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹24 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooking the bhurji a little drier than usual — with less visible moisture in the pan — is what stops the bread from turning soggy within minutes of assembling.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 4 slices bread
- 1 tsp butter (optional, for toasting)

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
2. Cook for about 2 minutes, stirring occasionally, until soft.
3. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir for a few seconds.

4. Crack both eggs into the pan. Wait 5 seconds, then start breaking the yolks and folding everything together with your spoon.
5. Keep cooking and folding for about 1 minute 30 seconds — a bit longer than you'd cook bhurji to eat on its own — until the mixture looks dry and crumbly rather than glossy and wet. Any extra moisture here will make the sandwich soggy later.
6. Turn off the stove and let the bhurji cool for about 1 minute before the next step — spreading hot filling straight onto bread creates steam that makes it damp almost instantly.
7. Lay out 2 slices of bread. Using a spoon, spread the bhurji generously and evenly across both, right to the edges.
8. Place the other 2 slices on top to close the sandwiches.
9. If toasting: butter the outside of both slices, place in a pan on medium heat, and press down gently with your spatula. Cook for about 1 minute per side, until golden. If skipping toasting, just cut and eat.

Money Hack: This is a great way to turn one egg's worth of bhurji into a filling meal by padding it out with extra bread.

Swap It: No onion? A pinch of any dried herb mixed into the eggs still gives good flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Onion/spices — ₹3, Bread — ₹8. Estimated total — ₹25.

Handheld comfort food, no plate required.

68. Microwave Steamed Egg Bowl

Soft, custardy, savoury steamed egg — made entirely in the microwave.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Microwave **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Microwaving on reduced power cooks the egg far more gently than a hot pan — full power turns it rubbery and full of holes almost instantly, so the power level here matters more than anything else.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- ½ cup water or milk
- Pinch of salt
- A few drops of soy sauce or a pinch of pepper (optional)

METHOD

1. Crack both eggs into a microwave-safe bowl.
2. Add the water or milk and a pinch of salt.
3. Using a fork, beat everything together just until combined — don't whisk in a lot of air bubbles, which causes uneven cooking with holes later.
4. Set your microwave to medium power — around 50-60% if your microwave has

a power setting. This is the single most important step; skipping it and using full power will overcook parts of the egg before the rest even sets.

5. Microwave for 1 minute. Stop and open the door to check — the edges should look just barely set while the centre is still visibly liquid.
6. Close the door and microwave for another 30 seconds. Check again.
7. Keep repeating in 30-second bursts, checking each time, until the egg is mostly set but still looks a little wobbly and glossy in the very centre — it's better to slightly undercook here, since it keeps firming up from residual heat once you take it out.
8. Let it rest for 1 minute without touching it.
9. Drizzle with soy sauce or a pinch of pepper, and eat straight from the bowl.

Money Hack: Using milk instead of water gives a noticeably richer, smoother result for the same cost difference of a few rupees.

Swap It: No microwave-safe bowl? Any heatproof glass or ceramic bowl works, as long as it's microwave-safe.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Milk (optional) — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹16.

Soft, gentle, and possibly the easiest hot meal in this entire book.

69. Egg Curry with Bread

The same comforting egg curry, served with bread instead of rice for a change.



TIME: 18 min **COST:** ₹26 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Bread mops and scoops rather than absorbing the way rice does, so the gravy here is made a little thicker than usual so it clings to the bread instead of running off.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs, boiled and peeled
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- 4 slices bread

METHOD

1. If you haven't already, boil the eggs: cover with water in a small pan, bring to a boil on high heat, boil for 9 minutes, then transfer to cold water for 2 minutes and peel.
2. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.

3. Cook for about 4 minutes, stirring occasionally, until it turns deep golden-brown, not just soft.
4. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for 3–4 minutes, mashing gently with your spoon, until it fully breaks down into a soft, glossy mixture.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, garam masala, and salt. Stir for about 1 minute.
6. Add a small splash of water — noticeably less than you’d use if serving this over rice, since you want a thicker gravy this time that clings to bread rather than running off.
7. Let it simmer for 3–4 minutes, stirring occasionally, until it thickens slightly.
8. Using a knife, halve the boiled eggs lengthwise.
9. Nestle the egg halves into the gravy, cut-side up, and spoon a little sauce over the yolks. Warm through for about 1 minute without stirring vigorously.
10. Turn off the stove and serve with bread on the side, for mopping up the gravy.

Money Hack: This is a good way to use bread that isn’t quite fresh enough for a sandwich but is perfectly fine for mopping up gravy.

Swap It: No bread? Rice or even plain roti works just as well alongside this curry.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Vegetables/spices — ₹6, Bread — ₹6. Estimated total — ₹26.

Different base, same comfort.

70. Egg Aloo Bhurji

Scrambled egg and mashed potato cooked together — twice the filling power.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Mashed potato added to bhurji makes it noticeably creamier and heartier than the egg-only version, and it barely takes any extra time.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- 1 small potato, boiled and roughly mashed
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. If your boiled potato is still hot, let it cool for a few minutes before mashing — a very hot potato releases steam that can make the final bhurji slightly gluey.
2. Put the potato in a bowl. Using a fork, mash it, leaving some small lumps rather than mashing it completely smooth — those lumps add texture to the finished dish.

3. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
4. Cook for about 2 minutes, until soft.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir for a few seconds.
6. Add the mashed potato and mix it through, breaking it up as you stir so it combines evenly with the onion and spice rather than sitting in one dense clump.
7. Crack both eggs directly on top of the potato mixture.
8. Scramble everything together, folding continuously with your spoon, until the eggs are just cooked through and evenly mixed in — the whole thing should turn a uniform pale yellow, with no separate patches of plain potato and plain egg.
9. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: This recipe is a great way to use up a single leftover boiled potato that's not quite enough for a full dish on its own.

Swap It: No potato on hand? Regular egg bhurji works fine without it — just skip that step.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Potato — ₹4, Onion/spices — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹21.

Two humble ingredients, one very filling result.

71. Light Egg Drop Soup

Warm, brothy, and the closest this book gets to a hug in a bowl.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Pouring the beaten egg in slowly while stirring gently is what creates soft, feathery ribbons — pour it in all at once and you get a few large, rubbery clumps instead.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 egg, beaten
- 1.5 cups water
- ½ tsp cornflour (optional, for slight thickness) mixed with a little water
- Pinch of salt, pepper
- Chopped spring onion or coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Crack the egg into a small bowl or cup and beat it with a fork until smooth. Set aside.
2. Pour the water into a pan, put it on the stove, and turn the flame to medium-high. Bring it to a gentle boil, about 2-3 minutes.
3. Season with a pinch of salt and pepper.

4. If using cornflour: in a small cup, mix the cornflour with 1 tablespoon of cold water until fully dissolved with no lumps. Pour this into the simmering broth and stir. Let it simmer for 1 minute until it thickens very slightly and turns a bit glossy.
5. Turn the flame down to low, so the broth is at a gentle simmer, not a hard boil — a rolling boil will turn the egg into tough clumps almost instantly.
6. Hold the beaten egg a few inches above the pan. With one hand, drizzle it in very slowly in a thin, steady stream. At the same time, with your other hand, stir the broth gently in one consistent circular direction.
7. Keep this up for about 10–15 seconds until all the egg is in.
8. Turn off the stove the moment the egg looks just set — it happens fast, usually within seconds of finishing the pour.
9. Top with spring onion or coriander if using, and serve immediately.

Money Hack: This is an excellent way to use a single egg when you don't have enough for a full omelette or bhurji.

Swap It: No cornflour? Skip it — the soup will be thinner, but just as comforting.

COST BREAKDOWN

Egg — ₹7, Cornflour — ₹1, Seasoning — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹10.

This is what a bad day deserves to end with.

72. Spiced Curd Egg Mash

A cooling, protein-packed mash that works as a spread, a dip, or a meal on its own.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Kettle or one pan (to boil eggs) **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Mashing boiled egg into curd rather than mayonnaise gives you something lighter and tangier, closer to a raita than an egg salad.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs, boiled and peeled
- 3 tbsp curd
- Pinch of chaat masala, black pepper, salt
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Boil and peel the eggs the usual way: cover with water, boil for 9 minutes, cool in cold water for 2 minutes, then peel.
2. Let the eggs sit for another minute or two so they're not too hot to handle comfortably.
3. Place the eggs in a bowl. Using a fork, mash them roughly — press down and turn the fork to break them up, leaving a coarse, uneven texture with visible bits

of yolk and white, not a completely smooth paste.

4. Add the curd and mix thoroughly, folding it through the mashed egg with a spoon until evenly combined.
5. Sprinkle in a pinch of chaat masala, a pinch of pepper, and a pinch of salt.
6. Mix again, then taste a small spoonful — curd varies in tanginess, so adjust the seasoning if needed.
7. Top with coriander if using, and serve with bread, roti, or crackers, or eat straight with a spoon.

Money Hack: This is a great way to use eggs that were boiled a day or two ago and are sitting in the fridge waiting for a purpose.

Swap It: No curd? Mashed avocado or a little mayonnaise works if you have either, though the flavour will be quite different.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Curd — ₹4, Masala — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹19.

Cool, tangy, and quietly one of the more versatile things in this book.

73. Butter Masala Fried Egg

A sunny-side-up egg, dressed up with butter and a proper spice mix.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Sprinkling the spices on while the egg is still cooking, rather than after, lets them partially cook into the surface instead of just sitting loose on top.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- 1 tsp butter
- Pinch of red chilli powder, chaat masala, salt

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add the butter, and turn the flame to medium.
2. Wait for the butter to fully melt and just start to foam slightly at the edges — this takes about 30–45 seconds and is a good sign the pan is at the right temperature.
3. Crack the first egg gently into the pan, trying to keep the yolk whole and centred. Crack the second egg in beside it, leaving a little space so the whites don't run into each other too much.
4. While the whites are still mostly see-through and just starting to turn opaque

at the edges (this happens quickly, within about 20 seconds), sprinkle the chilli powder, chaat masala, and salt evenly over the top.

5. Let the eggs cook without touching them. Watch the whites — you're waiting for them to turn fully opaque and set all the way through, while the yolk still looks glossy and slightly soft when you gently shake the pan. This takes about 2-3 minutes.
6. If you prefer a firmer yolk, let it cook 1 more minute, checking every 20 seconds since it can go from soft to fully hard quite quickly at this stage.
7. Turn off the stove and slide the eggs out onto a plate.

Money Hack: Butter makes a noticeable difference here over oil, but a mix of half butter, half oil stretches your butter further without losing much flavour.

Swap It: No chaat masala? A simple mix of salt and black pepper still makes a great fried egg.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Butter/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹18.

Same egg you've always made, dressed up like it means something.

74. Egg and Spinach Scramble

A quick way to sneak some greens into an otherwise simple egg dish.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Spinach releases a lot of water as it cooks, which is why it needs to fully wilt down before the eggs go in — otherwise that moisture leaks into the eggs and leaves you with a watery scramble.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- 1 cup spinach leaves, roughly chopped
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of salt, pepper
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Wash the spinach leaves under running water, then roughly chop them on a cutting board.
2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.

3. Cook for about 2 minutes, until soft.
4. Add the chopped spinach — it will look like a lot at first, filling the pan right up, but don't worry, it shrinks dramatically as it cooks.
5. Stir frequently for about 2 minutes, until it's fully wilted down to roughly a quarter of its original size, with no dry leaves left standing.
6. Look at the pan — if there's a noticeable pool of liquid, let it cook for another 30 seconds to reduce slightly.
7. Crack both eggs directly on top of the wilted spinach. Add a pinch of salt and pepper.
8. Scramble everything together with a folding motion, cooking until the eggs are just set and no longer glossy — the spinach should be spread evenly through as green flecks, not sitting in a separate layer.
9. Turn off the stove and serve immediately.

Money Hack: Spinach is one of the cheaper leafy greens available seasonally — buy a bunch and use half here, half in another recipe within a day or two.

Swap It: No spinach? Any other leafy green you have access to works with the same method.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggs — ₹14, Spinach — ₹4, Onion/spices — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹20.

Green, filling, and still ready in ten minutes.

75. Egg-Coated Paratha (Anda Paratha)

A plain paratha or roti, dipped in beaten egg and pan-fried until golden.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One tawa or pan
LEVEL: Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Pressing the roti into the beaten egg and holding it there for a moment lets the surface actually soak up a thin layer, so the egg cooks into a genuine golden crust instead of sliding off.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or plain paratha (leftover or freshly made)
- 1 egg
- Pinch of salt, pepper, chilli flakes
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Crack the egg into a shallow bowl or plate — wide enough that the roti can lie flat in it.
2. Add a pinch of salt, pepper, and chilli flakes. Beat with a fork until smooth.
3. Lay the roti into the beaten egg. Press down gently with your fingers and hold for a few seconds so the surface soaks up some of the egg, rather than the egg

just sitting on top.

4. Flip the roti over in the egg and repeat on the other side.
5. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds until it looks hot and shimmery.
6. Carefully place the egg-coated roti into the pan.
7. Don't move it for the first minute — this undisturbed time is what lets a proper golden crust form instead of a patchy, torn one.
8. After about 2 minutes, check underneath with your spatula — it should look set and golden at the edges. Flip carefully.
9. Cook the second side for another 2 minutes, until evenly golden and the egg is fully cooked through with no runny patches visible at the edges.
10. Slide it onto a plate, cut into strips if you like, and serve.

Money Hack: This is an excellent way to turn a single leftover roti into a much more substantial, protein-rich meal.

Swap It: No leftover roti? Bread works with the same method, though the texture will be a little different.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Egg — ₹7, Oil/spices — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹15.

A leftover roti's glow-up moment.

Vegetarian Comfort Food

Purely vegetarian, genuinely comforting, and built around ingredients that don't ask much of your budget or your energy. These are slightly slower than the ultra-quick recipes elsewhere in this book, but every step is still broken down small, so nothing is left to guesswork.

76. Paneer Bhurji

Paneer's answer to egg bhurji — scrambled, spiced, and just as fast.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹28 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Paneer doesn't scramble the way eggs do — it just crumbles and soaks up whatever it's cooked in, so giving it enough time in the pan with the spices is what makes it taste properly seasoned rather than bland.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g paneer, crumbled by hand
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Take the paneer block in your hands over a plate or the pan itself. Break it apart with your fingers into small, irregular crumbles — no need for a knife, this is actually faster and gives a better texture than cutting.
2. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion and chilli, if using.
3. Cook for about 2 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the onion turns soft and just see-through at the edges.
4. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for about 2 minutes, mashing gently with your spoon, until it softens and turns a little saucy.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir for a few seconds.
6. Add the crumbled paneer. Mix it through thoroughly so it's coated in the onion-tomato mixture.
7. Let it cook for 2–3 minutes, stirring occasionally — this resting time in the pan is what lets the paneer properly soak up the flavour instead of just sitting there coated on the outside.
8. Turn off the stove and serve hot.

Money Hack: Crumble the paneer with your hands rather than a knife — it creates a more authentic bhurji texture and saves you dirtying a cutting board.

Swap It: No paneer? Crumbled tofu (if available) works with a similar method and texture.

COST BREAKDOWN

Paneer — ₹16, Vegetables — ₹5, Spices/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹24.

Same comfort as egg bhurji, completely vegetarian.

77. Aloo Matar with Roti

Potato and peas in a simple, spiced gravy — an absolute classic for good reason.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A properly browned onion and a fully broken-down tomato are what give a simple curry its depth — rushing through those two steps is the most common reason a home version tastes thinner than you remember.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 medium potatoes, boiled and cubed
- ½ cup peas (fresh or frozen)
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- Roti, to serve

METHOD

1. If your potatoes aren't boiled yet, put them whole in a pot of water, bring to a boil, and cook for about 15–20 minutes until a knife slides in easily. Drain, cool slightly, peel, and cut into cubes.

2. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the chopped onion.
3. Cook, stirring occasionally, for about 4 minutes — you want a proper golden-brown colour here, not just soft, so be patient.
4. Add the chopped tomato. Cook for 3–4 minutes, mashing it gently against the pan with your spoon, until it completely collapses into a soft, jammy texture — you'll see a little oil separate at the edges when it's ready.
5. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, garam masala, and salt. Stir for about 1 minute.
6. Add the boiled potato cubes and the peas, along with a splash of water — enough to loosen everything into a gravy, not a dry sauté.
7. Let it simmer for 5–8 minutes, stirring occasionally. Partway through, press a potato cube or two gently against the pan with your spoon — this releases a little starch and thickens the gravy naturally.
8. The peas are done once they're tender but still bright green, not dull and overcooked. Turn off the stove and serve hot with roti.

Money Hack: Boiling potatoes in bulk once and using them across several recipes during the week saves both time and gas or electricity.

Swap It: No fresh peas? Frozen peas work identically and don't need any extra prep.

COST BREAKDOWN

Potatoes — ₹6, Peas — ₹6, Vegetables/spices — ₹5, Roti — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹22.

This is the dish that makes a rented room feel a little more like home.

78. Simple Palak Dal

Spinach cooked into dal — an easy way to get greens into a meal you were already going to make.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Adding the spinach only in the last few minutes keeps it bright green and fresh-tasting — add it too early and it turns dull and overcooked.

INGREDIENTS

- ¼ cup toor or moong dal
- 1 cup spinach leaves, roughly chopped
- ¼ onion, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, cumin seeds, salt
- 1 tsp oil or ghee
- 2 cups water

METHOD

1. Rinse the dal in a bowl: fill with water, swirl, pour off the cloudy water while holding the dal back, repeat once or twice.
2. Put the rinsed dal into a pot, add the 2 cups of water and a pinch of turmeric.
3. Put the pot on the stove and turn the flame to high. Bring it to a boil, about 3 minutes.

4. Turn the flame down to a simmer. Cook for about 12 minutes, mashing gently with the back of your spoon every few minutes, until it breaks down into a thick, soupy consistency.
5. While the dal simmers, wash and roughly chop the spinach on a cutting board.
6. In the last 3–4 minutes of the dal’s cooking time, stir the chopped spinach directly into the pot and let it wilt in the hot dal — don’t add it any earlier than this.
7. While that finishes, make the tempering: heat the oil in a small separate pan on medium heat, add the cumin seeds, and wait about 10 seconds for them to sizzle.
8. Add the chopped onion to the tempering pan and cook for about 2 minutes until golden.
9. Pour the hot tempering directly into the pot of dal — it will sizzle loudly on contact, which is exactly right.
10. Add salt to taste, stir once, and serve with rice or roti.

Money Hack: This is a good way to use spinach that’s starting to wilt — it’s going into a simmering dal anyway, so texture matters less.

Swap It: No spinach? Any other leafy green, or even grated bottle gourd, works with the same method.

COST BREAKDOWN

Dal — ₹6, Spinach — ₹4, Onion/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

Greens, protein, and comfort, all in one pot.

79. Mild Coconut Vegetable Stew

A gentle, lightly sweet stew inspired by South Indian coconut-based curries.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹26 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Coconut milk can split or turn grainy if boiled too hard, so keeping the heat gentle once it goes in is what gives you that smooth, comforting texture.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup mixed vegetables (potato, carrot, beans, peas — whatever you have)
- ¼ onion, chopped
- ½ cup coconut milk (or 2 tbsp desiccated coconut blended with ½ cup water)
- Pinch of black pepper, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- A few curry leaves (optional)

METHOD

1. On a cutting board, chop the vegetables you're using into roughly bite-sized, similar-sized pieces.
2. Put a pot on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium.
3. If using curry leaves, add them now and let them crackle for a few seconds.
4. Add the chopped onion. Cook for about 2 minutes, until soft.

5. Add the mixed vegetables and cook for 2 minutes, stirring to coat them lightly in the oil.
6. Pour in the coconut milk, adding a splash of water too if the mixture looks thick.
7. Turn the flame down to low, so it's at a very gentle simmer — small, slow bubbles, not a rolling boil, since coconut milk can separate under too much heat.
8. Cook uncovered for 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, keeping the heat low the entire time.
9. Check doneness by piercing the largest piece of vegetable (usually potato or carrot) with a fork — it should slide in easily with no resistance.
10. Season with pepper and salt, tasting a small spoonful before adding more, since coconut milk's natural sweetness affects how much salt you'll want. Turn off the stove and serve.

Money Hack: Small tetra packs of coconut milk are more economical than buying a fresh coconut for one recipe, and they keep in the fridge for a few days once opened.

Swap It: No coconut milk at all? A splash of milk with a pinch of sugar approximates some of the richness, though the flavour will be different.

COST BREAKDOWN

Vegetables — ₹10, Coconut milk — ₹12, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹26.

Gentle, mild, and a nice break from the usual spice level.

80. Smoky Mashed Eggplant (Baingan Bharta Shortcut)

A stovetop shortcut for the classic smoky roasted eggplant mash.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Covering the pan while the eggplant cooks traps steam that softens it much faster than cooking it uncovered — you won't get quite the same smokiness as an open-flame roast, but the texture gets close.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 medium eggplant (baingan), cut into chunks
- ¼ onion, ½ tomato, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, salt
- 1 tsp oil
- Chopped coriander (optional)

METHOD

1. Wash the eggplant and cut it into rough chunks on a cutting board, about the size of large dice.
2. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium-low. Add the eggplant chunks.

3. Cover immediately with a lid — the trapped steam softens the eggplant much faster than leaving it uncovered.
4. Cook for 10–12 minutes, stirring every few minutes (put the lid back on each time after stirring). You're waiting for the eggplant to become completely soft and almost fall apart when pressed with your spoon.
5. Once soft, mash it roughly right in the pan using the back of your spoon, leaving some texture rather than mashing it into a completely smooth purée.
6. Push the mashed eggplant to one side of the pan. Add a touch more oil if the pan looks dry, and add the chopped onion to the empty space.
7. Cook the onion for about 2 minutes, until soft, then add the tomato and cook for 2–3 minutes until it breaks down.
8. Mix the mashed eggplant back into the onion-tomato base. Add a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt.
9. Cook for 3–4 more minutes, stirring occasionally, until everything is well combined and heated through.
10. Turn off the stove, top with coriander if using, and serve.

Money Hack: Eggplant is often one of the cheaper seasonal vegetables — buy it when it's in season for the best price.

Swap It: No eggplant? Mashed, roasted or boiled potato with the same onion-tomato base makes a different but still tasty dish.

COST BREAKDOWN

Eggplant — ₹8, Vegetables/spices — ₹6, Oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹16.

Smoky, soft, and a lot more impressive than the ten-minute prep suggests.

81. Besan Curd Kadhi

A tangy, warming besan-and-curd curry, best eaten with rice.



TIME: 20 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pot **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Kadhi splits or turns lumpy when the curd and besan aren't whisked completely smooth before any heat is involved — getting that step right first avoids the problem entirely.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup curd, whisked smooth
- 2 tbsp besan (gram flour)
- Pinch of turmeric, salt
- Pinch of mustard seeds, cumin seeds
- 1 tsp oil
- 1.5 cups water

METHOD

1. Put the curd and besan together in a bowl — no water yet. Whisk them together thoroughly with a fork or whisk until completely smooth, with no lumps of besan anywhere. This is much easier to do now than after water's been added.

2. Gradually whisk in the water, a little at a time, along with a pinch of turmeric and salt, until you have a completely smooth, thin mixture.
3. Pour this into a pot and place it on the stove on medium heat.
4. Stir frequently and continuously as it heats up — this constant stirring in the early stages is what prevents the curd from splitting.
5. Once it reaches a gentle boil (small bubbles across the surface), turn the flame down to low.
6. Let it simmer for 10–12 minutes, stirring every minute or so, until it thickens slightly to a consistency similar to a thin gravy.
7. While it simmers, make the tempering: heat the oil in a small separate pan on medium heat, add the mustard and cumin seeds, and let them pop for about 10 seconds.
8. Pour this tempering over the finished kadhi just before serving, and serve with rice.

Money Hack: Slightly sour curd (a day or two past its best) actually works better in kadhi than very fresh curd — it gives a proper tang.

Swap It: No mustard seeds for the tempering? Just cumin seeds in the oil still gives good flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Curd — ₹10, Besan — ₹4, Spices/oil — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹18.

Tangy, warm, and a nice change of pace from the usual curries.

82. Everyday Mixed Vegetable Sabzi

A simple, dry-style vegetable curry that goes with anything — rice, roti, or even bread.



TIME: 18 min **COST:** ₹20 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cutting all the vegetables to a similar size is what matters most here — evenly sized pieces cook at the same rate, so you don't end up with raw potato next to mushy cauliflower.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups mixed vegetables (potato, beans, carrot, cauliflower — whatever's available), chopped
- ¼ onion, chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, cumin seeds, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. On a cutting board, chop all your vegetables into roughly the same size pieces, about bite-sized — this matters more than which specific vegetables you use.
2. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Add the cumin seeds.
3. Wait about 10 seconds for them to sizzle, then add the chopped onion.

4. Cook for about 2 minutes, until soft.
5. Add all the mixed vegetables, a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, and salt. Stir well so everything gets an even coating of spice.
6. Cover with a lid and turn the flame down to low-medium.
7. Cook for 12-15 minutes, stirring every 3-4 minutes (putting the lid back on each time) to check on progress and prevent sticking.
8. If it looks like it's starting to catch on the bottom of the pan, add a small splash of water.
9. Test doneness by pushing a fork into the largest, hardest piece — usually potato or carrot. It's done once the fork slides in with no resistance.
10. Turn off the stove and serve.

Money Hack: This is the perfect recipe for using up small amounts of several different vegetables that aren't enough on their own for a full dish.

Swap It: No specific vegetables? Literally any combination works — this recipe is built around flexibility, not a fixed ingredient list.

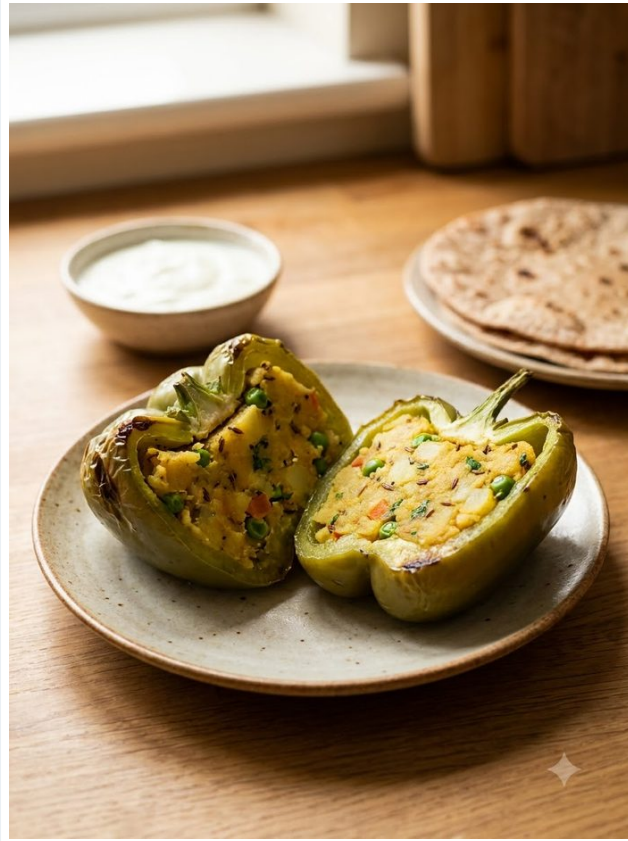
COST BREAKDOWN

Vegetables — ₹12, Onion/spices — ₹4, Oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹18.

Not exciting. Just reliably, quietly good.

83. Simple Stuffed Capsicum

Bell peppers filled with spiced mashed potato — looks impressive, isn't hard at all.



TIME: 25 min **COST:** ₹24 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Cooking the stuffed capsicum cut-side up, covered, lets it steam gently from the inside while the bottom slowly chars against the pan — a properly cooked pepper without needing an oven at all.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 capsicums (bell peppers), halved and deseeded
- 2 medium potatoes, boiled and mashed
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of turmeric, red chilli powder, garam masala, salt
- 1 tsp oil

METHOD

1. Wash the capsicums. Using a knife, cut each one in half through the stem, top to bottom.
2. Using a spoon, carefully scoop out the seeds and white membrane from inside each half, trying not to tear the flesh — a torn capsicum won't hold its filling well.

3. Put the mashed potato in a bowl. Add the chopped onion, a pinch of turmeric, chilli powder, garam masala, and salt. Mix thoroughly with a spoon until evenly combined.
4. Spoon this mixture into each capsicum half, pressing it down gently with the back of your spoon so it's compact and doesn't have large air gaps. Mound it slightly above the rim if you have extra filling.
5. Put a pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to low-medium.
6. Arrange the stuffed capsicums in the pan, cut-side facing up.
7. Cover immediately with a lid — the trapped steam is what cooks the capsicum through without needing to flip it, which would spill the filling.
8. Cook for 12-15 minutes without lifting the lid too often.
9. Check doneness by gently pressing a capsicum with a fork — it should yield easily rather than feeling firm and raw. If you peek underneath one, you should see light charring on the base.
10. Turn off the stove and serve.

Money Hack: This is a great way to use up potatoes you've already boiled for another recipe — no extra cooking step needed for the filling base.

Swap It: No capsicum? The same spiced potato filling works well wrapped in a roti instead.

COST BREAKDOWN

Capsicum — ₹10, Potatoes — ₹6, Onion/spices — ₹5, Oil — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹23.

Looks like you tried much harder than you did. Keep that between us.

Budget Snacks & Late-Night Hunger



Late-night hunger doesn't care about your assignment deadline, your exam tomorrow, or the fact that the kitchen is technically closed. Every step below is broken down small enough that you can follow it half-asleep.

84. Spiced Roasted Makhana

Fox nuts, roasted with a bit of spice, until they turn into an oddly addictive crunchy snack.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Low, steady heat slowly drives the moisture out of makhana until it turns light and crackly — rushing this with high heat just browns the outside while the inside stays soft.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup makhana (fox nuts)
- 1 tsp ghee or oil
- Pinch of red chilli powder, chaat masala, salt

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add the ghee, and turn the flame to low-medium — resist turning it up higher, since makhana needs gentle, even heat to crisp all the way through.
2. Wait about 20 seconds for the ghee to melt.
3. Add the makhana, spreading it out in as close to a single layer as your pan allows.
4. Stir frequently — every 20-30 seconds — for 5-6 minutes.

5. To test if it's done: take one piece out, let it cool for a few seconds, then tap it against the side of the pan or bite it gently. It should sound and feel hollow and light, and crisp when you bite it — not soft or chewy. If it still feels chewy, keep roasting in 1-minute bursts, testing each time.
6. Once properly crisp, turn off the stove. While the makhana is still warm, sprinkle over the chilli powder, chaat masala, and salt.
7. Toss immediately so the residual heat and light oiliness help the spices stick to every piece.

Money Hack: Makhana can be pricier per packet than other snacks, but a single cup goes a long way and keeps well in an airtight container for future late nights.

Swap It: No chaat masala? Plain salt and pepper still makes a satisfying version.

COST BREAKDOWN

Makhana — ₹10, Ghee/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

Crunchy enough to make you forget you're supposed to be sleeping.

85. Stovetop Masala Popcorn

No microwave popcorn packets needed — just a pan, some kernels, and a bit of patience.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹10 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan with lid
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Managing the heat evenly is the whole technique here — too low and the kernels won't build enough pressure to pop; too high and you'll scorch the ones that have already popped.

INGREDIENTS

- ¼ cup popcorn kernels
- 1 tsp oil
- Pinch of salt, chilli powder, or chaat masala

METHOD

1. Put your pan (one with a lid) on the stove, add the oil, and turn the flame to medium.
2. Add just 2 or 3 kernels first and wait, with the lid off, watching them — when they pop, that's your sign the oil and pan are at the right temperature.
3. Add the rest of the kernels in as close to a single layer as you can, then immediately cover with the lid.

4. Every 15–20 seconds, pick up the pan by the handle and shake it gently side to side over the heat, without lifting the lid — this helps unpopped kernels get even contact with the hot surface and stops popped ones from burning.
5. Listen closely to the popping sound. Once it slows down from rapid, constant popping to a gap of 2–3 seconds between pops, remove the pan from the heat right away — don't wait for complete silence, or you risk scorching the last few kernels.
6. Take the lid off carefully (steam will escape) and pour the popcorn into a bowl.
7. While it's still warm, sprinkle with salt and your chosen spice, and toss well so the seasoning sticks to the slightly oily surface.

Money Hack: A bag of loose popcorn kernels is far cheaper per serving than any packaged or microwave popcorn — and lasts for many, many late nights.

Swap It: No specific seasoning? Even plain salted popcorn is a perfectly good late-night snack.

COST BREAKDOWN

Popcorn kernels — ₹4, Oil/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹8.

Cheaper than a movie ticket snack, and you don't even have to leave your room.

86. Jhaal Muri (Spiced Puffed Rice)

A Kolkata street-food classic — puffed rice tossed with a punchy, tangy mix.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Puffed rice is extremely absorbent, so this needs to be tossed and eaten right away — left sitting even ten minutes, it soaks up moisture from the vegetables and turns soft.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups puffed rice (muri)
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- 1 green chilli, chopped (optional)
- A few peanuts (optional)
- Pinch of chaat masala, salt
- 1 tsp mustard oil (or any oil) and a squeeze of lemon

METHOD

1. Before touching the puffed rice, get everything else ready first: finely chop the onion, tomato, and chilli, and have your peanuts, masala, oil, and a cut lemon within reach.

2. Put the puffed rice into a large bowl — choose one with enough room that you can toss without it spilling over the sides.
3. Add the chopped onion, tomato, chilli, and peanuts.
4. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of salt evenly over the top.
5. Drizzle the mustard oil over everything.
6. Squeeze the lemon over the bowl too.
7. Toss immediately and thoroughly, lifting the mixture from the bottom and turning it over rather than stirring flat, so the dressing reaches every piece.
8. Eat right away — this is a “make it and eat it in the same minute” recipe, since the crisp texture is the entire point.

Money Hack: Puffed rice is sold very cheaply in bulk — it’s one of the most cost-effective snack bases available anywhere in India.

Swap It: No mustard oil? Regular oil with an extra squeeze of lemon gets you close to the same sharp flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Puffed rice — ₹6, Vegetables/peanuts — ₹5, Masala/oil — ₹3. Estimated total — ₹14.

Loud, tangy, crunchy — exactly what late-night hunger is asking for.

87. Dry Roasted Masala Chickpeas

A crunchy, spiced snack made from chickpeas you’ve already boiled.



TIME: 10 min (with pre-boiled chana) **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Drying the chickpeas thoroughly before they hit the pan is the single biggest factor in whether they crisp or stay soft — any leftover surface moisture just steams them instead of roasting them.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup boiled chickpeas, well drained and patted dry
- 1 tsp oil
- Pinch of red chilli powder, chaat masala, salt

METHOD

1. Drain the chickpeas thoroughly in a sieve.
2. Spread them out on a clean kitchen towel or a few sheets of paper towel. Pat them dry, gently rolling and pressing so the towel absorbs moisture from all sides — don't skip this, it's what determines whether you get crisp chickpeas or steamed ones.

3. Put your pan on the stove, add 1 teaspoon of oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds until it looks hot and shimmery.
4. Add the dried chickpeas.
5. Roast, stirring frequently so they cook evenly on all sides rather than just the bottom, for 6–8 minutes.
6. Watch for the colour to deepen slightly and small cracks or blisters to appear on some of the skins — both are signs they're crisping properly.
7. Turn off the stove. While still hot, sprinkle with chilli powder, chaat masala, and salt.
8. Toss immediately so the seasoning sticks to the warm, slightly oily surface.

Money Hack: Making sure the chickpeas are well drained and dry before roasting helps them crisp up properly instead of steaming in the pan.

Swap It: No boiled chickpeas ready? Canned chickpeas, drained and dried with a paper towel, work just as well.

COST BREAKDOWN

Chickpeas — ₹10, Oil/spices — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

A snack that's actually doing you a favour, for once.

88. Quick Onion Pakora

Crispy, spiced onion fritters — the ultimate rainy-evening snack.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Salted onion releases its own water, which is what binds this batter together — trust that process instead of pouring in extra water too early, or the mixture gets too wet to shape.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 onion, thinly sliced
- ½ cup besan (gram flour)
- Pinch of red chilli powder, carom seeds (ajwain), salt
- A little water
- 2 tsp oil, for pan-frying

METHOD

1. Peel the onion and slice it thinly on a cutting board.
2. Put the sliced onion in a bowl. Add the besan, chilli powder, carom seeds, and a pinch of salt.
3. Mix everything together with your hands for about 30 seconds — you're working the salt into the onion, which starts drawing out moisture.

4. Let the mixture sit for 1–2 minutes. You'll notice it becoming slightly wetter and clumpier on its own as the onion releases water.
5. Check the texture: if it's still too dry and crumbly to hold together when you squeeze a bit in your hand, add just a small splash of water — not a lot, add a teaspoon at a time.
6. Put your pan on the stove, add the oil, and turn the flame to medium. Wait 30 seconds for it to heat.
7. Using a spoon, scoop up a small portion of the mixture and drop it into the pan, then flatten it slightly with the back of the spoon so it cooks through evenly rather than staying raw in the centre.
8. Repeat with the rest of the mixture, leaving space between each one.
9. Fry for about 3 minutes, then check the underside by lifting one edge with your spatula — you want a deep golden-brown colour with visibly crisp edges before flipping.
10. Flip each one and fry the second side for another 3 minutes, checking the same way. Remove and serve hot.

Money Hack: Shallow-frying in a pan instead of deep-frying uses far less oil while still getting a good crisp texture.

Swap It: No carom seeds? Cumin seeds work as a substitute, though the flavour will be slightly different.

COST BREAKDOWN

Onion — ₹3, Besan — ₹6, Oil/spices — ₹6. Estimated total — ₹15.

Rain outside, crispy pakoras inside — perfect trade.

89. Midnight Cheese Toast Melt

For the exam-night hunger that specifically wants something warm, cheesy, and immediate.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹22 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Low heat and a little patience lets the cheese melt through fully by the time the bread turns golden — high heat browns the outside long before the inside has warmed at all.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices bread
- 1 cheese slice (or a small handful of grated cheese)
- Pinch of chilli flakes or oregano
- 1 tsp butter

METHOD

1. Using a butter knife, spread butter on one side of each bread slice, covering right to the edges.
2. Place the cheese slice between the two pieces of bread, with the buttered sides facing outward on both.
3. Put a dry pan on the stove and turn the flame to low-medium — genuinely lower

than feels natural, since this needs time for the heat to reach the cheese in the middle.

4. Place the sandwich into the pan.
5. Press down gently and evenly with your spatula for a few seconds — this good contact helps the heat transfer through faster.
6. Let it cook for about 2 minutes. Check the underside by lifting an edge — you want a deep, even golden-brown, which usually means the cheese inside is at least halfway melted.
7. Flip the sandwich over and press down again with your spatula.
8. Cook the second side for another 2 minutes, until equally golden.
9. Remove from the pan, sprinkle with chilli flakes or oregano, and cut in half. Let it cool for about 30 seconds before biting — the cheese inside will be very hot.

Money Hack: Keep a few cheese slices in the fridge specifically for nights like this — they last for weeks and are worth the small investment for exam season alone.

Swap It: No cheese? A thick layer of butter and a sprinkle of chaat masala makes a different but still comforting version.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹4, Cheese — ₹8, Butter/spices — ₹5. Estimated total — ₹17.

Studying can wait four minutes. Eat this first.

90. Crispy Masala Papad Nachos

Broken roasted papad, topped like nachos — crunchy, spicy, oddly satisfying.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan (to roast papad)
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A properly roasted papad puffs and crisps evenly and shatters cleanly when you bite it — exactly the textural contrast you want against the soft onion and tomato on top.

INGREDIENTS

- 2–3 papads
- ¼ onion, ¼ tomato, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala
- Squeeze of lemon
- A dollop of curd (optional)

METHOD

1. If roasting over an open flame: hold the papad with tongs about an inch above the flame. Keep it moving constantly, turning and rotating it so every part gets even exposure. This takes about 10–15 seconds total — you're watching for it to puff up slightly and darken evenly.
2. If using a dry pan instead: put it on medium heat, place the papad in, and press

down firmly and evenly with a spatula, flipping every few seconds so it doesn't scorch in one spot before the rest crisps.

3. Once evenly roasted (it should snap cleanly when you bend it, not bend softly), break it into large, irregular pieces with your hands and arrange them on a plate.
4. Scatter the chopped onion and tomato over the top, spreading it evenly so every piece of papad gets some topping.
5. Sprinkle with chaat masala.
6. Cut a lemon in half and squeeze one half over everything.
7. If using curd, add a small dollop now, positioned so it doesn't touch every piece at once and make everything soggy immediately.
8. Serve right away, while the papad is still crisp.

Money Hack: Papads are one of the cheapest crunchy snacks available and store for months unopened — always worth keeping a packet around.

Swap It: No curd? Skip it — the papad and toppings are still satisfying without it.

COST BREAKDOWN

Papad — ₹6, Vegetables — ₹4, Masala/curd — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹14.

Nacho night, minus the nachos, minus most of the cost.

91. Banana Chips Masala Chaat

Store-bought banana chips, given a quick chaat-style upgrade.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Squeezing the lemon on right before eating, not any earlier, is what keeps the chips crunchy — the acidity starts softening them almost immediately once it touches them.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup banana chips (store-bought)
- ¼ onion, finely chopped
- Pinch of chaat masala, red chilli powder
- Squeeze of lemon

METHOD

1. Put the banana chips into a bowl, choosing one with enough room to toss them gently without crushing too many.
2. Finely chop the onion on a cutting board and add it to the bowl.
3. Sprinkle a pinch of chaat masala and a pinch of chilli powder over the top.
4. Cut the lemon in half. Right before you're ready to eat — not any earlier — squeeze one half over the bowl.

5. Toss gently and quickly, using a folding motion so the seasoning spreads without breaking too many chips.
6. Eat immediately, while the crunch is still at its best.

Money Hack: Buy banana chips loose from a local shop rather than a branded packet — usually a better price for the same amount.

Swap It: No onion? The chaat masala and lemon alone still transform plain banana chips into something more interesting.

COST BREAKDOWN

Banana chips — ₹12, Onion/masala — ₹3, Lemon — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹15.

A packet snack that now tastes like you put in some effort.

Sweet/Cheap Comfort Recipes

Sometimes you don't need a meal. You need something sweet, warm, and a little bit indulgent, without spending money you don't have. Every method step here is broken down small, so even if you've never made dessert before, you'll know exactly what to do.

92. Bread Halwa

A quick, sweet pudding made from bread, milk, and sugar — dessert with almost no shopping list.



TIME: 12 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Toasting the bread briefly in ghee before the milk goes in firms up the surface just enough that it absorbs the milk gradually, instead of instantly turning to mush.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 slices bread, torn into small pieces

- 1 tsp ghee
- 1 cup milk
- 2 tbsp sugar
- Pinch of cardamom powder, a few chopped nuts (optional)

METHOD

1. Tear the bread slices into small pieces with your hands.
2. Put your pan on the stove, add the ghee, and turn the flame to medium. Wait about 20 seconds for it to melt.
3. Add the torn bread pieces. Toss and stir for about 2 minutes, until they turn a shade golden and feel slightly firmer when you press one with your spoon.
4. Add the milk and sugar. Stir well to combine.
5. Turn the flame down to medium-low. Cook, stirring frequently — about every 30 seconds — for 5–6 minutes.
6. Watch the texture: the bread will gradually soften and swell as it absorbs the milk, and the mixture will thicken from loose and liquid to something that holds together when you drag your spoon through it.
7. Once thick and most of the milk is absorbed, stir in the cardamom powder. Cook for 30 more seconds.
8. Turn off the stove. Top with chopped nuts if using, and serve warm.

Money Hack: This is an excellent way to use bread that's a little stale — it soaks up the milk better than fresh bread.

Swap It: No milk? Water with an extra spoon of sugar works, though it won't be as rich or creamy.

COST BREAKDOWN

Bread — ₹6, Milk — ₹6, Sugar/ghee — ₹4. Estimated total — ₹16.

Warm, sweet, and ready before you've even decided you deserve dessert.

93. Simple Suji Halwa

The classic semolina halwa — soft, ghee-rich, and endlessly comforting.



TIME: 15 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Roasting the semolina thoroughly before any liquid touches it is what gives the finished halwa its nutty depth of flavour, instead of tasting like plain sweetened porridge.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup sooji (semolina)
- 2 tbsp ghee
- ⅓ cup sugar
- 1.5 cups water
- Pinch of cardamom powder, a few nuts or raisins (optional)

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add the ghee, and turn the flame to medium-low.
2. Once the ghee has melted (about 20 seconds), add the sooji.
3. Stir constantly and continuously — don't walk away, since sooji can go from perfectly roasted to burnt within seconds if left unattended.
4. Keep stirring for 4-5 minutes, until the sooji turns a light golden colour and smells noticeably toasty and nutty, rather than raw and starchy.

5. While the sooji roasts, heat the water and sugar together in a separate small pan or kettle until the sugar fully dissolves — having this ready means you're not scrambling to boil water the moment the sooji finishes.
6. With your sooji pan still on low heat, pour the hot sugar-water in very slowly, stirring vigorously and continuously as you pour — it will bubble and spit on contact, so pour from a slight distance and keep stirring the whole time to prevent lumps.
7. Once all the liquid is in, keep stirring over low heat for 2–3 minutes. Watch for the mixture to thicken and start pulling away from the sides of the pan slightly — that pulling-away is your clearest sign it's ready.
8. Stir in the cardamom and nuts or raisins if using.
9. Turn off the stove and serve warm.

Money Hack: Sooji and sugar are both cheap pantry staples — this dessert costs very little for how satisfying and generous a portion it makes.

Swap It: No cardamom? A drop of vanilla essence, if you have it, gives a different but pleasant flavour.

COST BREAKDOWN

Sooji — ₹5, Sugar — ₹4, Ghee — ₹6, Nuts (optional) — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹16.

This is what "everything's going to be fine" tastes like.

94. Microwave Chocolate Banana Mug Cake

A genuine mug cake, made in the microwave, with no oven and minimal cleanup.



TIME: 6 min **COST:** ₹18 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Microwave **LEVEL:** Easy

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Microwave cakes cook from the outside in, quite differently from oven-baked cakes, which is why checking early rather than assuming the full time is needed matters so much here.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 small banana, mashed well
- 3 tbsp atta or plain flour
- 1 tbsp cocoa powder (if available) or 1 extra tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 2 tbsp milk
- A tiny pinch of baking soda (optional, for a softer texture)

METHOD

1. Peel the banana and put it directly into a large mug.
2. Using a fork, mash it against the side of the mug until mostly smooth, with just a few small lumps left.

3. Add the flour, cocoa powder (if using), sugar, milk, and baking soda (if using) into the same mug.
4. Stir with the fork just until you can't see any dry flour anymore — about 15–20 stirs. Stop as soon as it looks combined; overmixing makes the finished cake denser.
5. Place the mug in the microwave. Set it to high power and microwave for 90 seconds.
6. Stop and check — don't assume it needs longer without looking. Insert a knife or fork into the centre and pull it out.
7. If it comes out mostly clean, with maybe a few moist crumbs but no wet batter, it's done. If it's still wet, microwave in 15-second bursts, checking each time — mug cakes go from underdone to overcooked very quickly.
8. Let it cool for 1 minute before eating directly from the mug — it keeps cooking slightly from residual heat even after you take it out.

Money Hack: No cocoa powder? Skip it entirely rather than buying it just for this — a plain banana mug cake is still genuinely good.

Swap It: No baking soda? The cake will be slightly denser, but still perfectly enjoyable.

COST BREAKDOWN

Banana — ₹6, Flour/sugar — ₹5, Cocoa (optional) — ₹5, Milk — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹13 (₹18 with cocoa).

A genuine treat, ready faster than you could've ordered dessert.

95. Sweet Lassi

A thick, cold, sweetened yoghurt drink — refreshing and filling at the same time.



TIME: 5 min **COST:** ₹14 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

A proper minute of brisk whisking is what introduces air and fully breaks down the curd, giving you that classic thick, slightly frothy texture — a half-hearted stir leaves it thin and watery.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup curd
- ¼ cup cold water or milk
- 2 tsp sugar (adjust to taste)
- Pinch of cardamom powder (optional)

METHOD

1. Put the curd into a bowl or large glass first, before adding anything else.
2. Using a fork or small whisk, whisk it vigorously for about 30 seconds — moving fast, breaking up any lumps completely, until the curd looks smooth and slightly glossy.
3. Add the cold water or milk gradually, a little at a time, continuing to whisk briskly

after each addition — this is what introduces the light frothiness lassi is known for, rather than just diluting the curd into a flat liquid.

4. Add the sugar and cardamom, if using.
5. Whisk once more, for about 15 seconds, until the sugar is fully dissolved — no gritty texture left.
6. Taste a small sip and check the sweetness, adding a touch more sugar if you'd like.
7. If you have ice, add it now, right before drinking, rather than earlier — adding it too soon dilutes the lassi while you're still whisking.
8. Pour into a glass and drink cold.

Money Hack: Making lassi with slightly thick, full-fat curd (if that's what's available) gives a richer result without needing to add anything extra.

Swap It: No cardamom? A few drops of rose water, if you have it, gives a different but pleasant flavour twist.

COST BREAKDOWN

Curd — ₹12, Sugar — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹14.

Cold, sweet, and thick enough to almost count as lunch.

96. No-Cook Peanut Jaggery Bites

Small, chewy energy bites made from just peanuts and jaggery — no cooking required.



TIME: 10 min **COST:** ₹16 **SERVES:** 4 bites **EQUIPMENT:** No cooking needed
LEVEL: Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

These hold together purely from the warmth and pressure of your hands working the jaggery until it becomes slightly sticky — no heat, no syrup, just hand warmth doing all the work.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup roasted peanuts, roughly crushed
- ¼ cup jaggery, very finely grated or crushed
- A tiny pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Put the peanuts on a cutting board or in your palm. Crush them roughly using the flat side of a knife, the back of a spoon, or by pressing your palms together with the peanuts in between — you want a mix of small pieces and some finer crumb, not a completely uniform powder.
2. If your jaggery is in a hard block, grate it using a grater, or crush it into small bits with the back of a spoon — the finer this is, the more evenly it will bind with

the peanuts later.

3. Put the crushed peanuts, jaggery, and a tiny pinch of salt into a bowl.
4. Mix with your hands for about 30 seconds — the warmth from your palms will start softening the jaggery slightly as you work it through the peanuts, and you'll feel the mixture start to hold together a little.
5. Take a small portion of the mixture — about a tablespoon — and press it firmly between your palms, rolling it into a compact ball. Apply real pressure here; it's that pressing and the warmth of your hands that binds everything together.
6. Repeat with the rest of the mixture, making 4 similar-sized bites.
7. Place the bites on a plate and let them sit for a few minutes to firm up slightly before eating.

Money Hack: Make a slightly bigger batch and store in an airtight container — these keep for several days without needing refrigeration.

Swap It: Jaggery too hard to grate? Warm it very briefly (a few seconds) in the microwave to soften it before mixing.

COST BREAKDOWN

Peanuts — ₹8, Jaggery — ₹6, Salt — negligible. Estimated total — ₹14.

Two ingredients, genuinely no cooking, still tastes like you tried.

Emergency “Almost Nothing Left” Meals

Some nights, it’s genuinely down to this — a few days before money comes in, the pantry is nearly bare, and you need something, anything, that counts as a meal. Even with almost nothing to work with, every step below is still spelled out clearly.

97. Butter Salt Rice

Rice, butter or ghee, and salt. That’s genuinely the whole recipe.



TIME: 5 min (with pre-cooked rice) **COST:** ₹8 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** Microwave or one pan (to warm rice) **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU’LL LOVE IT

Stirring the butter into the rice while it’s still properly hot — not just warm — is what melts it completely and coats every grain, instead of leaving unmelted lumps sitting on top.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice

- 1 tsp butter or ghee
- Salt to taste
- Pinch of black pepper (optional, if you have it)

METHOD

1. Put the rice into a microwave-safe bowl, or into a pan if warming on the stove.
2. If using a microwave: heat on high for about 1 minute, then stir once, then heat for another 30 seconds if it's not fully hot yet. If using a pan: put it on the stove on medium heat, add a small splash of water, and stir occasionally for about 2 minutes until steaming hot.
3. Check that the rice is properly hot all the way through, not just warm on the outside — if using a microwave, feel the middle of the bowl after stirring to make sure there are no cold spots.
4. While it's still steaming hot, add the butter or ghee directly on top.
5. Stir immediately — the residual heat should melt it within a few seconds as you mix it through.
6. Add salt, tasting a small spoonful as you go, since salt is doing most of the flavour work here. Add pepper if using.
7. Give it one final stir to make sure everything is evenly mixed, then eat.

Money Hack: Always keep a small block of butter or ghee in your room specifically for nights like this — it's the single ingredient that turns "just rice" into a real meal.

Swap It: No butter or ghee? A teaspoon of oil and a little extra salt still makes this edible and warm, if less rich.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice (already cooked) — ₹6, Butter — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹8.

This still counts as dinner. No judgement here.

98. Sugar Roti

A roti with ghee and sugar — the emergency comfort food that tastes like being a kid again.



TIME: 5 min (with pre-made roti) **COST:** ₹6 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan (to warm roti) **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Making sure the roti is genuinely warm, not just at room temperature, lets the ghee melt in slightly rather than sitting as a cold, waxy layer on top.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 roti or chapati
- 1 tsp ghee
- 1 tsp sugar

METHOD

1. Put a dry pan on the stove and turn the flame to medium, or hold the roti directly over a low open flame using tongs.
2. Warm the roti for about 10 seconds on one side, then flip and warm the other side for 10 seconds too — you want it soft and slightly bendable, not stiff or cold.
3. Lay the warm roti flat on a plate.
4. Using a spoon, scoop the ghee and spread it evenly over one side while the roti is still warm — the warmth helps it melt in slightly rather than sitting as a solid

layer.

5. Sprinkle the sugar evenly over the ghee, making sure it reaches right to the edges so every bite gets some sweetness.
6. Fold the roti in half, then in half again if you'd like it more compact, or roll it up from one side.
7. Eat immediately while it's still warm — the sugar's crunch and the ghee's softness are both at their best right away.

Money Hack: This recipe needs almost nothing, but if you have even one more ingredient — a banana, some peanuts — chopping it in makes it feel like an upgrade.

Swap It: No ghee? Butter works exactly the same way here.

COST BREAKDOWN

Roti — ₹5, Ghee/sugar — ₹1. Estimated total — ₹6.

Someone probably made you this exact thing when you were small. It still works.

99. Jeera Water Rice

Plain rice, lifted by nothing more than a simple cumin tempering — the true last-resort meal.



TIME: 8 min **COST:** ₹8 **SERVES:** 1 **EQUIPMENT:** One pan **LEVEL:** Beginner

WHY YOU'LL LOVE IT

Letting the cumin seeds actually sizzle and turn a shade darker in the hot oil, rather than tossing them in with everything else at once, releases far more aroma than raw cumin ever could.

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 cups cooked rice
- 1 tsp oil or ghee
- Pinch of cumin seeds
- Salt to taste

METHOD

1. Put your pan on the stove, add the oil, and turn the flame to medium.
2. Wait about 30 seconds until the oil looks hot — you can test this by flicking one drop of water into the pan; if it sizzles immediately, it's ready.
3. Add the cumin seeds.

4. Wait for them to sizzle and turn a shade darker — this takes about 10–15 seconds, and it's the entire flavour base of the dish, so don't rush past it.
5. Add the cooked rice straight away, right after the cumin is ready.
6. Toss everything together well with your spoon, making sure the tempered oil coats every part of the rice rather than staying pooled at the bottom of the pan.
7. Add salt, tasting a small spoonful as you go.
8. Give it one final toss and eat — straight from the pan if that's genuinely all the energy you have tonight.

Money Hack: Keep a small jar of cumin seeds specifically as an emergency flavour booster — it costs very little and turns almost any plain starch into something with intention behind it.

Swap It: No cumin seeds? A pinch of any spice you have — even just black pepper — is better than nothing.

COST BREAKDOWN

Rice (already cooked) — ₹6, Oil/cumin — ₹2. Estimated total — ₹8.

You made something out of almost nothing. That's not a small thing tonight.

10 Meals for the Last Week of the Month

You know this week. The one where you're doing quiet math before every purchase, and "cheap" needs to mean genuinely, seriously cheap. These ten recipes are the least expensive in the entire book — most of them under ₹15.

1. **#98 Sugar Roti** — ~₹6
2. **#29 Chai and Rusk (The Classic Combo)** — ~₹8
3. **#97 Butter Salt Rice** — ~₹8
4. **#99 Jeera Water Rice** — ~₹8
5. **#59 Crispy Roti Chips with Chutney** — ~₹10
6. **#85 Stovetop Masala Popcorn** — ~₹10
7. **#5 Butter Masala Toast** — ~₹12
8. **#11 Roasted Peanut Chaat** — ~₹12
9. **#14 Garlic Butter Toast** — ~₹14
10. **#20 Besan Chilla** — ~₹14

This isn't a punishment list. Several of these — the chilla especially — are genuinely good food that just happens to also be nearly free.

10 Recipes for When You're Too Tired to Cook

Some days, “cooking” is one step too many. These recipes need no real heat, no real technique, and barely any standing up.

1. **#2 Peanut Butter Banana Toast** — no cooking needed
2. **#3 Curd Rice in a Bowl** — no cooking needed
3. **#8 Curd, Banana & Honey Bowl** — no cooking needed
4. **#11 Roasted Peanut Chaat** — no cooking needed
5. **#13 Boiled Chana Chaat** — no cooking needed (with pre-boiled chana)
6. **#21 Overnight Oats** — prep the night before, zero effort in the morning
7. **#27 Cold Veg Sandwich with Mint Chutney** — no cooking needed
8. **#30 Curd and Flattened Rice Bowl (Dahi Poha)** — no cooking needed
9. **#91 Banana Chips Masala Chaat** — no cooking needed
10. **#95 Sweet Lassi** — no cooking needed

10 Filling Meals Under ₹30

For when you want something that feels like an actual meal — not a snack — but still comfortably light on the wallet.

1. **#41 Simple Vegetable Pulao** — ~₹26
2. **#42 Egg Fried Rice** — ~₹20
3. **#44 One-Pot Tomato Rice** — ~₹20
4. **#45 Comfort Khichdi** — ~₹15
5. **#50 Curry Leaf & Peanut Rice** — ~₹14
6. **#54 Simple Dal-Chawal** — ~₹18
7. **#63 Bread Uttapam** — ~₹13
8. **#70 Egg Aloo Bhurji** — ~₹21
9. **#77 Aloo Matar with Roti** — ~₹22
10. **#78 Simple Palak Dal** — ~₹14

10 Midnight Hunger Fixes

Late-night hunger doesn't negotiate. These are quiet-kitchen-friendly, quick, and won't leave you with a pile of dishes at 1am.

1. **#26 Quick Bread Pakora**
2. **#35 Cheesy Maggi (Small Splurge Version)**
3. **#84 Spiced Roasted Makhana**
4. **#85 Stovetop Masala Popcorn**
5. **#86 Jhaal Muri (Spiced Puffed Rice)**
6. **#87 Dry Roasted Masala Chickpeas**
7. **#88 Quick Onion Pakora**
8. **#89 Midnight Cheese Toast Melt**
9. **#90 Crispy Masala Papad Nachos**
10. **#91 Banana Chips Masala Chaat**

5 Recipes for When You Miss Home

Some nights aren't about hunger at all — they're about missing a kitchen that isn't yours anymore. These five lean hardest into comfort.

1. **#45 Comfort Khichdi** — the dish every Indian household makes when someone needs looking after.
2. **#54 Simple Dal-Chawal** — rice and dal, the most basic and most reliable combination there is.
3. **#77 Aloo Matar with Roti** — a genuine Indian-household classic, cooked in one pan.
4. **#93 Simple Suji Halwa** — warm, ghee-rich, and the smell alone does half the work.
5. **#98 Sugar Roti** — the exact thing someone probably made you as a child. It still works.

Weekly Food Planner

Copy this table into a notebook or a notes app, and fill it in at the start of each week. Having even a rough plan reduces the number of “what do I even eat” moments — and makes it much easier to shop for exactly what you need.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Snack	Estimated Daily Cost
Mon					
Tue					
Wed					
Thu					
Fri					
Sat					
Sun					

You don’t need to fill in every box every week — even planning three or four meals in advance saves you from the expensive, tired decision to just order something.

Weekly Budget Planning Examples

These are illustrative examples only — they show how the recipes in this book can be combined into a full week, at three different budget levels. They are not a promise that your own week will cost exactly this; your actual numbers will depend on your city, your shop, and what's already in your pantry.

₹500 A WEEK

At this level, the plan leans heavily on the cheapest recipes in the book, reuses ingredients aggressively, and keeps snacks minimal.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	#29 Chai and Rusk	#97 Butter Salt Rice	#45 Comfort Khichdi
Tue	#3 Curd Rice	#54 Dal-Chawal	#78 Simple Palak Dal + roti
Wed	#20 Besan Chilla	#44 Tomato Rice	#99 Jeera Water Rice
Thu	#29 Chai and Rusk	#45 Comfort Khichdi	#82 Mixed Vegetable Sabzi + roti
Fri	#7 Five-Minute Poha	#54 Dal-Chawal	#41 Vegetable Pulao
Sat	#20 Besan Chilla	#77 Aloo Matar + roti	#45 Comfort Khichdi
Sun	#93 Simple Suji Halwa	#44 Tomato Rice	#78 Simple Palak Dal + roti

This week stays vegetarian throughout and relies on rice, dal, and roti as the backbone — the cheapest, most stretchable combination in the whole book.

₹1,000 A WEEK

This budget allows a bit more variety, an egg most days, and the occasional small snack.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	#19 Masala Omelette with Toast	#42 Egg Fried Rice	#45 Comfort Khichdi

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Tue	#17 Sooji Uttapam	#77 Aloo Matar with Roti	#52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl
Wed	#4 Loaded Masala Maggi	#54 Dal-Chawal	#41 Vegetable Pulao
Thu	#26 Quick Bread Pakora	#48 Chana Masala Rice Bowl	#70 Egg Aloo Bhurji
Fri	#7 Five-Minute Poha	#42 Egg Fried Rice	#76 Paneer Bhurji + roti
Sat	#20 Besan Chilla	#47 Quick Rajma Rice	#45 Comfort Khichdi
Sun	#15 Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits	#77 Aloo Matar with Roti	#52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl

₹1,500 A WEEK

At this level, there's room for paneer a couple of times, more snacks, and a proper dessert on the weekend.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	#19 Masala Omelette with Toast	#51 Budget Paneer Pulao	#48 Chana Masala Rice Bowl
Tue	#18 Eggless Banana Pancakes	#42 Egg Fried Rice	#76 Paneer Bhurji + roti
Wed	#17 Sooji Uttapam	#47 Quick Rajma Rice	#41 Vegetable Pulao
Thu	#4 Loaded Masala Maggi	#52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl	#79 Mild Coconut Vegetable Stew
Fri	#26 Quick Bread Pakora	#51 Budget Paneer Pulao	#70 Egg Aloo Bhurji
Sat	#35 Cheesy Maggi	#83 Simple Stuffed Capsicum	#52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl + #94 Chocolate Banana Mug Cake
Sun	#15 Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits	#47 Quick Rajma Rice	#76 Paneer Bhurji + roti + #93 Simple Suji Halwa

Use these three examples as a starting shape, not a fixed rulebook — swap in whatever

recipes from the book match your own taste and whatever's cheapest in your local market that week.

Recipe Indexes

By Cooking Time

10 minutes or less (64 recipes)

#1 Bread Omelette Roll-Up, #2 Peanut Butter Banana Toast, #3 Curd Rice in a Bowl, #4 Loaded Masala Maggi, #5 Butter Masala Toast, #6 Quick Egg Bhurji Mash, #7 Five-Minute Poha, #8 Curd, Banana & Honey Bowl, #9 Bread Upma, #10 Tomato-Onion Chutney Sandwich, #11 Roasted Peanut Chaat, #12 Jaggery Oats Bowl, #13 Boiled Chana Chaat, #14 Garlic Butter Toast, #15 Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits, #18 Eggless Banana Pancakes, #19 Loaded Masala Omelette with Toast, #20 Besan Chilla, #21 Overnight Oats (Prep Tonight, Eat Tomorrow), #22 Sprouted Moong Breakfast Bowl, #23 Egg Bhurji Roti Wrap, #24 Vermicelli Upma (Semiya), #26 Quick Bread Pakora, #27 Cold Veg Sandwich with Mint Chutney, #29 Chai and Rusk (The Classic Combo), #30 Curd and Flattened Rice Bowl (Dahi Poha), #31 Dry Garlic Butter Maggi, #32 Maggi Frittata (Noodle Omelette), #33 Peanut Maggi (Dry, Crunchy Twist), #34 Maggi Bhel, #35 Cheesy Maggi (Small Splurge Version), #36 Maggi Soup Bowl, #37 Maggi Fried Rice Style, #38 Tomato Masala Noodles (No Tastemaker), #39 Maggi Upgrade Bowl with Boiled Egg, #40 Chilli Garlic Noodle Bowl, #56 Roti Pizza, #59 Crispy Roti Chips with Chutney, #60 Curd Roti Wrap, #63 Bread Uttapam, #64 Spiced Chana Roti Wrap, #65 Leftover Sabzi Roti Roll, #66 Boiled Egg Chaat, #67 Egg Bhurji Sandwich, #68 Microwave Steamed Egg Bowl, #71 Light Egg Drop Soup, #72 Spiced Curd Egg Mash, #73 Butter Masala Fried Egg, #74 Egg and Spinach Scramble, #75 Egg-Coated Paratha (Anda Paratha), #76 Paneer Bhurji, #84 Spiced Roasted Makhana, #85 Stovetop Masala Popcorn, #86 Jhaal Muri (Spiced Puffed Rice), #87 Dry Roasted Masala Chickpeas, #89 Midnight Cheese Toast Melt, #90 Crispy Masala Papad Nachos, #91 Banana Chips Masala Chaat, #94 Microwave Chocolate Banana Mug Cake, #95 Sweet Lassi, #96 No-Cook Peanut Jaggery Bites, #97 Butter Salt Rice, #98 Sugar Roti, #99 Jeera Water Rice

11-20 minutes (32 recipes)

#16 Mashed Potato Stuffed Roti, #17 Sooji Uttapam, #25 Milk Dalia (Broken Wheat Porridge), #28 Moong Dal Chilla, #41 Simple Vegetable Pulao, #42 Egg Fried Rice, #43 South Indian Lemon Rice, #44 One-Pot Tomato Rice, #46 Simple Peas Pulao, #47 Quick Rajma Rice, #48 Chana Masala Rice Bowl, #49 Budget Schezwan Fried Rice, #50 Curry Leaf & Peanut Rice, #51 Budget Paneer Pulao, #52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl, #53 Masala Rice with Roasted Papad, #55 Carrot & Coconut Rice, #57 Vegetable Roti Roll, #58 Sweet Coconut Stuffed Roti, #61 Simple Missi Roti, #62 Stovetop Cheese Garlic Roti, #69 Egg Curry with Bread, #70 Egg Aloo Bhurji, #77 Aloo Matar with Roti, #78 Simple Palak Dal, #79 Mild Coconut Vegetable Stew, #80 Smoky Mashed Eggplant (Baingan Bharta Shortcut), #81 Besan Curd Kadhi, #82 Everyday Mixed

Vegetable Sabzi, #88 Quick Onion Pakora, #92 Bread Halwa, #93 Simple Suji Halwa

Over 20 minutes (3 recipes)

#45 Comfort Khichdi, #54 Simple Dal-Chawal, #83 Simple Stuffed Capsicum

By Approximate Cost

Under ₹15 (28 recipes)

#3 Curd Rice in a Bowl, #5 Butter Masala Toast, #7 Five-Minute Poha, #11 Roasted Peanut Chaat, #12 Jaggery Oats Bowl, #14 Garlic Butter Toast, #20 Besan Chilla, #22 Sprouted Moong Breakfast Bowl, #24 Vermicelli Upma (Semiya), #25 Milk Dalia (Broken Wheat Porridge), #28 Moong Dal Chilla, #29 Chai and Rusk (The Classic Combo), #53 Masala Rice with Roasted Papad, #59 Crispy Roti Chips with Chutney, #61 Simple Missi Roti, #65 Leftover Sabzi Roti Roll, #68 Microwave Steamed Egg Bowl, #71 Light Egg Drop Soup, #73 Butter Masala Fried Egg, #84 Spiced Roasted Makhana, #85 Stovetop Masala Popcorn, #86 Jhaal Muri (Spiced Puffed Rice), #87 Dry Roasted Masala Chickpeas, #90 Crispy Masala Papad Nachos, #95 Sweet Lassi, #97 Butter Salt Rice, #98 Sugar Roti, #99 Jeera Water Rice

₹16-₹30 (69 recipes)

#1 Bread Omelette Roll-Up, #2 Peanut Butter Banana Toast, #4 Loaded Masala Maggi, #6 Quick Egg Bhurji Mash, #8 Curd, Banana & Honey Bowl, #9 Bread Upma, #10 Tomato-Onion Chutney Sandwich, #13 Boiled Chana Chaat, #15 Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits, #16 Mashed Potato Stuffed Roti, #17 Sooji Uttapam, #18 Eggless Banana Pancakes, #19 Loaded Masala Omelette with Toast, #21 Overnight Oats (Prep Tonight, Eat Tomorrow), #23 Egg Bhurji Roti Wrap, #26 Quick Bread Pakora, #27 Cold Veg Sandwich with Mint Chutney, #30 Curd and Flattened Rice Bowl (Dahi Poha), #31 Dry Garlic Butter Maggi, #32 Maggi Frittata (Noodle Omelette), #33 Peanut Maggi (Dry, Crunchy Twist), #34 Maggi Bhel, #36 Maggi Soup Bowl, #37 Maggi Fried Rice Style, #38 Tomato Masala Noodles (No Tastemaker), #39 Maggi Upgrade Bowl with Boiled Egg, #40 Chilli Garlic Noodle Bowl, #41 Simple Vegetable Pulao, #42 Egg Fried Rice, #43 South Indian Lemon Rice, #44 One-Pot Tomato Rice, #45 Comfort Khichdi, #46 Simple Peas Pulao, #47 Quick Rajma Rice, #48 Chana Masala Rice Bowl, #49 Budget Schezwan Fried Rice, #50 Curry Leaf & Peanut Rice, #52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl, #54 Simple Dal-Chawal, #55 Carrot & Coconut Rice, #56 Roti Pizza, #57 Vegetable Roti Roll, #58 Sweet Coconut Stuffed Roti, #60 Curd Roti Wrap, #62 Stovetop Cheese Garlic Roti, #63 Bread Uttapam, #64 Spiced Chana Roti Wrap, #66 Boiled Egg Chaat, #67 Egg Bhurji Sandwich, #69 Egg Curry with Bread, #70 Egg Aloo Bhurji, #72 Spiced Curd Egg Mash, #74 Egg and Spinach Scramble, #75 Egg-Coated Paratha (Anda Paratha), #76 Paneer Bhurji, #77 Aloo Matar with Roti, #78 Simple Palak Dal, #79 Mild Coconut Vegetable Stew, #80 Smoky

Mashed Eggplant (Baingan Bharta Shortcut), #81 Besan Curd Kadhi, #82 Everyday Mixed Vegetable Sabzi, #83 Simple Stuffed Capsicum, #88 Quick Onion Pakora, #89 Midnight Cheese Toast Melt, #91 Banana Chips Masala Chaat, #92 Bread Halwa, #93 Simple Suji Halwa, #94 Microwave Chocolate Banana Mug Cake, #96 No-Cook Peanut Jaggery Bites

Over ₹30 (2 recipes)

#35 Cheesy Maggi (Small Splurge Version), #51 Budget Paneer Pulao

By Equipment

No cooking needed (13 recipes)

#2 Peanut Butter Banana Toast, #3 Curd Rice in a Bowl, #8 Curd, Banana & Honey Bowl, #11 Roasted Peanut Chaat, #13 Boiled Chana Chaat, #21 Overnight Oats (Prep Tonight, Eat Tomorrow), #22 Sprouted Moong Breakfast Bowl, #27 Cold Veg Sandwich with Mint Chutney, #30 Curd and Flattened Rice Bowl (Dahi Poha), #86 Jhaal Muri (Spiced Puffed Rice), #91 Banana Chips Masala Chaat, #95 Sweet Lassi, #96 No-Cook Peanut Jaggery Bites

One pan (69 recipes)

#1 Bread Omelette Roll-Up, #4 Loaded Masala Maggi, #5 Butter Masala Toast, #6 Quick Egg Bhurji Mash, #7 Five-Minute Poha, #9 Bread Upma, #10 Tomato-Onion Chutney Sandwich, #12 Jaggery Oats Bowl, #14 Garlic Butter Toast, #15 Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits, #17 Sooji Uttapam, #18 Eggless Banana Pancakes, #19 Loaded Masala Omelette with Toast, #20 Besan Chilla, #23 Egg Bhurji Roti Wrap, #24 Vermicelli Upma (Semiya), #25 Milk Dalia (Broken Wheat Porridge), #26 Quick Bread Pakora, #28 Moong Dal Chilla, #29 Chai and Rusk (The Classic Combo), #31 Dry Garlic Butter Maggi, #32 Maggi Frittata (Noodle Omelette), #33 Peanut Maggi (Dry, Crunchy Twist), #35 Cheesy Maggi (Small Splurge Version), #36 Maggi Soup Bowl, #37 Maggi Fried Rice Style, #38 Tomato Masala Noodles (No Tastemaker), #39 Maggi Upgrade Bowl with Boiled Egg, #40 Chilli Garlic Noodle Bowl, #42 Egg Fried Rice, #43 South Indian Lemon Rice, #47 Quick Rajma Rice, #48 Chana Masala Rice Bowl, #49 Budget Schetzwan Fried Rice, #50 Curry Leaf & Peanut Rice, #52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl, #53 Masala Rice with Roasted Papad, #55 Carrot & Coconut Rice, #56 Roti Pizza, #57 Vegetable Roti Roll, #59 Crispy Roti Chips with Chutney, #60 Curd Roti Wrap, #63 Bread Uttapam, #64 Spiced Chana Roti Wrap, #65 Leftover Sabzi Roti Roll, #66 Boiled Egg Chaat, #67 Egg Bhurji Sandwich, #69 Egg Curry with Bread, #70 Egg Aloo Bhurji, #71 Light Egg Drop Soup, #72 Spiced Curd Egg Mash, #73 Butter Masala Fried Egg, #74 Egg and Spinach Scramble, #76 Paneer Bhurji, #77 Aloo Matar with Roti, #80 Smoky Mashed Eggplant (Baingan Bharta Shortcut), #82 Everyday Mixed Vegetable Sabzi, #83 Simple Stuffed Capsicum, #84

Spiced Roasted Makhana, #85 Stovetop Masala Popcorn, #87 Dry Roasted Masala Chickpeas, #88 Quick Onion Pakora, #89 Midnight Cheese Toast Melt, #90 Crispy Masala Papad Nachos, #92 Bread Halwa, #93 Simple Suji Halwa, #97 Butter Salt Rice, #98 Sugar Roti, #99 Jeera Water Rice

One pot (9 recipes)

#41 Simple Vegetable Pulao, #44 One-Pot Tomato Rice, #45 Comfort Khichdi, #46 Simple Peas Pulao, #51 Budget Paneer Pulao, #54 Simple Dal-Chawal, #78 Simple Palak Dal, #79 Mild Coconut Vegetable Stew, #81 Besan Curd Kadhi

Microwave (3 recipes)

#68 Microwave Steamed Egg Bowl, #94 Microwave Chocolate Banana Mug Cake, #97 Butter Salt Rice

Kettle (9 recipes)

#4 Loaded Masala Maggi, #12 Jaggery Oats Bowl, #15 Hot Masala Milk with Biscuits, #29 Chai and Rusk (The Classic Combo), #34 Maggi Bhel, #36 Maggi Soup Bowl, #39 Maggi Upgrade Bowl with Boiled Egg, #66 Boiled Egg Chaat, #72 Spiced Curd Egg Mash

Tawa (7 recipes)

#5 Butter Masala Toast, #14 Garlic Butter Toast, #16 Mashed Potato Stuffed Roti, #58 Sweet Coconut Stuffed Roti, #61 Simple Missi Roti, #62 Stovetop Cheese Garlic Roti, #75 Egg-Coated Paratha (Anda Paratha)

Vegetarian Recipes

(79 recipes — every recipe in this book not listed under Egg Recipes below)

Egg Recipes

(20 recipes)

#1 Bread Omelette Roll-Up, #4 Loaded Masala Maggi, #6 Quick Egg Bhurji Mash, #19 Loaded Masala Omelette with Toast, #23 Egg Bhurji Roti Wrap, #32 Maggi Frittata (Noodle Omelette), #37 Maggi Fried Rice Style, #39 Maggi Upgrade Bowl with Boiled Egg, #42 Egg Fried Rice, #52 Egg Curry Rice Bowl, #66 Boiled Egg Chaat, #67 Egg Bhurji Sandwich, #68 Microwave Steamed Egg Bowl, #69 Egg Curry with Bread, #70 Egg Aloo Bhurji, #71 Light Egg Drop Soup, #72 Spiced Curd Egg Mash, #73 Butter Masala Fried Egg, #74 Egg and Spinach Scramble, #75 Egg-Coated Paratha (Anda Paratha)

Late-Night Recipes

(All recipes from the Budget Snacks & Late-Night Hunger chapter, plus a few other quiet, quick options)

#26 Quick Bread Pakora, #35 Cheesy Maggi, #84 Spiced Roasted Makhana, #85 Stovetop Masala Popcorn, #86 Jhaal Muri, #87 Dry Roasted Masala Chickpeas, #88 Quick Onion Pakora, #89 Midnight Cheese Toast Melt, #90 Crispy Masala Papad Nachos, #91 Banana Chips Masala Chaat

“Almost Nothing Left” Recipes

#97 Butter Salt Rice, #98 Sugar Roti, #99 Jeera Water Rice

Final Quality-Control Summary

Check	Result
Total recipes	99
Recipes at or under the ₹99 target	99
Recipes under ₹50	99
Recipes under 15 minutes	82
Vegetarian recipes	79
Egg recipes	20
One-pot / one-pan recipes	78
No-cook / very-low-equipment recipes	13

Every recipe in this book was checked for a complete set of ingredients with quantities, clear numbered steps, an equipment tag, a time estimate, and a cost breakdown that adds up correctly. No recipe requires special equipment beyond a basic induction plate or burner, a kettle, a microwave, or a single pan or pot.